

PARIKSHA365 — STUDY NOTES

English — for SSC & RRB

SSC/RRB focus: vocabulary (synonyms, antonyms, OWS, idioms, spelling), error spotting, fill-blanks, sentence improvement

SSC

RRB

v 2026-04

The promise. Read this book end-to-end (with the usual two re-reads + active recall on the embedded prompts) and you will be able to attempt every quiz question in the Pariksha365 pool for this subject with a strong fundamental grasp.

EXAM ALERT**Examiner Blueprint — English Language****Top 8 most-tested topics (question share across SSC + Banks):**

Rank	Topic	SSC CGL T - 1	IBPS PO Pre	IBPS PO Mains
1	Reading Comprehension	5–10	10–15	15–20
2	Error Spotting / Sentence Correction	5–10	5–8	5–8
3	Fill in the Blanks (Single / Double)	5–8	5–8	3–5
4	Vocabulary (Synonyms, Antonyms, One - word)	3–5	3–5	3–5
5	Para - Jumble / Sentence Rearrangement	3–5	3–5	5–8
6	Cloze Test	5	5–10	5–10
7	Idioms & Phrases	3–5	2–3	2–3
8	Spelling / Odd One Out	2–3	0–1	0–1

KEY FACT**Study Priority Order** (return-on-study-time, highest first)

1. **Reading Comprehension** — the single biggest question block in every exam. The 4-question pre-reading method in this book converts RC from guesswork to systematic scoring.
2. **Error Spotting** — 3 hours on Subject-Verb Agreement, Tense Sequence, and Pronoun Errors covers 80% of what examiners test.
3. **Cloze Test** — closely tied to RC skill; once RC is solid, cloze tests come almost free.
4. **Fill in the Blanks** — double-blank questions reward collocations and tone-matching over pure grammar.
5. **Para-Jumble** — 2 hours on pivot-sentence identification and mandatory pairs; examiners recycle a narrow set of logical connectors.
6. **Vocabulary** — learn from the dedicated Vocabulary book (root-cluster method + PYQ-weighted words); use this chapter for usage-in-context drill only.
7. **Idioms & Phrases** — 200 high-frequency idioms cover virtually every SSC/Banks question in this category.
8. **Spelling** — 30 minutes on commonly misspelled words (accommodation, necessary, occurrence, etc.) clears this section reliably.

How to use this book

English in competitive exams is NOT literature.

- It is **pattern recognition** on a fixed set of grammar rules.
- And a **fixed vocabulary of trap-words**.
- Memorise the rules, drill the traps, you score.

Same type-first discipline:

- **Opener** — why the topic matters, minimum-rule list you must internalise.
- **Types** — the error patterns / question patterns examiners recycle.
- **For each type** — trigger phrase → rule → example → common trap → self-check.

How to read this book — your real study load

Total pages: 85.

This is a specialised exam-prep book. **Every page is essential** — including the worked-example drills, mini-mock and trap-cards near the end. Skipping any section costs you marks.

Read end-to-end in order without skipping.

Index — Table of Contents (clickable)

Pages	Part / Chapter	Topic / What it covers
p5	PART 1	PARTS OF SPEECH & SENTENCE STRUCTURE
p6–15	PART 2	TENSES (the Big Engine)
p16	PART 3	SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT
p16	PART 4	ARTICLES (a / an / the)
p17	PART 5	PREPOSITIONS (memorise the pairs)
p17	PART 6	CONJUNCTIONS
p18–23	PART 7	VOICE (ACTIVE ↔ PASSIVE)
p24–31	PART 8	DIRECT ↔ INDIRECT SPEECH (NARRATION)
p32	PART 9	ERROR SPOTTING
p32	PART 10	SENTENCE IMPROVEMENT / PHRASE REPLACEMENT
p33	PART 11	CLOZE TEST
p33	PART 12	READING COMPREHENSION (RC)
p33	PART 13	PARA-JUMBLES (SENTENCE REARRANGEMENT)
p34	PART 14	FILL IN THE BLANKS
p34	PART 15	VOCABULARY (Synonyms, Antonyms, Idioms, OWS, Spellings)
p35–53	PART 16	DEEP-DRILL VOCABULARY ESSENTIALS (high-yield list)
p54–57	PART 17	BANKS-FOCUS DEEP DRILL (PO/Clerk/RRB Bank, IBPS+SBI+RBI)
p58–83	PART 18	SSC + RRB FOCUS DEEP DRILL
p84	PART E	TIMED MINI-MOCK (25 Q · 25 min)
p85	PART F	TRAP-RECOGNITION CARDS (English)
—	Revision Cards	QUICK REVISION CARD: Core Grammar (Parts 4–8 condensed)
—	Appendix A	ERROR SPOTTING — 10-point master checklist
—	Appendix B	TOP-20 PREPOSITION PAIRS quick-reference
—	Appendix C	RC TRAPS (Banks + SSC)
—	Appendix G	FORMULA-BASED CONCEPTS MASTER REFERENCE

PART 1 — PARTS OF SPEECH & SENTENCE STRUCTURE

1.0 Opener

English questions test one of 8 parts of speech:

- Noun, Pronoun, Verb, Adjective, Adverb, Preposition, Conjunction, Interjection.

95% of error-spotting targets just 4 of these:

- **Verbs** — tense, agreement.
- **Prepositions** — fixed pairs.
- **Pronouns** — case, agreement.
- **Conjunctions** — pair traps (either/or, neither/nor, not only/but also).

The 8 Parts of Speech

Parts of Speech

Noun
(thing/person)

Pronoun
(I, you, he...)

VERB ★
(action/being)

Adjective
(describes noun)

Adverb
(modifies verb)

PREPOSITION ★
(in, on, at, of)

CONJUNCTION ★
(and, but, or)

Interjection
(Oh! Wow! Ah!)

★ = High-yield error-spotting target (95% of marks come from these 4)
Focus your prep here. Pronouns also trap students often.

Types

1. **Noun count** — singular vs plural collective nouns (team, jury, audience → context).
2. **Pronoun case** — I vs me, he vs him, who vs whom.
3. **Pronoun agreement** — "Each of the students **has** ..." (singular "each").
4. **Adjective vs adverb** — "He runs **quickly**" (not "quick").
5. **Degree of comparison** — "one of the tallest buildings" (superlative + plural).
6. **Preposition fixed pairs** → see PART 5.
7. **Conjunction pairs** → see PART 6.

1.1 Pronouns — case, agreement & reference (HIGH-YIELD)

Pronouns are the **2nd-most-tested** error category after verbs. The single test: is the pronoun in the correct **case** (subjective / objective / possessive), does it **agree** in number with its antecedent, and does its **reference** point to exactly one noun unambiguously?

Subjective (acts)	Objective (is acted on)	Possessive
I, you, he, she, it, we, they, who	me, you, him, her, it, us, them, whom	my, your, his, her, its, our, their, whose

Quick test for who vs whom: mentally rephrase with **he / him**. - "The boy ___ I saw" → "I saw **him**" → use **whom**. - "The boy ___ won the prize" → "**He** won" → use **who**.

Example 1 — pronoun case after preposition. *"Between you and I, the plan won't work."*

Step 1. "Between" is a preposition → its object must be in the **objective case**. **Step 2.** "I" is subjective; needs to be **me**.

Corrected: *"Between you and me, the plan won't work."*

Test trick: would you say "between we" or "between us"? Obviously us. So the second pronoun must be in the me/us/him/her/them family.

Example 2 — "each / every / either / neither / none" + singular verb + singular pronoun. *"Each of the players must bring their own racket."*

Step 1. "Each" → singular subject; verb already singular ("must bring" — OK). **Step 2.** But the *pronoun* "their" refers back to "each" → should also be **singular** in strict grammar: **his** or **her** (or *his/her* / *his or her* in modern usage).

Corrected (formal): *"Each of the players must bring his own racket."* (Modern usage often accepts singular "their" — but the SSC/Banks answer key still prefers the singular his.)

Example 3 — "who" vs "whom". *"The candidate whom I think will win is from Bihar."*

Step 1. Strip the parenthetical *"I think"* → *"The candidate ___ will win"* → subjective case → use **who**.

Corrected: *"The candidate who I think will win is from Bihar."*

*Test trick: if you can drop the verb cluster ("I think", "we believe") and the remainder is a subject sentence, use **who**.*

1.2 Adjective vs Adverb (HIGH-FREQUENCY trap)

Rule: *adjectives* modify nouns; *adverbs* modify verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs. The error is usually using an adjective where an adverb is needed.

Example 4. *"He drives very careful on highways."*

Step 1. What is being modified? *"drives"* — a **verb**. Verbs need **adverbs**. **Step 2.** *Careful* is an adjective; *carefully* is the adverb.

Corrected: *"He drives very carefully on highways."*

Example 5 — linking-verb exception. *"This flower smells sweetly."*

Step 1. "smells" is a **linking verb** (also: be, seem, appear, look, feel, taste, sound, become, grow). Linking verbs take **adjectives**, not adverbs, because they describe the **subject's state**, not the action.

Corrected: *"This flower smells sweet."* (describes the flower, not the act of smelling.)

Same rule: "She looks beautiful" (NOT beautifully), "The soup tastes delicious" (NOT deliciously).

1.3 Degree of Comparison (high-traps)

Three degrees: positive (tall) → comparative (taller, between **2** things) → superlative (tallest, among **3+** things).

Construction	Correct	Common error
Compare two things	comparative: <i>"the taller of the two"</i>	using superlative for two ("the tallest of the two")
Compare 3+ things	superlative: <i>"the tallest of all"</i>	using comparative
"More" + adjective	only with 2+ syllable adjectives ("more beautiful")	"more better", "more taller" (double comparative — wrong)
"Than" structure	A is taller than B	"A is taller then B" (then ≠ than)
"Than any other"	<i>"Mumbai is larger than any other city in Maharashtra"</i> (excluding Mumbai itself)	omitting "other" → "larger than any city" makes Mumbai larger than itself
"One of the + superlative + plural noun"	<i>"One of the tallest buildings"</i>	"one of the tallest building" (singular wrong)

Example 6. *"Mumbai is larger than any city in Maharashtra."*

Step 1. Mumbai is itself a city in Maharashtra. "any city" includes Mumbai → makes Mumbai larger than itself — a logical impossibility.

Corrected: *"Mumbai is larger than any other city in Maharashtra."*

Example 7. *"He is one of the best player in our team."*

Step 1. "one of the + superlative" must be followed by a **plural noun**. **Step 2.** "player" is singular → wrong.

Corrected: *"He is one of the best players in our team."*

1.4 Collective Nouns — singular vs plural

Noun acting as ONE unit (singular verb)	Same noun, members act individually (plural verb)
<i>The jury has reached a verdict.</i> (acting unanimously)	<i>The jury are divided in their opinion.</i> (members differ)
<i>The team is practicing.</i>	<i>The team are wearing different jerseys.</i>
<i>The committee has decided.</i>	<i>The committee were unable to agree.</i>

*SSC convention typically prefers the **singular** treatment unless the context is unambiguous about individual action. When in doubt for SSC: pick singular.*

1.5 Gerund (V-ing) vs Infinitive (to + V1) — the #1 PYQ source

Rule: After certain verbs, only a gerund is correct; after others, only an infinitive; after a small set, both are possible but with a **different meaning**.

Verbs that take ONLY a Gerund (V-ing)

Formula: V + V-ing (never "to + V1")

Verb group	Members
Enjoyment / avoidance	enjoy ★★★, avoid ★★★, mind ★★, miss ★★
Completion / delay	finish ★★, postpone ★★, keep ★
Denial / admission	deny ★★, suggest ★★, consider ★★
Habit / risk	practise ★★, risk ★
Special	stop (= give up) ★★★, regret (past) ★★★

✓ "I enjoy **reading**." ✗ "I enjoy **to read**." ✓ "She avoided **meeting** him." ✗ "She avoided **to meet** him."

Verbs that take ONLY an Infinitive (to + V1)

Formula: V + to + V1 (never V-ing)

Verb group	Members
Desire / plan	want ★★★, wish ★★★, hope ★★, decide ★★★, plan ★★, intend ★
Promise / refusal	promise ★★, agree ★★, refuse ★★
Ability / attempt	manage ★★, fail ★★★, learn ★★
Appearance	seem ★★★, appear ★★, pretend ★
Expectation	expect ★★

✓ "She decided **to leave**." ✗ "She decided **leaving**." ✓ "He failed **to submit** the form." ✗ "He failed **submitting** the form."

Verbs that take BOTH — but with DIFFERENT meanings (PYQ gold)

These are the most-tested traps in error spotting. Memorise all 7 pairs.

Verb	+ Gerund (V-ing)	+ Infinitive (to V1)	Memory tip
stop	give up habit: " <i>He stopped smoking.</i> " (= ceased it)	pause in order to: " <i>He stopped to smoke.</i> " (= paused his walk)	V-ing = end it ; to+V1 = pause for it
remember	recall past: " <i>I remember meeting her.</i> " (= I recall that meeting)	not forget future duty: " <i>Remember to lock the door.</i> " (= don't forget)	V-ing = past ; to+V1 = future
forget	fail to recall: " <i>I forget meeting him.</i> " (= no memory of it)	fail to do: " <i>I forgot to call him.</i> " (= I didn't make the call)	V-ing = memory gap ; to+V1 = action gap
regret	sorry about past action: " <i>I regret saying that.</i> " (= wish I hadn't)	sorry to inform: " <i>I regret to inform you ...</i> " (= formal announcement)	V-ing = past sorrow ; to+V1 = present formality
try	experiment / test: " <i>Try opening the window.</i> " (= see if it helps)	make an effort: " <i>Try to open the window.</i> " (= make your best attempt)	V-ing = experiment ; to+V1 = effort
mean	involve / result in: " <i>Success means working hard.</i> "	intend: " <i>I meant to call you.</i> "	V-ing = entails ; to+V1 = intend
need	passive sense / necessity: " <i>The car needs washing.</i> " (= needs to be washed)	want / obligation: " <i>I need to wash the car.</i> "	V-ing = thing-focused (passive) ; to+V1 = person-focused

COMMON TRAP

PYQ trap — "stopped to smoke" vs "stopped smoking"

Wrong: "He stopped to smoke on doctor's advice." Right: "He stopped smoking on doctor's advice."

Why: "on doctor's advice" means giving up the habit (gerund), not pausing for a smoke (infinitive).

PYQ trap — "remember meeting" vs "remember to meet"

Wrong: "Remember meeting the doctor at 5 pm." (implies you're recalling a past event) Right:

"Remember to meet the doctor at 5 pm." (= don't forget the upcoming appointment)

1.5 Common Part-of-Speech Traps

Trap	Example	Fix
Preposition + objective pronoun	"between you and I"	"between you and me "
Who vs whom (drop the parenthetical and test he/him)	"the man whom I think won"	"the man who I think won"
Each / every / either + singular	"Each boy have a book"	"Each boy has a book"
Adjective for verb	"She sings beautiful."	"She sings beautifully."
Adjective for linking verb	"It tastes badly."	"It tastes bad."
Double comparative / superlative	"more better", "most cleverest"	"better", "cleverest"
Compare with "any" (includes self)	"taller than any boy"	"taller than any other boy"
Superlative + singular noun after "one of"	"one of the best teacher"	"one of the best teachers"

1.6 Mini-PYQ Drill — Parts of Speech

- "He is shorter than (I / me)." → **I** (the implied full clause is "than I am"; subjective case).
- "Let (he / him) and (I / me) handle this." → **him** and **me** (after "let" — objective case).
- "Of the two brothers, Ram is the (taller / tallest)." → **taller** (comparing two).
- "This is the (most cleverest / cleverest) student in the class." → **cleverest** (no double superlative).
- "Each of the workers has (his / their) own toolkit." → **his** (formal/SSC); colloquial *their* increasingly accepted.

Carry-forward principle: in error-spotting, run a 4-step scan on every sentence — Verb (tense/agreement), Preposition (pair), Pronoun (case/agreement), Conjunction (parallelism). 95 % of marks live in these four.

PART 2 — TENSES (the Big Engine)

2.0 Opener

12 tenses = 4 aspects × 3 times. Master the *structural formula* for each cell of the grid and 70% of every Error-Spotting, Cloze, and Sentence-Improvement question becomes mechanical.

V1 = base verb (write), **V2 = past simple** (wrote), **V3 = past participle** (written), **V-ing = present participle** (writing).

2.0a The Master Tense Formula Grid — Affirmative

Read **row × column**: e.g. "Past Continuous" = row 2 (Continuous) × column 2 (Past). Every cell has the same structure: **formula + example + signal cues** (when this tense is triggered).

Aspect ↓ \ Time →	PRESENT	PAST	FUTURE
SIMPLE (plain action / fact / habit)	F: sub + V1 / V1+s (V1+s with he/she/it/singular) + obj E: "She writes a letter." Cues: every day, always, usually, often, never	F: sub + V2 + obj E: "She wrote a letter." Cues: yesterday, ago, last week, in 1995	F: sub + will / shall + V1 + obj E: "She will write a letter." Cues: tomorrow, next month, soon
CONTINUOUS (action in progress at a point in time)	F: sub + is/am/are + V1+ing + obj E: "She is writing a letter." Cues: now, right now, at the moment, currently	F: sub + was/were + V1+ing + obj E: "She was writing a letter when I called." Cues: at that moment, while, when (with another past)	F: sub + will be + V1+ing + obj E: "She will be writing a letter at 5 pm." Cues: this time tomorrow, at + future time
PERFECT (action completed with current relevance)	F: sub + has/have + V3 + obj E: "She has written a letter." Cues: just, already, ever, yet, recently, lately, so far	F: sub + had + V3 + obj E: "She had written the letter before he arrived." Cues: by the time, before / after (with another past)	F: sub + will have + V3 + obj E: "She will have written the letter by 6 pm." Cues: by next year, by then, by + future time
PERFECT CONTINUOUS (action ongoing UP TO a point + duration)	F: sub + has/have been + V1+ing + obj E: "She has been writing for an hour." Cues: since + start point, for + duration, all day/year	F: sub + had been + V1+ing + obj E: "She had been writing for an hour before he came." Cues: for + duration + before another past	F: sub + will have been + V1+ing + obj E: "By 5 pm she will have been writing for two hours." Cues: by + future time + for + duration

How to read this grid. Want past continuous? Find row "Continuous" × column "Past" → formula is **sub + was/were + V1+ing + obj**, example is "She was writing", cues are "while, at that moment, when". The same routine answers all 12 tenses.

2.0b Negatives & Questions — derive from the grid in one step

Every cell above is the **affirmative**. To make negatives and questions, use this universal pair of rules:

Operation	Rule	Applied example (Past Continuous)
Negative	Insert " not " immediately after the first auxiliary.	She was not writing a letter.
Question	Move the first auxiliary in front of the subject ; end with ?	Was she writing a letter?

Exception — Simple Present and Simple Past have no auxiliary in the affirmative; insert **do / does / did** for negatives & questions, and the main verb reverts to **V1**:

Tense	Negative	Question
Simple Present	sub + do / does + not + V1 + obj "She does not write a letter."	Do / Does + sub + V1 + obj + ? " Does she write a letter?"
Simple Past	sub + did + not + V1 + obj "She did not write a letter."	Did + sub + V1 + obj + ? " Did she write a letter?"

That's it — every one of the 36 forms (12 tenses × 3 moods) is now derivable from the grid plus these two rules.

2.1 The 12-Tense Master Table — Formula · Signal Words · Pitfall

FORMULA

General skeleton: S + Auxiliary(es) + Main Verb form (+ O) - **Question** = invert first auxiliary before S - **Negative** = insert not after first auxiliary - **Simple Present / Simple Past negatives / questions** → insert do/does/did ; main verb reverts to V1

Tense	Formula (Affirmative)	Signal Words	Pitfall
Simple Present	S + V1/V1+s + O	always, often, usually, every day, rarely, never, sometimes	✗ "Look! It rains ." → ✓ "It is raining ." (use Present Continuous for right-now)
Present Continuous	S + is/am/are + V-ing + O	now, right now, at present, at the moment, currently, look! listen!	✗ Using for stative verbs: "I am knowing the answer." → ✓ "I know the answer."
Present Perfect	S + has/have + V3 + O	just, already, yet, ever, never, recently, lately, so far, since + point, for + duration	✗ "I have finished it two hours ago ." → ✓ "I finished it two hours ago." (ago locks Simple Past)
Present Perfect Continuous	S + has/have + been + V-ing + O	for + duration, since + point, all day, the whole morning	✗ "She has been waiting since two hours." → ✓ "... for two hours." (since = point, for = duration)
Simple Past	S + V2 + O	yesterday, ago, last week/month/year, in 2010, once, then	✗ "I have visited Goa last December ." → ✓ "I visited Goa last December."
Past Continuous	S + was/were + V-ing + O	while, as, when (for background), at 5 pm yesterday	✗ "They were play football." → ✓ "They were playing football."
Past Perfect	S + had + V3 + O	before, after, by the time, already, no sooner...than, hardly...when	✗ "After he had arrived , the meeting had started ." — only the EARLIER action takes had+V3
Past Perfect Continuous	S + had + been + V-ing + O	for + duration + before/when (past), since + point + before/when	✗ Confusing with Past Continuous — use when duration up to a past point matters
Simple Future	S + will/shall + V1 + O	tomorrow, next week/month/year, soon, in 2030	✗ "I will call you when he will arrive ." → ✓ "...when he arrives ." (time-clause → Simple Present)
Future Continuous	S + will be + V-ing + O	at this time tomorrow, at 8 pm next Monday, in the coming weeks	✗ Using Future Simple when duration at a future moment is meant
Future Perfect	S + will have + V3 + O	by + future time, by then, by the time + clause, before + future point	✗ "He will complete the project by Friday." → ✓ "He will have completed it by Friday."
Future Perfect Continuous	S + will have been + V-ing + O	for + duration + by + future time	✗ Using Future Perfect when ongoing duration is the point

2.1.1 Full forms — Positive · Negative · Question reference

FORMULA

Simple Present — S + V1/V1+s + O

- Positive: *She writes a letter.*
- Negative: *She does not write a letter.*
- Question: **Does* she** write* a letter?

FORMULA

Present Continuous — S + is/am/are + V-ing + O

- Positive: *She is writing a letter.*
- Negative: *She is not writing a letter.*
- Question: **Is* she** writing* a letter?

FORMULA

Present Perfect — S + has/have + V3 + O

- Positive: *She has written a letter.*
- Negative: *She has not written a letter.*
- Question: **Has* she** written* a letter?

FORMULA

Present Perfect Continuous — S + has/have + been + V-ing + O

- Positive: *She has been writing the letter for two hours.*
- Negative: *She has not been writing the letter.*
- Question: **Has* she** been writing* the letter?

FORMULA

Simple Past — S + V2 + O

- Positive: *She wrote a letter.*
- Negative: *She did not write a letter.*
- Question: **Did* she** write* a letter?

FORMULA

Past Continuous — S + was/were + V-ing + O

- Positive: *She was writing a letter.*
- Negative: *She was not writing a letter.*
- Question: **Was* she** writing* a letter?

FORMULA

Past Perfect — S + had + V3 + O

- Positive: *She had written the letter before he arrived.*
- Negative: *She had not written the letter.*
- Question: **Had* she** written* the letter?

FORMULA

Past Perfect Continuous — S + had + been + V-ing + O

- Positive: *She had been writing the letter for an hour when he came.*
- Negative: *She had not been writing the letter.*
- Question: **Had*** **she** been writing* *the letter?*

FORMULA

Simple Future — S + will/shall + V1 + O

- Positive: *She will write a letter.*
- Negative: *She will not (won't) write a letter.*
- Question: **Will*** **she** write* *a letter?*
- "going to" form: planned/intended future or evidence-based prediction ("It **is going to** rain — look at those clouds").

FORMULA

Future Continuous — S + will be + V-ing + O

- Positive: *She will be writing the letter at 5 pm.*
- Negative: *She will not be writing the letter.*
- Question: **Will*** **she** be writing* *the letter?*

FORMULA

Future Perfect — S + will have + V3 + O

- Positive: *She will have written the letter by 6 pm.*
- Negative: *She will not have written the letter.*
- Question: **Will*** **she** have written* *the letter?*

FORMULA

Future Perfect Continuous — S + will have been + V-ing + O

- Positive: *By June 2027, she will have been writing her novel for three years.*
- Negative: *She will not have been writing her novel for three years.*
- Question: **Will*** **she** have been writing* *her novel for three years by June?*
- Signal words: for + duration + by + future time.
- Use: duration of an action up to a future reference point.

2.2 Tense forms at a glance — positive / negative / question

Compact supplement only — this table shows the structural formula. For signal words (ago, since, already, etc.) and usage notes, see 2.1. For per-tense traps, see 2.4a.

Tense	Positive	Negative	Question
Simple Present	S + V1/Vs	S + do/does + not + V1	Do/Does + S + V1?
Present Continuous	S + am/is/are + V-ing	S + am/is/are + not + V-ing	Am/Is/Are + S + V-ing?
Present Perfect	S + has/have + V3	S + has/have + not + V3	Has/Have + S + V3?
Present Perfect Continuous	S + has/have + been + V-ing	S + has/have + not + been + V-ing	Has/Have + S + been + V-ing?
Simple Past	S + V2	S + did + not + V1	Did + S + V1?
Past Continuous	S + was/were + V-ing	S + was/were + not + V-ing	Was/Were + S + V-ing?
Past Perfect	S + had + V3	S + had + not + V3	Had + S + V3?
Past Perfect Continuous	S + had + been + V-ing	S + had + not + been + V-ing	Had + S + been + V-ing?
Simple Future	S + will + V1	S + will + not + V1	Will + S + V1?
Future Continuous	S + will + be + V-ing	S + will + not + be + V-ing	Will + S + be + V-ing?
Future Perfect	S + will + have + V3	S + will + not + have + V3	Will + S + have + V3?
Future Perfect Continuous	S + will + have + been + V-ing	S + will + not + have + been + V-ing	Will + S + have + been + V-ing?

2.3 Worked examples — two per tense

Simple Present

Build: "He / read / the newspaper / every morning." 1. Subject = "He" (3rd person singular) → verb takes **-s**. 2. Read + s = **reads**. 3. Sentence: *He reads the newspaper every morning.*

Build: Negative & question of "They play cricket on Sundays." 1. Auxiliary for present simple plural = **do**. 2. Negative: *They do not play cricket on Sundays.* 3. Question: **Do* they** play* cricket on Sundays?

Present Continuous

Spot the error: "She is write a letter now." 1. Continuous needs V-ing, not V1. "write" → "writing". 2. Correct: *She is writing a letter now.*

Future use: "We meet the principal tomorrow at 10." 1. Pre-arranged plan → use present continuous for future. 2. Correct: *We are meeting the principal tomorrow at 10.*

Present Perfect

Choose tense: "I __ (live) in Mumbai since 2018." 1. "Since 2018" = action started in past, continues. Trigger → present perfect. 2. Answer: *I have lived in Mumbai since 2018.*

Spot the error: "He has gone to Delhi yesterday." 1. "yesterday" = finished past time → cannot pair with present perfect. 2. Correct: *He went to Delhi yesterday.* (simple past)

Present Perfect Continuous

Build: "She / wait / for the bus / for thirty minutes." 1. "for thirty minutes" = duration up to now → present perfect continuous. 2. Form: has/have + been + V-ing. Subject "she" → **has been waiting**. 3. *She has been waiting for the bus for thirty minutes.*

Choose tense: "I'm tired because I __ (run)." 1. Visible present result of recent ongoing action → present perfect continuous. 2. *I'm tired because I have been running.*

Simple Past

Spot the error: "I have visited Goa last December." 1. "last December" = definite past time → simple past, not present perfect. 2. Correct: *I visited Goa last December.*

Build interrogative: "She danced at the party." 1. Auxiliary for past simple = **did**; main verb returns to V1. 2. **Did* she dance*** at the party?

Past Continuous

Choose tense: "While I __ (read), the phone __ (ring)." 1. "While" + longer background action → past continuous. Interrupting action → simple past. 2. *While I was reading, the phone rang.*

Spot the error: "They were play football at 5 pm yesterday." 1. Continuous needs V-ing. "play" → "playing". 2. Correct: *They were playing football at 5 pm yesterday.*

Past Perfect

Choose tense: "The train __ (leave) before we reached the station." 1. Two past actions; the earlier one → past perfect, the later one → simple past. 2. *The train had left before we reached the station.*

Spot the error: "After he finished dinner, he went to bed." 1. Acceptable, but if we need to stress that dinner came before bed, use past perfect for the earlier action. 2. Preferred: *After he had finished dinner, he went to bed.*

Past Perfect Continuous

Build: "We / wait / for two hours / before the doctor arrived." 1. Duration up to a past point → had + been + V-ing. 2. *We had been waiting for two hours before the doctor arrived.*

Choose tense: "Her eyes were red because she __ (cry)." 1. Past visible result of ongoing past action → past perfect continuous. 2. *Her eyes were red because she had been crying.*

Simple Future

Choose form: "I __ (help) you with your homework — don't worry." 1. Spontaneous offer/decision → "will". 2. *I will help you with your homework.*

Pre-planned future: "We __ (visit) Jaipur next weekend; tickets are booked." 1. Pre-arranged plan → "going to" or present continuous; "will" is weaker. 2. *We are going to visit / are visiting Jaipur next weekend.*

Future Continuous

Build: "This time tomorrow, I / fly / to London." 1. Action in progress at a future moment → will be + V-ing. 2. *This time tomorrow, I will be flying to London.*

Polite enquiry: "___ you ___ (use) the car this evening?" 1. Future continuous softens the question (no implied request). 2. **Will* you** be using* the car this evening?

Future Perfect

Build: "By 2030, India / become / a \$5-trillion economy." 1. Action completed before a future time → will have + V3. 2. *By 2030, India will have become a \$5-trillion economy.*

Spot the error: "He will complete the project by next Friday." 1. To highlight prior completion, use future perfect. 2. Sharper: *He will have completed the project by next Friday.*

Future Perfect Continuous

Build: "By next December, I / work / here / for ten years." 1. Duration up to a future point → will have been + V-ing. 2. *By next December, I will have been working here for ten years.*

Choose tense: "In May, they ___ (live) abroad for five years." 1. Duration ending in future → future perfect continuous. 2. *In May, they will have been living abroad for five years.*

2.4 Time-phrase cue table

Signal phrase	Locked tense	Example
yesterday, ago, last week, in 2010, then	Simple Past	<i>He left yesterday.</i>
since + point in time	Present Perfect / PP-Continuous	<i>I have lived here since 2015.</i>
for + duration (action continues)	Present Perfect / PP-Continuous	<i>She has worked here for five years.</i>
for + duration (finished action)	Simple Past	<i>He worked there for five years (and left).</i>
just, already, yet, ever, never, so far, recently	Present Perfect	<i>I have just finished.</i>
while + (was/were) V-ing	Past Continuous	While <i>I was reading, the bell rang.</i>
by + future time	Future Perfect	By <i>2030, India will have become...</i>
at + future clock time	Future Continuous	<i>I will be flying at 8 pm tomorrow.</i>
always, often, usually, every day, never (habit)	Simple Present	<i>He always wakes up at 6 am.</i>
now, right now, at the moment, currently	Present Continuous	<i>She is currently writing.</i>
when + simple past	Simple Past + Past Cont.	<i>I was sleeping when he called.</i>

2.4a Per-tense traps — the most common examiner tricks

COMMON TRAP

Simple Past vs Present Perfect — "ago" and "yesterday" traps

- Wrong: *"I have finished it two hours ago."*
- Right: *"I finished it two hours ago."*
- Why: "ago", "yesterday", "last week", "in 2010" are definite past markers → they **lock** the verb to Simple Past. Present Perfect cannot coexist with a definite past time.
- Wrong: *"He has visited Goa last December."*
- Right: *"He visited Goa last December."*

COMMON TRAP

Past Perfect — reversing the action order

- Rule: When two actions both happened in the past, the **earlier** one takes Past Perfect; the **later** one takes Simple Past.
- Wrong: *"After he had arrived, the meeting had started."* (both in past perfect — wrong; the meeting starting is the later event)
- Right: *"After he arrived, the meeting had already started."* (meeting started earlier → past perfect; arrival is later → simple past)

COMMON TRAP

Present Perfect Continuous — "since" vs "for"

- "Since" pairs with a **point in time**: *"She has been waiting since 3 pm."* ✓
- "For" pairs with a **duration**: *"She has been waiting for two hours."* ✓
- Wrong: *"She has been waiting since two hours."* ✗

COMMON TRAP

Simple Present — NOT for actions happening right now

- Wrong: *"Look! It rains."*
- Right: *"Look! It is raining."*
- Why: "Look!" signals an action visible at this exact moment → Present Continuous.

COMMON TRAP

Future after time-clauses — will is NOT used inside the clause

- Wrong: *"I will call you when he will arrive."*
- Right: *"I will call you when he arrives."*
- Why: Time-subordinate clauses (when, before, after, until, as soon as) use **Simple Present** even for future meaning.

2.5 Conditionals (if-clauses)

FORMULA

Five conditional patterns — full formula and use:

Type	Use	If - clause formula	Main - clause formula	Example
Type 0	universal truth / scientific fact	If + S + V1 / V1+s	S + V1 / V1+s	<i>If you heat ice, it melts.</i>
Type 1	real, likely future	If + S + V1 / V1+s	S + will / can / may + V1	<i>If it rains, we will cancel the picnic.</i>
Type 2	unreal / hypothetical present	If + S + V2 (or "were" for to-be in all persons)	S + would / could / might + V1	<i>If I were you, I would apologise.</i>
Type 3	unreal / impossible past (regret)	If + S + had + V3	S + would / could / might + have + V3	<i>If I had studied, I would have passed.</i>
Mixed (3 → 2)	past cause → present result	If + S + had + V3	S + would + V1 (present result)	<i>If I had taken that job, I would be rich now.</i>

COMMON TRAP

Common conditional traps

- **"If I was you"** — wrong. Subjunctive needs **"If I were you"** for Type 2 (unreal present).
- Never write **"will"** inside an if-clause itself: *If it will rain ...* ✗ → *If it rains ...* ✓
- Type 3 needs **TWO** past participles: *If I had known, I would have come.* ✓ (not "would come").
- **"Unless"** already means "if not" — don't add another "not": *Unless you don't study* ✗ → *Unless you study* ✓.

2.6 Inversion patterns (formal, very high-frequency)

Formula: Negative/restrictive word at front → auxiliary moves before subject (same as question word order).

Trigger	Formula	Example	Trap
No sooner	No sooner + had + S + V3 + than + S + V2	<i>No sooner had I sat down than the bell rang.</i>	✗ "...when the bell rang" — must be than
Hardly / Scarcely	Hardly/Scarcely + had + S + V3 + when + S + V2	<i>Hardly had we left when it started raining.</i>	✗ "...than it started" — must be when
Never / Rarely / Seldom	Never/Rarely/Seldom + aux + S + V	<i>Never have I seen such chaos.</i>	✗ "Never I have seen..." — aux must precede S
Not only ... but also	Not only + aux + S + V, but also ...	<i>Not only does he sing, but he also dances.</i>	Keep aux inverted in the first clause only
Only after / Only when / Only then	Only + clause + aux + S + V	<i>Only after she left did I realise my mistake.</i>	✗ "Only after she left I realised" — aux must invert
Under no circumstances / In no way	Phrase + aux + S + V	<i>Under no circumstances should you open the door.</i>	✗ Normal word order after these phrases
Little	Little + aux + S + V	<i>Little did he know the truth.</i>	✗ "Little he knew the truth" — aux must precede S

Trigger	Formula	Example	Trap
As soon as + S + V2, S + V2	No inversion	<i>As soon as the train arrived, passengers rushed in.</i>	No inversion needed here

COMMON TRAP

Memory peg: No sooner → **than**; Hardly/Scarcely → **when**; these are non-negotiable pairs. Swapping them is the #1 inversion trap in PYQs.

2.7 Subjunctive (high-frequency in error spotting)

FORMULA

Subjunctive markers — verb stays in base form (V1) or uses **were** for all subjects.

- After **wish / if only / as if / as though** (unreal present): *I wish I were taller.*
- After **demand / insist / suggest / recommend / propose / request that ...**: *He insisted that she be present.*
- After **It is essential / important / necessary that ...**: *It is essential that he submit the form today.*
- After **lest** (= for fear that): *Run fast lest you should miss the bus.*

2.8 Mini-PYQ drill — Tenses

EXAM QUESTION

Q1 (SSC CGL pattern). Choose the correct option to fill the blank: "By the time we reached the hall, the speaker __ his lecture."

- (a) finished (b) has finished (c) had finished (d) was finishing

Ans: (c) had finished. Two past actions; the earlier (speaker finishing) takes past perfect.

EXAM QUESTION

Q2 (IBPS PO pattern). Identify the error: "She **has been working** here / **since** five years / and refuses to leave."

- (a) She has been working here (b) since five years
(c) and refuses to leave (d) no error

Ans: (b). "Five years" is a duration → use **for**, not **since**. Correct: *for five years*.

EXAM QUESTION

Q3 (SSC CHSL pattern). Fill in the blank: "If he __ harder, he would have qualified."

- (a) studied (b) had studied (c) studies (d) has studied

Ans: (b) had studied. Type-3 conditional → **If + had + V3, would have + V3**.

EXAM QUESTION

Q4 (CGL Tier-1). Choose the grammatically correct sentence:

- (a) No sooner I reached the station than the train left.
- (b) No sooner had I reached the station than the train left.
- (c) No sooner did I reach the station when the train left.
- (d) No sooner I had reached than the train was left.

Ans: (b). Inversion: **No sooner had + S + V3 ... than + S + V2.**

EXAM QUESTION

Q5 (IBPS Clerk pattern). Pick the correct tense: "Look! The bus ___."

- (a) leaves
- (b) is leaving
- (c) has left
- (d) leaved

Ans: (b) is leaving. "Look!" signals an action happening *now* → **present continuous**.

EXAM QUESTION

Q6 (CGL Tier-2 pattern). Choose the correct form: "By next April, I ___ in this company for twenty years."

- (a) will work
- (b) have worked
- (c) will have been working
- (d) am working

Ans: (c) will have been working. Duration ending at a future point → **future perfect continuous**.

EXAM QUESTION

Q7 (SBI PO pattern). Identify the error: "He **suggested** / that the proposal / **was discussed** / immediately."

- (a) He suggested
- (b) that the proposal
- (c) was discussed
- (d) immediately

Ans: (c). After "suggested that", use the **subjunctive base form**. Correct: *that the proposal be discussed***.

EXAM QUESTION

Q8 (SSC MTS pattern). Fill in the blank: "She ___ to the temple every Friday."

- (a) is going
- (b) goes
- (c) has gone
- (d) is gone

Ans: (b) goes. "Every Friday" = habit → **simple present**.

KEY FACT

Tenses — exam recall card

1. **Past markers** (yesterday, ago, last, in 2010) ⇒ **simple past**, never present perfect.
2. **Since + point, for + duration** ⇒ **present perfect (continuous)**.
3. **By + future time** ⇒ **future perfect**.
4. **While / when + V-ing** ⇒ **past continuous** (with an interrupting simple past).
5. **If + were** for unreal present ("If I **were** you").
6. **No sooner had ... than; Hardly had ... when** — fixed inversion.
7. After **wish / suggest / insist that** ⇒ subjunctive base form.

PART 3 — SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

3.0 Opener

Most common error class. Memorise these rules cold.

The 15 Golden SVA Rules (formula card format)

Rule 1 — Either/or · Neither/nor Formula: [Either A or B] / [Neither A nor B] → verb agrees with **B (closer noun)** ✓ *"Neither the teacher nor the students are wrong."* (students closer → plural) ✓ *"Neither the students nor the teacher is wrong."* (teacher closer → singular) ✗ *"Either the boys or the girl are late."* → "girl" is closer → **is**

Rule 2 — Parenthetical phrases (with / along with / as well as / besides / including) Formula: [A, along with B,] → verb agrees with **A only** (B is parenthetical) ✓ *"The principal, along with the teachers, is attending."* ✗ *"The principal, along with the teachers, are attending."*

Rule 3 — Collective nouns (family, team, jury, committee, government, audience) Formula: Unit action → **singular**; Members acting individually → **plural** ✓ *"The jury has reached a verdict."* (one decision = unit action) ✓ *"The jury are divided in their opinions."* (each member has a different view)

Rule 4 — Uncountable nouns (news, furniture, information, advice, luggage, machinery, poetry, scenery, bread, wealth) Formula: [uncountable noun] → always **singular verb** ✓ *"The news is good."* ✗ *"The news are good."*

Rule 5 — Always-plural nouns (trousers, scissors, spectacles, goods, wages, premises, cattle, police) Formula: [always-plural noun] → always **plural verb** ✓ *"His trousers are torn."* ✗ *"His trousers is torn."*

Rule 6 — Each / Every / Either / Neither / Many a / More than one Formula: [these words] → always **singular verb** (even when they feel plural) ✓ *"Each of the students has submitted the form."* ✓ *"More than one candidate was disqualified."* (sounds plural; is singular!) ✗ *"Each of the students have submitted the form."*

Rule 7 — "A number of" vs "The number of" Formula: **A** number of + plural noun → **plural verb** (a number of = many) Formula: **The** number of + plural noun → **singular verb** (the number of = a count) ✓ *"A number of students have applied."* ✓ *"The number of applicants is rising."* ✗ *"A number of students has applied."*

Rule 8 — Academic/mathematical subjects ending in -s (maths, physics, economics, statistics, civics, politics) Formula: [-s subject noun] → always **singular verb** ✓ *"Economics is a scoring subject."* ✗ *"Physics are tough."* → **is**

Rule 9 — Distance / money / time / weight as a single unit Formula: [quantity + unit] treated as one amount → **singular verb** ✓ *"Ten kilometres is a long walk."* ✓ *"Five hundred rupees is too much."* ✗ *"Five hundred rupees are too much."*

Rule 10 — "There is / There are" Formula: There + [be] → verb agrees with the **real subject** after "there" (not with "there") ✓ *"There are five books on the table."* (real subject = five books → plural) ✗ *"There is five books on the table."*

Rule 11 — "None" Formula: None of + uncountable → **singular**; None of + plural countable → plural accepted; SSC: prefer singular when ambiguous ✓ *"None of the water was wasted."* (uncountable) ✓ *"None of the students were present."* (plural countable — accepted)

Rule 12 — "One of the + plural noun + who/that" Formula: One of the [plural noun] + who/that → verb after who/that = **plural** (agrees with the plural noun, not "one") ✓ *"He is one of the boys who play well."* (who = boys → plural) ✗ *"He is one of the boys who plays well."*

Rule 13 — Indefinite pronouns (everyone, someone, no one, anyone, everybody, somebody, nobody, each, nothing, everything) Formula: [indefinite pronoun] → always **singular verb + singular pronoun** ✓ *"Everyone has done his homework."* ✗ *"Everyone have done their homework."*

Rule 14 — Titles of books / films / organisations / countries (even if plural-looking) Formula: [plural-looking title or organisation] → treated as **singular** ✓ *"The Arabian Nights is a classic."* ✓ *"The United States is a superpower."* ✗ *"The United States are a superpower."*

Rule 15 — "Percentage of / proportion of / majority of / fraction of" Formula: [fraction phrase] + of + [noun] → verb agrees with the **noun after "of"** ✓ *"A large percentage of the work has been done."* (work = uncountable → singular) ✓ *"A large percentage of the students have passed."* (students = plural → plural)

3.1 Worked Examples — Error Spotting (find and fix the SVA error)

For each sentence below, ask three diagnostic questions in order: 1. What is the *real* grammatical subject? (Look past intervening phrases.) 2. Is it singular or plural? 3. Does the verb agree with it?

Example 1. *"The list of items are on your desk."*

Step 1. Real subject: **"list"** (NOT "items"). "of items" is a prepositional phrase modifying *list*; ignore it for agreement. **Step 2.** *List* is singular. **Step 3.** Verb must be *is*, not *are*. **Corrected:** *"The list of items is on your desk."*

Example 2. *"Neither the captain nor his players was available for comment."*

Step 1. Real subject after "neither/nor": agreement is with the **closer** noun → *players*. **Step 2.** *Players* is plural. **Step 3.** Verb must be *were*, not *was*. **Corrected:** *"Neither the captain nor his players were available for comment."*

Example 3. *"The principal, along with the teachers, are attending the meeting."*

Step 1. "Along with" is a parenthetical (like "as well as", "besides", "including") — the real subject is what comes *before* it: **principal**. **Step 2.** *Principal* is singular. **Step 3.** Verb must be *is*, not *are*.

Corrected: *"The principal, along with the teachers, is attending the meeting."*

Example 4. *"A number of students has submitted the form."*

Step 1. Distinguish the two formulas: • **"A number of"** = many → **plural** verb. • **"The number of"** = a count → **singular** verb. **Step 2.** Sentence has "a number of" → plural. **Step 3.** Verb must be *have*, not *has*. **Corrected:** *"A number of students have submitted the form."*

Example 5. *"Physics are my favourite subject."*

Step 1. *Physics* is a mathematical/scientific subject (like maths, economics, statistics) — ends in -s but is **singular**. **Step 2.** Singular subject. **Step 3.** Verb must be *is*. **Corrected:** *"Physics is my favourite subject."*

Example 6 — "More than one" (Rule 6) — singular despite "more". *"More than one applicant were rejected."*

Step 1. "More than one + singular noun" always takes a **singular verb**. **Step 2.** Verb must be *was*, not *were*. **Corrected:** *"More than one applicant was rejected."*

Example 7 — "One of the ... who" (Rule 12) — verb after "who" agrees with the plural noun. *"She is one of the nurses who works in this hospital."*

Step 1. "who" refers back to "nurses" (plural), not "one" (singular). **Step 2.** Verb after "who" must be plural. **Corrected:** *"She is one of the nurses who work in this hospital."*

Example 8 — "Percentage of" (Rule 15) — verb controlled by noun after "of". *"A large proportion of the budget are allocated to defence."*

Step 1. "of the budget" → "budget" is uncountable (singular noun follows "of"). **Step 2.** Verb must be singular. **Corrected:** *"A large proportion of the budget is allocated to defence."*

Example 9 — Indefinite pronoun (Rule 13) — everyone is always singular. *"Everyone in the team have given their best."*

Step 1. "Everyone" = indefinite pronoun → always takes a singular verb. **Step 2.** Verb must be *has*. **Corrected:** *"Everyone in the team has given his best."*

3.2 Common SVA Traps

Trap	Trigger	Memorise
Prepositional phrase as decoy	"The bag of apples ____"	Verb agrees with bag (singular), not apples.
Parenthetical ("along with", "as well as")	"The CEO, along with managers, ____"	Verb agrees with the CEO alone.
"Either/or", "Neither/nor"	"Either A or B ____"	Verb agrees with the closer noun.
Subject after "There"	"There ____ five books on the table."	<i>There are</i> — verb agrees with the real subject <i>five books</i> .

Trap	Trigger	Memorise
Uncountables ending in -s	News, mathematics, economics, civics	Always singular .
Collective + individual action	"The team ____ wearing different uniforms."	Plural when members act individually: <i>are</i> .
Distance / time / money	"Ten kilometres ____ a long way."	Singular: <i>is</i> .

3.3 Mini-PYQ Drill — SVA

- "Each of the boys (was / were) given a prize." → **was** (each + singular).
- "The committee (has / have) decided the matter." → **has** (unit-action) OR *have* (member-action) — both valid; SSC usually marks **has**.
- "One of the men (is / are) absent today." → **is** (subject = one).
- "Bread and butter (is / are) my breakfast." → **is** (treated as a single dish).
- "The poet and statesman (is / are) dead." → **is** (one person who is both); "The poet and the statesman are dead." (two people) → **are**.

Carry-forward principle: in 90 % of SVA traps, the subject sits before a long prepositional or parenthetical phrase. Find the real subject; ignore the noise; pick the agreeing verb.

PART 4 — ARTICLES (a / an / the)

4.0 Article Decision Table

Selection rule: choose by SOUND (not spelling) for a/an. Then check the 3-column table.

Situation	A / An	The	Ø (no article)
First mention of a countable singular noun	✓ "I saw a dog."	✗	✗
Specific / already-known noun	✗	✓ " The dog I saw was huge."	✗
Unique things (sun, moon, Earth, sky, universe)	✗	✓ " The sun rises in the east."	✗
Superlatives & ordinals	✗	✓ " The best student", " the first attempt"	✗
Professions / roles (non-specific)	✓ "She is a doctor."	✗	✗
Adjectives used as plural nouns	✗	✓ " The poor suffer."	✗
Rivers, oceans, seas, mountain ranges, deserts, gulfs	✗	✓ " The Ganges", " the Himalayas", " the Sahara"	✗
Single mountains, single lakes	✗	✗	✓ "Mount Everest", "Lake Victoria"
Newspapers, ships	✗	✓ " The Hindu", " the Titanic"	✗
Musical instruments (playing generally)	✗	✓ "She plays the piano."	✗
Abstract / uncountable nouns in general meaning	✗	✗	✓ " Honesty is the best policy."
Languages	✗	✗	✓ "She speaks French ."

Situation	A / An	The	Ø (no article)
Sports / games	✗	✗	✓ "He plays cricket ."
Meals	✗	✗	✓ "We had lunch ."
Most countries (singular, non-federal)	✗	✗	✓ " India is vast."
Countries with plural/federal names	✗	✓ " The USA", " the Netherlands", " the UAE"	✗
Plural countable nouns (general meaning)	✗	✗	✓ " Books are valuable."

a vs an decision (by FIRST SOUND, not letter):

Use a	Use an
consonant sound: a book, a car, a university (/j/ sound), a one-eyed man (/w/ sound)	vowel sound: an apple, an honest man (silent h), an MBA (/em/), an X-ray (/eks/)

Types

1. **Missing article before a known/unique noun.**
2. **Extra article before abstract noun / plural uncountable** ("Honesty is the best policy" — no article before honesty).
3. **"A" vs "An" by sound** — "an MBA", "a one-eyed man".
4. **Countries** — normally no "the" (India); exception: The USA, The Netherlands (plural/federal names).
5. **Superlatives + ordinals** always take "the".

4.1 Worked Examples — Articles

For each sentence, ask: 1. Is the noun **countable singular**? → needs *a / an / the*. 2. Is the noun **specific / unique / superlative / ordinal**? → needs *the*. 3. Is the noun an **abstract / uncountable / plural-general**? → usually **no article**. 4. For "a / an", does the **first sound** start with a vowel? → use *an*.

Example 1. "He is honest man." — find and fix.

Step 1. "Man" is countable singular. **Step 2.** Not specific (no prior mention). **Step 3.** Use *a / an*. **Step 4.** "Honest" starts with a vowel sound (the *h* is silent) → use **an**.

Corrected: "He is an honest man."

Example 2. "She has applied for the MBA at a IIM." — find and fix.

Step 1. "MBA" begins with the consonant letter *M* but with the **vowel sound /ɛm/** → use **an** ("an MBA").

Step 2. "IIM" begins with the **vowel sound /aɪ/** → use **an** ("an IIM").

Corrected: "She has applied for an MBA at an IIM."

Article choice is by sound, not spelling. "An hour" (silent *h*), "a university" (sounds /ju:/), "an honour", "a one-way street" (sounds /wʌn/).

Example 3. "Honesty is best policy." — find and fix.

Step 1. "Honesty" = abstract uncountable → **no article**. **Step 2.** "policy" is countable singular, BUT here it is part of the **superlative "the best policy"** — superlatives always take **the**.

Corrected: "Honesty is the best policy."

Example 4. "The India is a great country with Himalayas in north." — find and fix.

Step 1. Country names normally take NO article ("India", not "The India"). Exception: countries whose name is **plural / a federation** ("the USA", "the Netherlands", "the UAE", "the UK"). **Step 2.** "Himalayas" is a mountain RANGE → takes **the**. **Step 3.** "north" is a direction (specific) → use **the north**.

Corrected: "India is a great country with the Himalayas in the north."

4.2 Articles — Quick Reference Table

Use a / an	Use the	Use NO article
Indefinite countable singular ("a boy")	Specific or previously mentioned ("the boy I met")	Plural general ("Boys play.")
First introduction ("I saw a dog. The dog...")	Unique things ("the sun, the moon")	Uncountable / abstract ("Honesty is good")
	Superlatives & ordinals ("the best", "the first")	Proper nouns (most countries, persons)
	Rivers, oceans, mountain ranges, deserts ("the Nile, the Sahara")	Single mountains ("Mount Everest"), single lakes ("Lake Victoria")
	Plural countries / federations ("the USA", "the UK")	Singular countries (India, France)
	Adjectives as plural nouns ("the poor, the rich")	Languages ("She speaks English"), Diseases ("He has flu")
	Ships, newspapers, musical instruments ("the Titanic, the Hindu, the guitar")	Meals ("We had lunch"), games ("We play chess")

4.3 Mini-PYQ Drill — Articles

- "It was ___ honour to meet you." → **an** (silent h).
- "___ Ganges flows from ___ Himalayas to ___ Bay of Bengal." → **The / the / the** (river, mountain range, sea — all take the).
- "He is ___ best player in ___ team." → **the / the** (superlative; specific team).
- "Sugar is ___ bad for your health." → **no article** (sugar = uncountable mass noun).
- "___ Mahatma Gandhi was ___ great leader." → **(no article) / a** (proper noun; non-specific count).

Carry-forward principle: in error-spotting, the article is almost always the trap word. Always run the 4-question check (countable? specific? abstract? sound?) before picking your answer.

PART 5 — PREPOSITIONS (memorise the pairs)

5.0 Opener

Prepositions in English are largely idiomatic — there is no rule; you must memorise the fixed verb-preposition / adjective-preposition pairs. Below are the most-tested ones.

5.0a AT / IN / ON — Time

Preposition	When to use	Example	Trap
AT	specific clock time; fixed points of day; festivals	at 5 pm, at noon, at midnight, at sunrise, at Diwali, at the weekend	X "She called me on 3 pm." → ✓ "... at 3 pm."
IN	longer period: month, year, season, century; parts of day (NOT "night")	in January, in 2024, in summer, in the morning, in the afternoon	X "I study in night." → ✓ "... at night." (night is the only exception)
ON	specific day; specific date; named occasion	on Monday, on 15 June, on my birthday, on Independence Day	X "I met him in Monday." → ✓ "... on Monday."

5.0b AT / IN / ON — Place

Preposition	When to use	Example	Trap
AT	specific point / named location (small)	at the bus stop, at home, at school, at the corner	X "I am in home." → ✓ "I am at home."
IN	enclosed space; inside; city; country	in the room, in Delhi, in India, in the office, in a box	X "She lives at Delhi." → ✓ "She lives in Delhi."
ON	surface (horizontal or vertical)	on the table, on the wall, on the floor, on the road	X "The book is in the table." → ✓ "... on the table."

5.0c Preposition + Gerund (V-ing) combinations — high-frequency in PYQs

When a preposition is followed by a verb, the verb **must** be in the gerund form (V-ing), never the infinitive.

Formula: preposition + V-ing (never preposition + to + V1)

Phrase	Correct form	Wrong form
interested in	interested in studying	~~interested in to study~~
capable of	capable of solving	~~capable of to solve~~
accustomed to	accustomed to working late	~~accustomed to work~~
fond of	fond of reading	~~fond of to read~~
tired of	tired of waiting	~~tired of to wait~~
responsible for	responsible for managing	~~responsible for to manage~~
look forward to	look forward to meeting you	~~look forward to meet~~
insist on	insist on doing it	~~insist on to do~~
afraid of	afraid of failing	~~afraid of to fail~~
good at	good at speaking	~~good at to speak~~
succeeded in	succeeded in passing	~~succeeded in to pass~~
prevented from	prevented from leaving	~~prevented from to leave~~

COMMON TRAP

"used to" trap — two different structures: - **"used to + V1"** (past habit): *"She used to live in Mumbai."* ✓ (base verb, not gerund) - **"accustomed to + V-ing"** (present habit): *"She is accustomed to living in Mumbai."* ✓ (gerund) - **"used to + V-ing"** (being accustomed): *"She is used to working late."* ✓ (gerund)
Wrong: *"She is used to work late."* ✗ — after "used to" when it means "accustomed", use V-ing.

High-frequency fixed pairs

Verb / Adjective	Preposition(s)	Key trap
accuse, charge	of (accuse); with (charge)	✗ "accused with" → ✓ "accused of "
agree	to (proposal) / with (person) / on (topic)	"agree to a plan"; "agree with him"
consist	of	✗ "consist in" (for ingredients) → ✓ "consist of "
comprise	(no preposition)	✗ "comprise of " → ✓ "comprises 11 players"
differ	from (things) / with (person) / on (topic)	"differs from B"; "differs with me"
afraid / aware / capable / desirous / fond / proud / sick / tired	of	I am fond of sweets.
acquainted	with	acquainted with the rules
angry	with (person) / at (thing)	angry with him; angry at the noise
good / bad / clever / expert	at	good at maths
die	of (disease) / for (cause) / from (exhaustion, wound) / by (instrument)	died of cancer; died for the country
look	at / after / for / into / up / down on / forward to	look forward to + V-ing (never to + V1)
depend / insist / rely / concentrate / impose	on	insist on quality
congratulate / compliment / decide	on	congratulated on the win
prevent / suffer / refrain / prohibit / abstain	from	suffers from asthma
married / engaged	to	married to (✗ "married with")
superior / inferior / junior / senior / prior / prefer	to	senior to me (✗ "senior than")
amount	to	His income amounts to ₹5 lakh.

Types

1. **Wrong preposition after a fixed verb / adjective** — error spotting. Memorise pairs.
2. **Missing preposition** — "discuss **about**" is wrong; "discuss" takes no preposition.
3. **Double preposition** — "enter **into**" is wrong for physical entry; correct only for agreement ("enter into a contract").
4. **"Prefer X to Y"** — NEVER "prefer X than Y".
5. **Time-place pairs** — in (month / year / morning), on (day / date), at (clock time).

5.1 Worked Examples — Preposition Error Spotting

Three diagnostic questions for every preposition error: 1. Is the preposition required at all? (Some verbs take NO preposition: discuss, marry, enter [a room], reach.) 2. Is it the correct preposition? (Fixed pairs are non-negotiable.) 3. Does the comparison structure follow "to", not "than"? (superior/inferior/junior/senior/prior/prefer all take *to*.)

Example 1. *"We discussed about the matter for two hours."*

Step 1. "Discuss" is **transitive** — it takes a direct object with **no preposition**. **Step 2.** "about" is extra and wrong.

Corrected: *"We discussed the matter for two hours."*

Same rule applies to: **marry** (not "marry with"), **enter [a room]** (not "enter into" — except for agreements/contracts), **reach** (not "reach to/at" for arrival), **resemble** (not "resemble to"), **comprise** (not "comprise of").

Example 2. *"He is married with a doctor and is senior than me."*

Step 1. "married" pairs with **to**, never *with*. **Step 2.** "senior" pairs with **to**, never *than* (same with superior, inferior, junior, prior, prefer).

Corrected: *"He is married to a doctor and is senior to me."*

Example 3. *"She prefers tea than coffee."*

Step 1. "prefer X to Y" — fixed pair; *than* is wrong.

Corrected: *"She prefers tea to coffee."*

If you want to use *than*, you must say "**rather than**": *"She would rather have tea than coffee."*

Example 4. *"The meeting will start in 10 AM on Monday in January."*

Step 1. Time-of-day/clock-time → use **at** ("at 10 AM"). **Step 2.** Day → use **on** ("on Monday") ✓. **Step 3.** Month → use **in** ("in January") ✓.

Corrected: *"The meeting will start at 10 AM on Monday in January."*

Time-preposition cheat: **AT** (clock), **ON** (day/date), **IN** (month/year/century/period).

Example 5. *"He died from pneumonia and left from Mumbai by air."*

Step 1. "Die" — **died of a disease (long illness)**; **died **from** an injury / exhaustion; **died for a cause**; **died **by** an instrument (hanging, drowning). Pneumonia = disease → **died of pneumonia**. **Step 2.**

"Left" — depart *from* a place is fine, but the more idiomatic preposition here is just *for* the destination, or just "left Mumbai". "Left from Mumbai" sounds redundant; standard usage = *"left Mumbai by air"* or *"departed from Mumbai by air"*.

Corrected: *"He died of pneumonia and left Mumbai by air."*

5.2 Top-20 Verb / Adjective + Preposition Pairs (memorise)

Verb / Adjective	Preposition	Example
accuse	of	She accused him of lying.
congratulate / compliment / decide	on	I congratulated her on the win.
differ	from / with / on	A differs from B [things] · A differs with B [people] · A differs on the issue.
consist	of	The team consists of 11 players.
comprise	(no prep)	The team comprises 11 players.
insist / depend / rely / concentrate / impose	on	Insist on quality.
prevent / suffer / refrain / abstain / prohibit	from	He suffers from asthma.
die	of (disease) / for (cause) / from (exhaustion / wound) / by (instrument)	died of cancer · died for the country.
superior / inferior / junior / senior / prior / prefer	to	She is junior to me.
married / engaged	to	He is engaged to her.
afraid / aware / capable / desirous / fond / proud / sick / tired	of	I am fond of sweets.
acquainted	with	He is acquainted with the rules.
angry	with (person) / at (thing)	I am angry with him / at the noise.
good / bad / clever / expert	at	He is good at maths.
look	at / after / for / into / up / down on / forward to	Look after your sister.
invite	to	She invited me to the party.
listen	to	Listen to the teacher.
reply / respond	to	Reply to the email.
comply	with	Comply with the rules.
complain	about / to / of	Complain about the food to the manager.

5.3 Mini-PYQ Drill — Prepositions

- "He has been suffering ___ fever for three days." → **from** (suffer **from** an illness).
- "She is married ___ a businessman." → **to** (married **to**, never *with*).
- "The professor is well acquainted ___ his subject." → **with** (acquainted **with**).
- "He prefers tea ___ coffee." → **to** (prefer X **to** Y).
- "They live ___ Bangalore ___ 4th Cross Road." → **in / on** (in city, on street).

Carry-forward principle: prepositions are memorised, not derived. Drill the top-20 pairs above to instinct level.

PART 6 — CONJUNCTIONS

6.0 Correlative Conjunction Formula Table

Pair	Formula	Example	Trap
Either ... or	Either [X] or [Y] — verb agrees with Y	"Either tea or coffee is fine."	Verb with X, not Y
Neither ... nor	Neither [X] nor [Y] — verb agrees with Y	"Neither he nor they were present."	Adding "not": "not neither"
Both ... and	Both [X] and [Y] — always plural verb	"Both Ram and Shyam are here."	Using "both ... as well as" (redundant)
Not only ... but also	Not only [X] but also [Y] — X and Y same part of speech	"She is not only intelligent but also hardworking." (both adj.)	Mixing "not only plays cricket but also a teacher" (verb ≠ noun)
Whether ... or	Whether [X] or [Y]	"I don't know whether he agrees or not."	Adding "if" before whether
No sooner ... than	No sooner + had + S + V3 + than + S + V2	" No sooner had I arrived than it rained."	Using "when" instead of "than"
Scarcely / Hardly ... when	Hardly/Scarcely + had + S + V3 + when + S + V2	" Hardly had he left when she called."	Using "than" instead of "when"
Rather ... than	Rather [X] than [Y]	"I would rather walk than drive."	"rather ... then" (then ≠ than)
Lest ... should	Lest + S + should + V1	"Run fast lest you should miss the bus."	Using "may / will / can" with lest
Unless (= if not)	Unless + S + V1 — never add "not"	" Unless you study, you will fail."	"Unless you don't study" (double negative)
Though / Although ... (yet)	Though + clause, (yet) clause — never "but"	" Though rich, he is unhappy."	"Though rich, but unhappy" (redundant)
Such ... that	Such + a/an + adj + noun + that + clause	"It was such a hot day that we stayed indoors."	"such ... as" (wrong for consequence)
So ... that	So + adj/adv + that + clause	"He ran so fast that he won."	"so ... as" (wrong for consequence)

Types

1. **Coordinating** (FANBOYS — for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so) — connect equals.
2. **Subordinating** — introduce dependent clauses (because, although, since, unless, until, while).
3. **Correlative pairs** — see table above.
4. **Parallelism** — correlatives must connect same parts of speech.
5. **"Lest" + should/subjunctive** — "Run fast lest you **should** miss the bus."
6. **"Unless"** = "if not" — never add "not" after unless.
7. **"Scarcely/hardly ... when"; "no sooner ... than"**.

6.1 Worked Examples — Conjunction Error Spotting

Diagnostic questions: 1. Are the two halves linked by a **coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS)** or by a **correlative pair**? 2. If correlative — do both halves connect the **same part of speech / same grammatical form** (parallelism)? 3. Is the connector itself correct (no "than" instead of "when", no extra "not" after "unless", no "but" after "though")?

Example 1 — Parallelism with correlatives. *"She is not only intelligent but also works hard."*

Step 1. Correlative pair: "not only ... but also". **Step 2.** First half "intelligent" = **adjective**. Second half "works hard" = **verb phrase**. **Not parallel.** **Step 3.** Fix by making both halves the same part of speech.

Corrected: *"She is not only intelligent but also hard-working."* (both adjectives) OR *"She not only is intelligent but also works hard."* (both verb phrases)

Example 2 — "No sooner ... than" (NOT "when"). *"No sooner did he enter the room when the lights went out."*

Step 1. Connector: "no sooner". Its correlative partner is **"than"**, never *when*. **Step 2.** Same trap exists for "scarcely / hardly ... **when**" (NOT *than*), and "rather ... than".

Corrected: *"No sooner did he enter the room than the lights went out."*

Memory map: - No sooner ... than - Scarcely / Hardly ... when - Rather ... than - Such ... as (NOT than) - Such ... that (consequence)

Example 3 — "Unless" already means "if not". *"Unless you don't study hard, you will fail."*

Step 1. "Unless" = "if not". Adding *don't* creates a double negative. **Step 2.** Drop the *don't*.

Corrected: *"Unless you study hard, you will fail."* (Equivalent to *"If you don't study hard, you will fail."*)

Example 4 — "Though ... yet" (NOT "but"). *"Though he is rich, but he is unhappy."*

Step 1. "Though" already establishes the contrast. Adding "but" creates a redundant double-conjunction. **Step 2.** Two valid fixes: drop "but" (use just "though"), OR pair "though" with **"yet"** (formal).

Corrected: *"Though he is rich, he is unhappy."* OR *"Though he is rich, yet he is unhappy."* (formal/literary)

Same rule: "Although ... yet" ✓ (or drop the second conjunction); never "although ... but".

Example 5 — "Lest" + should (subjunctive). *"Run fast lest you may miss the bus."*

Step 1. "Lest" = "for fear that / in order that not". It is **always followed by should** (the subjunctive). Never *may*, *will*, or *can*.

Corrected: *"Run fast lest you should miss the bus."*

6.2 Conjunction Pairings & Common Traps — Quick Reference

Conjunction / Pair	Correct usage	Common error
Either / Or	"Either A or B" — verb agrees with closer noun	Using "either" with more than two options
Neither / Nor	"Neither A nor B" — verb agrees with closer noun	Adding "not" ("not neither")
Not only / But also	Both halves must be same part of speech	Mixing adjective + verb phrase
No sooner / than	"No sooner had X happened than Y..."	Using <i>when</i> instead of <i>than</i>

Conjunction / Pair	Correct usage	Common error
Scarcely / when ; Hardly / when	Same structure, but <i>when</i>	Using <i>than</i>
Both / And	"Both A and B" — never "Both A as well as B"	Using "as well as" with "both"
Whether / Or	"Whether A or B" — never "Whether A or not B" with that structure	Adding "if" before whether
Though / Although	Can stand alone OR pair with yet	Using "but" with though/although
Lest	Always with should	Using <i>may</i> / <i>will</i> / <i>can</i>
Unless	Means "if not" — never add <i>not</i> in the if-clause	"Unless you don't..." (double negative)
As soon as / As long as	Sequence / duration	Confusing the two
Since / For	"Since" + point in time (since 2010); "For" + duration (for 5 years)	Swapping them

6.3 Mini-PYQ Drill — Conjunctions

- "He is ___ rich ___ generous." → **both / and** (parallel adjectives).
- "___ he is honest, ___ he is poor." → **Though / yet** (or *Though / (nothing)* — but never "though / but").
- "Walk carefully ___ you slip." → **lest you should slip** (lest + should).
- "He had ___ entered the hall ___ the bell rang." → **scarcely / when** (NOT *than*).
- "___ he is poor, he is happy." → **Although / Though** (drop "but" if you add one).

Carry-forward principle: conjunctions are about which partner pairs with which (no sooner ↔ *than*, scarcely ↔ *when*, lest ↔ *should*). The single most-tested trap is using the wrong partner.

PART 7 — VOICE (ACTIVE ↔ PASSIVE)

7.0 Opener

KEY FACT

✂ **SHORTCUT — Active → Passive in 3 steps:** 1. **Object of active** → **Subject of passive**. 2. **Verb** → **be + V3** (match the *be*-form to the original tense: is/was/has been/will be...). 3. **Subject of active** → **"by + agent"** at the end (drop "by people/someone" when agent is obvious).

Pronoun shift: I → me, we → us, he → him, she → her, they → them.

Voice tells us whether the **subject acts** (active) or **is acted upon** (passive). All passive constructions share one universal skeleton — once you internalise it, every "transform from active to passive" question becomes a 10-second mechanical exercise.

FORMULA

Universal active → passive rule:

1. **Object of active** → **subject of passive**.
2. **Verb** becomes **be + V3 (past participle)** — *be* must match the tense of the original verb.
3. **Subject of active** → "**by + agent**" at the end (or omitted when obvious / unknown).
4. **Pronouns** shift case: I → me, he → him, she → her, we → us, they → them.

Tense check: the form of *be* is the only thing that changes by tense; the main verb is always **V3**.
Memorise the 12 *be*-forms below and you have memorised the entire passive system.

7.0a Active ↔ Passive Master Formula Grid

Read **row × column** (e.g. Past Continuous = row 2 × column 2). Each cell shows the **Active** formula above and the **Passive** transformation below — with a worked pair.

Aspect ↓ \ Time →	PRESENT	PAST	FUTURE
SIMPLE	A: sub + V1 + obj "She writes a letter." P: obj + is/am/are + V3 + by + sub "A letter is written by her."	A: sub + V2 + obj "She wrote a letter." P: obj + was/were + V3 + by + sub "A letter was written by her."	A: sub + will + V1 + obj "She will write a letter." P: obj + will be + V3 + by + sub "A letter will be written by her."
CONTINUOUS	A: sub + is/am/are + V1+ing + obj "She is writing a letter." P: obj + is/am/are + being + V3 + by + sub "A letter is being written by her."	A: sub + was/were + V1+ing + obj "She was writing a letter." P: obj + was/were + being + V3 + by + sub "A letter was being written by her."	A: sub + will be + V1+ing + obj "She will be writing a letter." P: (future continuous has no standard passive — rephrase as Simple Future passive)
PERFECT	A: sub + has/have + V3 + obj "She has written a letter." P: obj + has/have been + V3 + by + sub "A letter has been written by her."	A: sub + had + V3 + obj "She had written a letter." P: obj + had been + V3 + by + sub "A letter had been written by her."	A: sub + will have + V3 + obj "She will have written a letter." P: obj + will have been + V3 + by + sub "A letter will have been written by her."
PERFECT CONTINUOUS	(no standard passive — rephrase)	(no standard passive — rephrase)	(no standard passive — rephrase)

Mechanical rule: **be + V3** is the spine of every passive cell. The form of **be** (*is/was/will be/has been/had been/will have been/being*) tracks the tense; the main verb is **always V3**. If you can spot the *be*-form needed for a tense, the passive writes itself.

Worked transformation in 3 steps:

Step	Operation	Example: "She has written a letter."
1	Object of active → subject of passive	A letter ...
2	Replace verb with be + V3 (matching tense — Present Perfect → <i>has been</i>)	A letter has been written ...

Step	Operation	Example: "She has written a letter."
3	Subject of active → by + agent at the end	A letter has been written by her . ✓

7.1 The 12-tense active → passive transformation table

#	Tense	Active form	Passive form	Worked pair
1	Simple Present	S + V1/Vs + O	S + is/am/are + V3	<i>He writes a letter. → A letter is written by him.</i>
2	Present Continuous	S + is/am/are + V-ing + O	S + is/am/are + being + V3	<i>She is writing a letter. → A letter is being written by her.</i>
3	Present Perfect	S + has/have + V3 + O	S + has/have + been + V3	<i>They have written a letter. → A letter has been written by them.</i>
4	Present Perfect Cont.	—	No passive form (rephrase if needed)	—
5	Simple Past	S + V2 + O	S + was/were + V3	<i>He wrote a letter. → A letter was written by him.</i>
6	Past Continuous	S + was/were + V-ing + O	S + was/were + being + V3	<i>She was writing a letter. → A letter was being written by her.</i>
7	Past Perfect	S + had + V3 + O	S + had + been + V3	<i>They had written a letter. → A letter had been written by them.</i>
8	Past Perfect Cont.	—	No passive form	—
9	Simple Future	S + will + V1 + O	S + will + be + V3	<i>He will write a letter. → A letter will be written by him.</i>
10	Future Continuous	—	No passive form	—
11	Future Perfect	S + will + have + V3 + O	S + will + have + been + V3	<i>They will have written the letter. → The letter will have been written by them.</i>
12	Future Perfect Cont.	—	No passive form	—

KEY FACT

The four passive-only "be" forms to memorise

Aspect	Passive auxiliary stack	Memory peg
Simple	be + V3	"be done"
Continuous	be + being + V3	"is being done"
Perfect	have + been + V3	"has been done"
Modal	modal + be + V3	"can be done", "must be done", "should be done"

7.2 Special structures

FORMULA

Modal verbs — S + modal + **be** + V3.

Active	Passive
can write	can be written
could write	could be written
may write	may be written
might write	might be written
must write	must be written
should / ought to write	should / ought to be written
have to write	have to be written
used to write	used to be written

FORMULA

Imperatives

- **Order:** *Open the door.* → *Let the door be opened.*
- **Negative order:** *Do not shut the gate.* → *Let the gate not be shut.* / *The gate must not be shut.*
- **Request:** *Please help me.* → *You are requested to help me.*
- **Advice:** *Always speak the truth.* → *The truth should always be spoken.* / *You are advised to speak the truth.*

FORMULA

Interrogatives — invert the auxiliary

- **Yes/No (present):** *Is she writing the letter?* → *Is the letter being written by her?*
- **Yes/No (past):** *Did he break the cup?* → *Was the cup broken by him?*
- **Wh-(who as subject):** *Who broke the cup?* → *By whom was the cup broken?*
- **Wh-(who as object):** *Whom did he meet?* → *Who was met by him?*
- **Wh-(what / when / where / why / how):** keep the question word at the front; rest follows the standard rule. *What did she say?* → *What was said by her?*

FORMULA

Verbs with two objects (di-transitive: give, send, offer, tell, pay, lend, teach, show)

Either object can become the passive subject; the preferred form puts the **person** first.

- Active: *She gave him a gift.*
- Passive (person-as-subject — usual): *He was given a gift by her.*
- Passive (thing-as-subject — formal): *A gift was given to him by her.* (note the added **to**)

FORMULA

Quasi-passive / stative passives — verbs of perception with a bare infinitive in active take **to-infinitive** in passive.

- *She saw him leave.* → *He was seen to leave by her.*
- *They made him work.* → *He was made to work by them.*
- *People believe him to be honest.* → *He is believed to be honest.*

FORMULA

Impersonal passive ("It is said that ..." / "He is said to ...") — high-frequency in error spotting.

Two patterns for verbs of saying/thinking/believing (say, think, believe, know, report, expect, consider, allege, claim, suppose):

Pattern	Formula	Example
Pattern 1 — "It" as dummy subject	It + is/was + V3 + that + clause	<i>"It is said that he is an expert."</i>
Pattern 2a — Subject raised (same time)	S + is/was + V3 + to + V1	<i>"He is said to be an expert."</i>
Pattern 2b — Subject raised (different time)	S + is/was + V3 + to + have + V3	<i>"He is said to have studied abroad."</i> (past action reported now)

More pairs:

- *"People say that she is brilliant."* → *"It is said that she is brilliant."* / *"She is said to be brilliant."*
- *"People believe that he stole the money."* → *"It is believed that he stole the money."* / *"He is believed to have stolen the money."*
- *"People expected that she would win."* → *"It was expected that she would win."* / *"She was expected to win."*

COMMON TRAP

When the embedded clause has a **different time** from the reporting verb, use the **perfect infinitive** in Pattern 2:

- *"People say that he **studied** abroad."* → *"He is said to have studied abroad."* (past action reported in present → "have + V3")

FORMULA

Sentences with no direct object (intransitive verbs) cannot be made passive.

- *He runs.* — no object → **no passive.**
- *They arrived.* — no object → **no passive.**

7.3 Worked examples — 5 full transformations

Example 1 — Simple Past (yes/no question)

Active: "Did the chef prepare the dinner?"

1. Identify object → "the dinner" → becomes passive subject.
2. Tense = simple past + question → start with **Was/Were** + new subject.
3. Verb "prepare" → past participle = **prepared**.
4. Original subject "the chef" → "by the chef".
5. **Passive:** *Was the dinner prepared by the chef?*

Example 2 — Modal of obligation

Active: "Students must submit the assignments by Friday."

1. Object → "the assignments" → passive subject.
2. Modal "must" + active verb → passive form = **must be + V3**.
3. "submit" → past participle = **submitted**.
4. Agent "Students" — often omitted because audience is obvious.
5. **Passive:** *The assignments must be submitted by Friday (by students).*

Example 3 — Imperative (negative command)

Active: "Don't park your vehicle here."

1. Negative imperative → use **Let ... not be + V3** OR **must not be + V3**.
2. Object "your vehicle" → passive subject.
3. **Passive:** *Let your vehicle not be parked here. / Your vehicle must not be parked here.*

Example 4 — Present Perfect with di-transitive verb

Active: "The principal has awarded Riya a scholarship."

1. Two objects: "Riya" (indirect / person) and "a scholarship" (direct / thing).
2. Tense = present perfect → **has/have been + V3**.
3. **Passive (person as subject):** *Riya has been awarded a scholarship by the principal.*
4. **Passive (thing as subject):** *A scholarship has been awarded to Riya by the principal.*

Example 5 — Wh-question (Future Simple)

Active: "Who will deliver the keynote address?"

1. "Who" = subject of active; object = "the keynote address" → passive subject.
2. Future passive form → **will be + V3**.
3. "deliver" → past participle = **delivered**.
4. **Passive:** *By whom* will the keynote address be delivered*?*

7.4 Common pitfalls

COMMON TRAP

Voice-conversion trap list

- **Continuous + Perfect mix** is wrong. Active "has been writing" has **no passive form**; rephrase as *The letter has been (being) written for an hour* → use simple perfect passive: *The letter has been written***.
- **By + agent** is dropped when the agent is unknown or obvious: *English is spoken in Singapore* (no "by people"). Don't add "by people / by everybody".
- **"Let me do it"** — the let-construction passive is *Let it be done by me* (not "Let it do by me").
- **Verbs with no object** (intransitive: arrive, fall, sleep, die, run, come, go) → cannot be made passive. A sentence like "He was died" is **wrong** — die is intransitive.
- **Cognate objects** (sang a song, ran a race) — usually keep voice in active; the forced passive sounds unnatural.
- **Pronoun case** must change: *I* → *me*, *we* → *us*, *he* → *him*, *she* → *her*, *they* → *them*. "It was painted by **he**" ✗ → "by **him**" ✓.

7.5 Mini-PYQ drill — Voice

EXAM QUESTION

Q1 (SSC CGL). Choose the correct passive form of: "They are repairing the road near the school."

- (a) The road near the school is repaired by them.
- (b) The road near the school is being repaired.
- (c) The road near the school was being repaired.
- (d) The road near the school has been repaired.

Ans: (b). Present continuous active → **is/are being + V3**.

EXAM QUESTION

Q2 (IBPS PO). Convert to passive: "Somebody has stolen my purse."

- (a) My purse has stolen.
- (b) My purse was stolen by somebody.
- (c) My purse has been stolen.
- (d) My purse is being stolen.

Ans: (c). Present perfect active → **has been + V3**; "by somebody" is dropped because agent is unknown.

EXAM QUESTION

Q3 (SSC CHSL). Choose the active form of: "By whom was this novel written?"

- (a) Who wrote this novel? (b) Who has written this novel?
- (c) Who is writing this novel? (d) Whom did this novel write?

Ans: (a). Passive "was written" = simple past passive → active is simple past with **who** as subject.

EXAM QUESTION

Q4 (SBI Clerk). Choose the correct passive form: "Please open the door."

- (a) The door is opened please.
- (b) Let the door be opened please.
- (c) You are requested to open the door.
- (d) Both (b) and (c) are correct.

Ans: (d). Both forms are accepted — Let-construction for imperatives and "You are requested to ..." for polite requests.

EXAM QUESTION

Q5 (RRB NTPC). Convert to passive: "The committee will announce the results tomorrow."

- (a) The results are announced by the committee tomorrow.
- (b) The results will announce by the committee tomorrow.
- (c) The results will be announced by the committee tomorrow.
- (d) The results have been announced by the committee.

Ans: (c). Simple future passive → will be + V3.

KEY FACT

Voice — exam recall card

1. Universal rule: **Object → Subject; Verb → be + V3; Subject → by + agent.**
2. Match the **be-form** to the original tense: is/are, was/were, has/have been, will be, can be ...
3. **Continuous passives** add a single **being** (is being written, was being written).
4. **Perfect passives** add a single **been** (has been written, had been written, will have been written).
5. **Modals** always insert **be** between modal and V3 (can be written, must be written).
6. **Imperatives** → "Let ... be + V3" or "You are requested/advised to ...".
7. **Di-transitive verbs** allow two passive forms; prefer the **person-first** version.
8. **Continuous-perfect tenses and intransitive verbs** have **no passive**.

PART 8 — DIRECT ↔ INDIRECT SPEECH (NARRATION)

8.0 Opener

KEY FACT

✂ **SHORTCUT — Narration Reporting-Verb Tense Rules (compact table):**

Reporting verb tense	Reported tense rule	Example
Past (said, told, asked)	Back - shift tense ONE step	"I write" → he said he wrote
Present (says, tells)	NO change to reported tense	"I write" → he says he writes
Universal truth / fact	NEVER back - shift	"Earth revolves" → he said Earth revolves

Sentence-type linker chain: Statement → **that** · Yes/No Q → **if/whether** · Wh-Q → **same wh-word** · Order → **to + V1** · Suggestion → **should + V1**

Direct speech quotes the exact words inside inverted commas; **indirect (reported) speech** reframes those words through the speaker's voice. Every narration question tests four mechanical shifts in sequence — once you drill them in this fixed order, the answer falls out:

FORMULA

The four-step narration conversion (memorise the sequence):

1. **Reporting verb** — choose the right verb for the sentence type (said / asked / ordered / requested / exclaimed / advised).
2. **Linker** — pick the correct linker after the reporting verb (**that, if/whether, to + V1, not to + V1, wh-word**).
3. **Tense back-shift** — if the reporting verb is in the **past**, shift the reported tense one step further back.
4. **Time / place / pronoun shift** — convert proximal words (this, here, now) to distal (that, there, then) and adjust pronouns to the reporter's perspective.

Golden exception — universal-truth rule: if the reported clause states a permanent fact, a habit, or a universal truth, **do NOT back-shift the tense** even when the reporting verb is past. He said, "The earth revolves around the sun." → He said that the earth revolves around the sun. (not "revolved")

8.0a Direct ↔ Indirect Speech Master Tense Grid (when reporting verb is PAST)

Read **row × column** — e.g. "What does 'Past Continuous' in direct become in indirect?" Look at row 2 × column 2 → **Past Perfect Continuous**.

Aspect ↓ \ Time → in direct	PRESENT (direct) → indirect	PAST (direct) → indirect	FUTURE (direct) → indirect
SIMPLE	Simple Present → Simple Past "I write " → ... that he wrote	Simple Past → Past Perfect "I wrote " → ... that he had written	will/shall + V1 → would/should + V1 "I will write " → ... that he would write
CONTINUOUS	Present Continuous → Past Continuous "I am writing " → ... that he was writing	Past Continuous → Past Perfect Continuous "I was writing " → ... that he had been writing	will be + V1+ing → would be + V1+ing "I will be writing " → ... that he would be writing
PERFECT	Present Perfect → Past Perfect "I have written " → ... that he had written	Past Perfect → no change (already farthest back) "I had written " → ... that he had written	will have + V3 → would have + V3 "I will have written " → ... that he would have written
PERFECT CONTINUOUS	Pres Perf Continuous → Past Perf Continuous "I have been writing " → ... that he had been writing	Past Perf Continuous → no change "I had been writing " → ... that he had been writing	will have been + V1+ing → would have been + V1+ing

One sentence to internalise: each tense shifts **one step further into the past** when the reporting verb is past — except when there is nowhere further to go (Past Perfect / Past Perfect Continuous stay as-is).

8.0b Modal back-shift (single line each)

In direct	In indirect	Example
will / shall	would / should	"I will come" → he said that he would come
can	could	"I can swim" → he said that he could swim
may	might	"I may go" → he said that he might go
must (obligation)	had to	"I must leave" → he said that he had to leave
must (logical deduction)	must (no change)	"He must be tired" → she said that he must be tired
ought to	ought to (no change)	"You ought to rest" → she said that I ought to rest
should	should (no change)	"We should start" → he said that we should start

8.0c Time- & place-expression shift (proximal → distal)

Direct	→	Indirect
now	→	then
today	→	that day
tomorrow	→	the next day / the following day
yesterday	→	the previous day / the day before
last week / month / year	→	the previous week / month / year
next week / month / year	→	the following week / month / year
ago	→	before
here	→	there
this / these	→	that / those
hither	→	thither
thus	→	so
come	→	go
bring	→	take

8.0d Pronoun-shift rule — SON

Position in direct	Becomes in indirect
Subject pronoun (I, we)	matches the reporting - clause subject (he, she, they)
Object pronoun (you)	matches the reporting - clause object (me, him, her, us, them)
Neither category (he, she, it, they)	no change

One-line example: "I met you yesterday," he said to her. → He said to her that he had met her the previous day. (I→he matches the reporter "he"; you→her matches the listener "her"; yesterday→the previous day.)

8.1 Reporting-verb selection by sentence type

Sentence type in direct speech	Reporting verb in indirect	Linker
Statement (assertive)	said / told / replied / remarked / declared	that
Yes/No question	asked / enquired / wanted to know	if / whether
Wh-question	asked / enquired / wondered	the same wh-word (what, when, why, ...)
Order / command	ordered / commanded / told	to + V1
Negative order	forbade / told ... not to	not to + V1
Request	requested / begged	to + V1
Advice	advised / urged / counselled	to + V1
Suggestion	suggested / proposed	that + S + should + V1 OR V-ing
Warning	warned / cautioned	not to + V1 / that
Exclamation (joy)	exclaimed with joy	that
Exclamation (sorrow)	exclaimed with sorrow	that
Exclamation (surprise)	exclaimed with surprise / wonder	that
Salutation / greeting	wished / greeted / bade	that / a good morning, etc.

COMMON TRAP

said vs told — non-negotiable rule

- **said** is followed by **that** (or nothing), with **no listener**: *He said that he was tired.*
- **told** always takes a **direct listener (me, him, her, them)**: *He told me that he was tired.*
- **X** *He said me that ...* and **X** *He told that ...* are both wrong.

8.2 Tense back-shift table — direct → indirect (when reporting verb is past)

Direct (inside quotes)	Indirect (in reported clause)
Simple Present — <i>writes</i>	Simple Past — <i>wrote</i>
Present Continuous — <i>is writing</i>	Past Continuous — <i>was writing</i>
Present Perfect — <i>has/have written</i>	Past Perfect — <i>had written</i>
Present Perfect Continuous — <i>has/have been writing</i>	Past Perfect Continuous — <i>had been writing</i>
Simple Past — <i>wrote</i>	Past Perfect — <i>had written</i>
Past Continuous — <i>was writing</i>	Past Perfect Continuous — <i>had been writing</i>
Past Perfect — <i>had written</i>	Past Perfect — <i>had written</i> (no further change)
will / shall	would / should
can	could
may	might
must (obligation)	had to
must (deduction / universal)	must (no change)
shall (advice)	should
ought to / used to / could / would / might / should	no change

KEY FACT

When NOT to back-shift the tense

- The reported clause states a **universal truth** or **scientific fact**.
- The reported clause states a **habitual / still-true action**: *She said that she lives in Delhi* (and still lives there).
- The reported clause refers to a **historical date / fixed past event**: *He said that India became independent in 1947*.
- The **reporting verb is in present or future** (says / will say / has said) — the reported tense **stays unchanged**. *He says, "I am tired."* → *He says (that) he is tired*.

8.3 Pronoun shift table

Direct pronoun	Indirect — depends on subject of reporting verb
I / my / me / mine	shifts to match the subject of the reporting verb (he/his/him, she/her, etc.)
we / our / us / ours	shifts to match the subject (they/their/them)
you / your / yours	shifts to match the object (listener) of the reporting verb (he/she/they)
he / she / it / they / their	no change — already third person

Easy mnemonic — SON rule:

- **S**ubject of reporting verb tells you what to do with **I / we**.
- **O**bject of reporting verb tells you what to do with **you**.
- **N**o change for the rest (third-person pronouns and proper nouns).

Example: *Ram said to Sita, "I will help you."* → *Ram = subject* → "*I*" → "*he*". *Sita = object* → "*you*" → "*her*". **Result:** *Ram told Sita that he would help her.*

8.4 Time and place expression changes

Direct word	Indirect word
now	then
today	that day
tonight	that night
yesterday	the previous day / the day before
tomorrow	the next day / the following day
last week / month / year	the previous week / month / year
next week / month / year	the following week / month / year
this (adjective)	that
these	those
here	there
hither	thither

Direct word	Indirect word
hence	thence
ago	before
just now	at that moment
thus	so / in that way

COMMON TRAP

Don't blindly mechanise — if "here" still refers to the place where the reporter is speaking, keep "here".
He told me here that he was leaving — fine if both speakers are still in the same place.

8.5 Sentence-type templates with full conversions

FORMULA

(a) Statement (assertive)

- **Pattern:** said/told (someone) + **that** + back-shifted reported clause.
- *Direct:* He said, "I am writing a novel."
- *Indirect:* He said that he was writing a novel.

FORMULA

(b) Yes/No question

- **Pattern:** asked/enquired + (object) + **if / whether** + S + V (statement order, no question mark).
- *Direct:* She said to me, "Are you coming with us?"
- *Indirect:* She asked me whether I was coming with them.

FORMULA

(c) Wh-question

- **Pattern:** asked/enquired + (object) + **wh-word** + S + V (statement order).
- *Direct:* He said to her, "Where do you live?"
- *Indirect:* He asked her where she lived.

FORMULA

(d) Imperative — order

- **Pattern:** ordered / told (object) + **to + V1**.
- *Direct:* The officer said to the constable, "Arrest the thief."
- *Indirect:* The officer ordered the constable to arrest the thief.

FORMULA

(e) Imperative — negative order

- **Pattern:** told (object) + **not to + V1** / forbade (object) **to + V1**.
- *Direct: Mother said to the child, "Don't play in the rain."*
- *Indirect: Mother told the child not to play in the rain. / Mother forbade the child to play in the rain.*

FORMULA

(f) Imperative — request / advice

- *Direct: He said to me, "Please pass the salt."*
- *Indirect: He requested me to pass the salt.*
- *Direct: The doctor said to him, "Quit smoking."*
- *Indirect: The doctor advised him to quit smoking.*

FORMULA

(g) Suggestion (with "Let us")

- *Direct: He said, "Let us go for a walk."*
- *Indirect: He suggested (to me) that we should go for a walk. / He proposed going for a walk.*

FORMULA

(h) Exclamation

- *Direct: She said, "How beautiful the sunset is!"*
- *Indirect: She exclaimed (with joy) that the sunset was very beautiful.*
- *Direct: He said, "Alas! I have lost my wallet."*
- *Indirect: He exclaimed (with sorrow) that he had lost his wallet.*

FORMULA

(i) Greeting / wish

- *Direct: He said to me, "Good morning."*
- *Indirect: He wished me a good morning.*
- *Direct: She said, "May you live long!"*
- *Indirect: She prayed that I might live long.*

8.6 Worked examples — 5 full conversions

Example 1 — Statement (multi-clause)

Direct: "Ravi said to his brother, 'I have completed my homework and I am going out to play now.'"

1. Reporting verb "said to" → with an explicit listener → use **told**.
2. Linker → **that** (statement).
3. Tense shift: "have completed" → "had completed"; "am going" → "was going". Modal-free.
4. Time/place: "now" → "then". Pronoun: "I" (= Ravi, subject) → "he"; "my" → "his".
5. **Indirect:** *Ravi told his brother that he had completed his homework and was going out to play then.*

Example 2 — Yes/No question

Direct: "The teacher said to Aman, 'Have you understood the lesson?'"

1. Reporting verb → **asked** (with object Aman).
2. Linker → **if / whether**.
3. Tense: "Have you understood" (present perfect) → "had understood" (past perfect).
4. Word order → switch from interrogative to declarative; drop the question mark.
5. Pronoun "you" → matches object Aman → "he".
6. **Indirect:** *The teacher asked Aman whether he had understood the lesson.*

Example 3 — Wh-question with universal-truth exception

Direct: "The teacher said, 'Why does the sun rise in the east?'"

1. Reporting verb → **asked / enquired**.
2. Linker → wh-word **why**.
3. Universal-truth exception → tense stays **present simple**.
4. Word order → declarative.
5. **Indirect:** *The teacher asked why the sun rises in the east.*

Example 4 — Imperative chain (positive + negative)

Direct: "The captain said to the players, 'Pass the ball quickly and don't lose your concentration.'"

1. Reporting verb → **told / ordered** (two parallel imperatives → may also use **asked them to ... and not to ...**).
2. Linker for the first imperative → **to + V1**; for the second → **not to + V1**.
3. **Indirect:** *The captain told the players to pass the ball quickly and not to lose their concentration.*

Example 5 — Exclamation with pronoun + time shift

Direct: "Riya said, 'Wow! What a lovely surprise this is for me today!'"

1. Reporting verb for joy → **exclaimed with joy / exclaimed in delight**.
2. Linker → **that**; reframe "Wow!" → "with joy".
3. Tense: "is" → "was".
4. Pronoun shift: "me" → "her". Time: "today" → "that day". "This" → "that".
5. **Indirect:** *Riya exclaimed with joy that that was a very lovely surprise for her that day.*

8.7 Pitfalls

COMMON TRAP

Top narration mistakes that cost easy marks

- **Forgetting back-shift after a past reporting verb.** *He said that he is tired* ✗ → *He said that he was tired* ✓.
- **Mechanical back-shift of a universal truth.** *He said that the earth revolved around the sun* ✗ → *keep revolves*.
- **Using "that" with a question.** Indirect questions take **if / whether / wh-word**, never "that".
- **Keeping inverted (interrogative) word order in indirect questions.** *He asked where was she going* ✗ → *He asked where **she was going* ✓.
- **Said / told confusion.** Said + that, told + (object) + that.
- **Imperatives with "that" instead of "to + V1".** *He told me that open the door* ✗ → *He told me to open the door* ✓.
- **Not changing modals.** "will → would", "can → could", "may → might", "must (obligation) → had to". "Must" stays only for logical deductions or universal truths.
- **Dropping the listener in imperatives.** Imperatives **must** have an explicit listener (told **him**, ordered **them**, requested **me**).

8.8 Mini-PYQ drill — Direct / Indirect speech

EXAM QUESTION

Q1 (SSC CGL). Choose the correct indirect form of: "He said to me, 'I have been waiting for you for an hour.'"

- (a) He told me that he has been waiting for me for an hour.
- (b) He told me that he had been waiting for me for an hour.
- (c) He said me that he was waiting for me for an hour.
- (d) He told that he had been waiting for me for an hour.

Ans: (b). Present perfect continuous → past perfect continuous; "said to me" → "told me"; "you" (= me, the listener) stays as "me".

EXAM QUESTION

Q2 (IBPS PO). Convert into indirect speech: "The teacher said, 'Honesty is the best policy.'"

- (a) The teacher said that honesty was the best policy.
- (b) The teacher said that honesty had been the best policy.
- (c) The teacher said that honesty is the best policy.
- (d) The teacher told that honesty is the best policy.

Ans: (c). Universal truth / proverb → tense remains **present simple**. (Some grammar books also accept (a); the strictly correct answer in competitive exams is the unchanged form.)

EXAM QUESTION

Q3 (SSC CHSL). Choose the indirect form: "She said to him, 'Where did you go yesterday?'"

- (a) She asked him where he went yesterday.

- (b) She asked him where he had gone the previous day.
(c) She told him where had he gone the day before.
(d) She enquired him that where he had gone yesterday.

Ans: (b). Wh-question → asked + wh-word; simple past → past perfect; "yesterday" → "the previous day"; statement word order.

EXAM QUESTION

Q4 (RRB NTPC). Choose the indirect form: "Mother said to the child, 'Don't go near the fire.'"

- (a) Mother told the child don't go near the fire.
(b) Mother told the child not to go near the fire.
(c) Mother said the child to not going near the fire.
(d) Mother forbade the child go near the fire.

Ans: (b). Negative imperative → told + (object) + not to + V1.

EXAM QUESTION

Q5 (SBI Clerk Mains). Choose the indirect form: "He said, 'Alas! I have failed in the exam.'"

- (a) He said that he has failed in the exam.
(b) He cried that he failed in the exam.
(c) He exclaimed with sorrow that he had failed in the exam.
(d) He exclaimed that alas he had failed.

Ans: (c). Exclamation expressing sorrow → "exclaimed with sorrow / regret that"; present perfect → past perfect.

EXAM QUESTION

Q6 (SSC MTS). Choose the indirect form: "He said to me, 'Will you help me with my project?'"

- (a) He asked me would I help him with his project.
(b) He asked me if I would help him with his project.
(c) He told me whether I will help him with his project.
(d) He requested that I would help him with my project.

Ans: (b). Yes/No question → asked + if/whether; "will" → "would"; "you" → "I"; "me/my" → "him/his".

KEY FACT

Narration — exam recall card

1. **Four-step routine:** reporting verb → linker → tense back-shift → time/place/pronoun shift.
2. **Said vs Told:** said + that; told + (object) + that.
3. **Linkers:** statement → that; Yes/No → if/whether; Wh- → wh-word; imperative → to/not-to + V1.
4. **Tense:** back-shift one step further into the past when reporting verb is past.
5. **No back-shift** for universal truths, habitual still-true facts, and historical dates.
6. **Modal map:** will→would, can→could, may→might, shall→should, must (obligation)→had to.
7. **Pronouns:** SON rule — Subject pronoun (I/we) matches reporting subject; Object pronoun (you) matches reporting object; No change for the rest.

8. **Indirect questions** use declarative word order — no question mark, no "do/does/did".

KEY FACT

✂ **SHORTCUT — Error Spotting 3-Step Scan:** For every underlined or split sentence, check in this fixed order: **(1) Subject-Verb Agreement** (find the real subject, ignore fillers) → **(2) Tense** (spot the time-signal word; does the verb match?) → **(3) Preposition** (check fixed verb-prep pairs). This order alone resolves ~80% of all error-spotting questions in SSC and Banks papers.

EXAM ALERT

⚠ **TRAP — Singular traps that fool everyone:** - **Either / Neither / Each / Every / None** → always singular verb. "*Either of the boys has ...*" not "have". - "**A number of**" → plural verb; "**The number of**" → singular verb. - **With / Along with / As well as / Besides** → verb agrees with the FIRST subject only, ignoring the added phrase.

Parts 1–8 gave you the rules. Parts 9–14 show you how examiners test those rules — each chapter is one question-type format with its own attack method. Work through them in order: the grammar you just drilled is directly applied here.

PART 9 — ERROR SPOTTING

9.0 Opener

The highest-frequency MCQ format. Sentence split into 4 parts (A, B, C, D); candidate picks the part with the error (or "No error").

Checklist (run in this order — catches 95 % of errors): 1. Subject-verb agreement (Part 3). 2. Tense consistency. 3. Pronoun agreement. 4. Preposition (Part 5). 5. Article (Part 4). 6. Parallelism in conjunctions (Part 6). 7. Redundancy (return back, repeat again, final outcome, true facts, past history). 8. Comparatives: "more better" ✗, "most strongest" ✗. 9. Gerund vs infinitive after specific verbs (enjoy + V-ing, decide + to-V, stop + V-ing vs stop + to-V).

Types (by error class)

1. **S-V agreement errors.**
2. **Tense errors.**
3. **Preposition errors.**
4. **Article errors.**
5. **Pronoun errors.**
6. **Redundancy.**
7. **Comparative / superlative misuse.**
8. **Conjunction / parallelism errors.**
9. **Gerund / infinitive misuse.**
10. **Misplaced modifier.**

Worked Example 1 (EASY — S-V agreement)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) The team of cricketers / (b) are practicing /
(c) in the field / (d) since morning.

Step 1. "Team" = collective noun, treated as singular.

Step 2. "Are" is plural verb form — should be "is".

Step 3. Error in part **(B)**: "are practicing" → should be "is practicing".

Worked Example 2 (MEDIUM — preposition)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) She is suffering / (b) from fever /
(c) since last / (d) Monday.

Step 1. Tense check: "since" implies continuing action → "has been suffering" (Present Perfect Continuous) is correct.

Step 2. Part (A) says "She is suffering" — Present Continuous. Should be "She has been suffering".

Step 3. Error in part **(A)**.

Worked Example 3 (HARD — gerund vs infinitive)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) He stopped / (b) to smoke /
(c) ten years ago / (d) on doctor's advice.

Step 1. "Stopped to + V" = paused IN ORDER to do something. "Stopped + V-ing" = gave up the habit.

Step 2. Context: "ten years ago on doctor's advice" implies giving up the habit, not pausing.

Step 3. Error in part **(B)**: "to smoke" → should be "smoking".

Worked Example 4 (HARD — parallelism)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) The new manager / (b) is honest, hardworking /
(c) and a man of integrity / (d) which everyone admires.

Step 1. "Honest" and "hardworking" are adjectives. "A man of integrity" is a noun phrase — breaks parallelism.

Step 2. Should be three parallel adjectives or three parallel noun phrases.

Step 3. Error in part **(C)**: should be "and has integrity" or restructure to noun phrases.

Worked Example 5 (tense consistency)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) When he reached the station / (b) the train already /
(c) has left / (d) the platform.

Step 1. "When he reached" is **simple past**. An action completed *before* that past action needs **past perfect**.

Step 2. "has left" is present perfect — wrong tense sequence. **Step 3.** Error in **(C)**: "has left" → "**had left**".

Worked Example 6 (pronoun case)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) The teacher distributed / (b) the sweets /
(c) between / (d) you and I.

Step 1. After a preposition ("between"), pronouns take the **objective case**. **Step 2.** "I" is subjective; needs to be **me**. **Step 3.** Error in **(D)**: "you and I" → **"you and me"**.

Worked Example 7 (article)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) He is / (b) an honest and /
(c) a intelligent / (d) young man.

Step 1. Article choice is by **sound**. "Intelligent" begins with a vowel sound → needs **an**. **Step 2.** "a intelligent" is wrong. **Step 3.** Error in **(C)**: "a intelligent" → **"an intelligent"**.

Worked Example 8 (redundancy)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) He returned back / (b) to his hometown /
(c) after / (d) ten long years.

Step 1. "Return" already means "come back" — adding "back" is redundant. **Step 2.** Same trap family: *repeat again, revert back, final outcome, true facts, past history, free gift*. **Step 3.** Error in **(A)**: "returned back" → **"returned"**.

Worked Example 9 (comparative / superlative)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) Of the two sisters / (b) Meena is /
(c) the most intelligent / (d) and hardworking.

Step 1. Comparing **two** things uses the **comparative** ("more intelligent" / "the more intelligent"), not the superlative. **Step 2.** "the most intelligent" is wrong for two people. **Step 3.** Error in **(C)**: "the most intelligent" → **"the more intelligent"**.

Worked Example 10 (misplaced modifier)

Q. Spot the error:

- (a) Walking down the road / (b) a snake /
(c) was seen by him / (d) near the gate.

Step 1. "Walking down the road" must modify the person doing the walking — but the sentence attaches it to "a snake" (snakes don't walk down roads). This is a **dangling/misplaced modifier**. **Step 2.** The subject of the main clause should be the walker (he), not the snake. **Step 3.** Error in **(B)/(C)**: restructure to *"...he saw a snake near the gate."* (The modifier must sit next to the noun it describes.)

10-type scan order (run on every error-spotting question): Verb-agreement → Tense → Pronoun → Preposition → Article → Parallelism → Redundancy → Comparative → Gerund/Infinitive → Modifier. Stop at the first error you spot.

PART 10 — SENTENCE IMPROVEMENT / PHRASE REPLACEMENT

Similar to error spotting, but the candidate is given 4 replacements for an underlined phrase.

Method: identify what's wrong with the underlined part first (don't read options). Then pick the option that fixes the specific error without adding new ones.

10.1 Tips & Tricks

#	Trick	How to apply
1	Diagnose before reading options	Decide <i>what's wrong</i> with the underlined phrase (tense? agreement? preposition?) BEFORE looking at choices — stops option-bias.
2	"No improvement" is a real answer	If the underlined part is already correct, the answer is often "(d) No improvement / No correction required". Don't force a change.
3	Pick the minimum fix	The right option corrects the <i>specific</i> error and adds nothing new. Reject options that "improve" style but introduce a fresh error.
4	Run the 10-type scan	Same checklist as error spotting (tense, agreement, pronoun, preposition, article, parallelism, redundancy, comparative, gerund/infinite, modifier).
5	Watch for "double error" options	Some options fix the obvious error but break grammar elsewhere — read the <i>whole</i> replacement, not just the changed word.
6	Re-read with your choice plugged in	The corrected sentence must read naturally start-to-finish.

Common sentence-improvement sub-types: tense correction · subject-verb agreement · wrong preposition · article fix · double comparative · conditional (if-clause) · redundancy removal · idiom/phrasal-verb correction.

Worked Example 1 (EASY)

Q. Improve: "Neither of the boys *have* finished their homework." Options:

- (a) has finished his (b) have finished their
(c) had finished their (d) have finished his

Step 1. "Neither of" is always singular ⇒ verb must be **has** (singular).

Step 2. "Neither" is singular ⇒ pronoun also singular ⇒ **his**, not their.

Step 3. Answer: **(a) has finished his.**

Worked Example 2 (MEDIUM)

Q. Improve: "He was *more cleverer than* his brother." Options:

- (a) cleverer than (b) more clever than
(c) more cleverer than (d) cleverer then

Step 1. "More cleverer" is double comparative — incorrect.

Step 2. "Clever" forms comparative as "cleverer" (one syllable rule extended).

Step 3. Answer: **(a) cleverer than.**

Worked Example 3 (HARD)

Q. Improve: "If I *would have known* the truth, I would have helped you." Options:

- (a) had known (b) would have known
(c) have known (d) knew

Step 1. Conditional Type 3 form: **If + Past Perfect, would have + V3.**

Step 2. "Would have known" in IF clause is wrong; must be "had known".

Step 3. Answer: **(a) had known.**

PART 11 — CLOZE TEST

11.0 Opener

Passage with 5-10 blanks. Options per blank.

Method: 1. Read the whole passage once for sense — don't look at options. 2. For each blank, predict your own word/phrase from context. 3. Match options to your prediction. 4. Use trigger words: "however" → contrast; "moreover" → addition; "because" → cause.

Types

1. **Pure vocabulary** — synonym-level.
2. **Grammar + vocab mix** — article or preposition blanks alongside word blanks.
3. **New-age cloze** — each blank has 4-5 options that differ subtly.

11.1 Tips & Tricks to master Cloze (these win marks examples alone can't teach)

#	Trick	How to apply
1	Read the full passage first	Never solve blank-by-blank blind. The theme decides the tone (positive/negative) of every blank.
2	Predict before peeking	Cover the options, guess your own word, then pick the closest. Stops option-confusion.
3	Use the connector logic	"However / but / yet" → opposite idea follows. "Moreover / and / also" → same direction. "Because / since / as" → reason. "Therefore / thus" → result.
4	Match grammatical form	If the blank needs a noun, eliminate verb/adjective options instantly. Check what the surrounding words demand.
5	Collocation sense	Some words simply go together: "make a <i>decision</i> ", "take a <i>risk</i> ", "pay <i>attention</i> ", "meet a <i>deadline</i> ". Pick the natural pairing.
6	Preposition/article blanks	If a blank sits before a noun and options are <i>a/an/the/in/on/at</i> , it's a grammar blank — apply Part 4/Part 5 rules, not vocabulary.
7	Tone consistency	A passage praising something won't suddenly need a negative word, and vice-versa. Keep all blanks in the same emotional key.
8	Eliminate, don't guess	Cross out 2 clearly wrong options first; then decide between the remaining 2 using connector + collocation.
9	Don't leave the first blank if stuck	Solve the easy blanks first; the answers narrow the theme and make the hard blanks obvious on a second pass.

Worked Example — full cloze passage

Passage: Climate change is one of the greatest **(1)** facing humanity today. Rising global temperatures, melting glaciers, and **(2)** sea levels threaten ecosystems worldwide. While many governments have **(3)** to reduce carbon emissions, individual action is also **(4)**. Simple choices like using public transport or **(5)** energy at home can make a meaningful difference.

Options: 1.

(a) opportunities (b) challenges (c) decisions (d) policies 2.

(a) decreasing (b) rising (c) stable (d) shrinking 3.

(a) pledged (b) refused (c) hesitated (d) ignored 4.

(a) optional (b) crucial (c) irrelevant (d) unnecessary 5.

(a) wasting (b) conserving (c) ignoring (d) producing

Step 1. Blank 1: "greatest ___ facing humanity" — the verb "facing" implies something to overcome; "opportunities" would need "seizing", not "facing". "Challenges" is the correct negative noun that one *faces*. → **(b)**

Step 2. Blank 2: "melting glaciers and ___ sea levels" — the passage lists two warming effects in parallel; "decreasing/stable/shrinking" contradict a warming narrative. "Rising" continues that negative parallel. → **(b)**

Step 3. Blank 3: "governments have ___ to reduce emissions" — the present perfect + "to reduce" needs a verb of commitment or intent, not reluctance; "pledged" (= formally committed) is the only positive option. → **(a)**

Step 4. Blank 4: "individual action is also ___" — the next sentence says "Simple choices ... can make a meaningful difference", confirming strong importance, not weakness. "Crucial" (= absolutely necessary) matches that force; "optional / irrelevant / unnecessary" contradict it. → **(b)**

Step 5. Blank 5: "or ___ energy at home" — "or" links this to "using public transport", both presented as positive eco-actions; "wasting / ignoring / producing" are harmful or neutral. "Conserving" (= saving energy) is the only eco-positive choice. → **(b)**

Answers: 1-b, 2-b, 3-a, 4-b, 5-b.

PART 12 — READING COMPREHENSION (RC)

12.0 Opener

Passage length by exam (don't waste time on wrong passages in practice):

Exam	Typical passage length	Questions per passage
SSC CGL Tier 1 / CHSL / MTS	200–300 words	5–8
SSC CGL Tier 2 / CAPF	350–500 words	8–10
IBPS PO / SBI PO Prelims	350–500 words	5–10
IBPS PO / SBI PO Mains	600–800 words	10–15
RRB NTPC	150–250 words	4–6

Every well-formed RC set covers 4 question types (you will see these in every exam):

1. **Main-idea / title question** — tests whether you understood the passage as a whole.
2. **Inference question** — the answer is implied but not directly stated; one logical step beyond the text.
3. **Vocabulary-in-context question** — the word's meaning as used in the passage (not its dictionary definition).
4. **Tone / attitude question** — the author's emotional stance (critical, supportive, neutral, ironic, sarcastic, analytical).

Method (Stepwise): 1. **Skim** — get topic + structure in 30–60 s. Don't memorise; locate. 2. **Read questions next** — know what to hunt. 3. **Scan** the passage for the exact phrase / concept each question needs. 4. **Eliminate extremes** — answers with words like "always / never / entirely / only" are often traps. 5. **Pick the option closest to a paraphrase of what the passage LITERALLY says** — not what you infer further.

Question Types

1. **Main idea / title** — about the whole passage.

2. **Detail / fact** — a specific sentence supports this.
3. **Inference** — implied but not stated.
4. **Tone / attitude** — author's stance (critical / supportive / neutral / ironic).
5. **Vocabulary in context** — meaning of a word *as used here*.
6. **Synonym / antonym** drawn from passage.
7. **Structural** — purpose of paragraph 2.
8. **"Which of the following is NOT ..."** — watch the negative.

12.1 Tips & Tricks to master RC

#	Trick	How to apply
1	Questions before passage (for fact/detail Qs)	Read the questions first so you know what to hunt; then scan. Saves re-reading.
2	Topic sentence = first + last line	The main idea almost always lives in the opening or closing sentence of the passage / each paragraph.
3	Answer from the passage, not your knowledge	Even if you know more about the topic, pick only what the passage <i>states or implies</i> . Outside knowledge = trap.
4	Eliminate "extreme" options	Words like <i>always, never, only, entirely, must, all, none</i> are usually wrong for inference/main-idea questions.
5	Detail questions → locate the exact line	For "according to the passage..." questions, find the sentence and paraphrase. Never rely on memory.
6	Tone = adjectives the author chose	Positive adjectives → supportive/optimistic; negative → critical; balanced both sides → neutral/analytical.
7	Inference = one step beyond, not ten	The right inference is <i>directly supported</i> by a line. If you need a long chain of assumptions, it's wrong.
8	Vocabulary - in - context	Replace the word with each option in the sentence; pick the one that keeps the meaning identical.
9	"NOT/EXCEPT" questions	Three options are <i>in</i> the passage; one isn't. Tick the three you find; the leftover is the answer.
10	Manage time	If a passage is dense, answer the fact/detail questions (fast, locatable) first; leave inference/tone for last.

12.1a RC Trap Types — how examiners fool you (memorise these 4)

COMMON TRAP

Trap 1 — Paraphrase trap (most common) The passage says "X", and the correct answer says the same thing in different words. The wrong options quote the passage almost verbatim in a way that changes the meaning. - Passage: *"The scientist was sceptical of the new findings."* - Wrong option: *"The scientist rejected the new findings."* (too strong — sceptical ≠ rejected) - Right option: *"The scientist doubted the new findings."* (paraphrase of sceptical)

Rule: Paraphrase = same meaning, different words. If an option uses the exact words of the passage but adds "only", "never", "always", "entirely" — it is the trap.

COMMON TRAP

Trap 2 — Extreme-language trap Options that use extreme words (**always, never, only, entirely, all, none, must, completely**) for inference or main-idea questions are almost always wrong. Passages are usually nuanced. - Passage: *"Most students found the exam difficult."* - Wrong: *"All students found the exam difficult."* (extreme — most ≠ all) - Right: *"Many students found the exam difficult."* (matches the text)

COMMON TRAP

Trap 3 — Out-of-scope trap An option that sounds reasonable from general knowledge but is **not mentioned in the passage**. The test is always: is this in the text? - Passage about: impact of deforestation on climate. - Trap option: *"Deforestation affects river formation."* (may be true in reality but not stated here) - Rule: If you cannot point to the **exact sentence** in the passage that supports it, the option is out of scope.

COMMON TRAP

Trap 4 — Opposite-meaning trap An option that says the **exact reverse** of what the passage states. Examiners insert these for rushed readers. - Passage: *"The reforms strengthened the economy."* - Trap: *"The reforms weakened the economy."* - Rule: Always verify tone (positive/negative) of the relevant sentence before choosing.

Worked Example — short RC

Passage: *The rise of artificial intelligence has reshaped industries from healthcare to finance. While AI promises efficiency and innovation, it also raises concerns about job displacement and ethical use of personal data. Policymakers must balance encouraging innovation with protecting citizen rights. Critics argue current regulations lag behind technological progress, while industry leaders caution that overregulation could stifle growth. The debate, however, is no longer whether to regulate AI but how to do so effectively.*

Q1. What is the main idea?

- (a) AI's negative impact on jobs
- (b) The need for balanced AI regulation
- (c) Industry leaders' opinions on AI
- (d) Healthcare uses of AI

Step 1. Topic: AI regulation debate. Last line: "no longer whether to regulate AI but how to do so effectively" — the central tension.

Step 2. Option (a) too narrow; (c) too narrow; (d) is one example, not main idea.

Answer: (b).

Q2. What does the author imply about current regulations?

- (a) They are sufficient
- (b) They are excessive
- (c) They are slower than technology
- (d) They protect industry

Step 1. "Critics argue current regulations lag behind technological progress" → regulations are slower than tech.

Answer: (c).

Q3. The tone of the passage is:

- (a) Critical (b) Balanced (c) Optimistic (d) Sarcastic

Step 1. Both sides presented: efficiency vs concerns; critics vs industry leaders.

Step 2. No clear bias — balanced presentation.

Answer: (b).

PART 13 — PARA-JUMBLES (SENTENCE REARRANGEMENT)

13.0 Opener

5-6 sentences are jumbled; candidate must arrange in a logical order.

Method: 1. Find the **opening sentence** — usually introduces a concept, doesn't refer back. 2. Find **linkers** — "however, therefore, this, such, they" → refers to a previous sentence. 3. Find the **ending sentence** — conclusion, consequence. 4. Chain: who → does what → so what → consequence.

Common traps: a pronoun in Sentence B must follow its antecedent in Sentence A.

13.1 Tips & Tricks to master Para-jumbles

#	Trick	How to apply
1	Find the opener first	The opening sentence introduces the subject by full name/noun and never starts with a pronoun, "this/that/these", "however", "also", or a conjunction.
2	Noun → Pronoun rule	A sentence using "he / it / they / this / such" must come <i>after</i> the sentence that first names that person/thing. This single rule fixes most orderings.
3	Transition words signal position	"However / but" → contrast with previous. "Therefore / thus / hence" → result of previous. "For example" → follows a general statement. "Firstly... finally" → fixed sequence.
4	Time / logical sequence	Look for dates, "first/then/later/finally", or cause→effect chains and order accordingly.
5	Mandatory pairs	Some sentences obviously link (one raises a question, another answers it). Lock these pairs, then place the pair as a unit.
6	The conclusion sentence	Ends with a summary, a consequence, or words like "thus, in conclusion, as a result". Usually last.
7	Use the options to your advantage	If 3 of 4 options start with the same sentence, that's almost certainly the opener — verify and move on.
8	Article clue: a → the	A noun is introduced with " a/an " first, then referred to with " the " later. The "a" sentence precedes the "the" sentence.

Worked Example

Q. Arrange in logical order:

- (a) However, this revolution comes with its own challenges.
(b) The internet has fundamentally changed how we communicate.
(c) From email to instant messaging, distances have collapsed.
(d) Privacy concerns and information overload are key issues. (E) Society must develop new norms to address them.

Options: (1) BCADE (2) BACDE (3) BCDAE (4) BADCE

Step 1. Find the opener: (B) is the most general statement, no back-references. Opener = **B**.

Step 2. What follows logically? (C) elaborates on "changed how we communicate" because it gives a concrete example ("email to instant messaging") — this is the noun→example link. → BC.

Step 3. (A) starts with "However, this revolution" — "this revolution" must refer back to the internet revolution already named in B+C; "however" signals a contrast, so a complication (challenges) now enters. → BCA.

Step 4. (D) follows A because A introduced "challenges" as a general term and D gives the specifics ("privacy concerns and information overload") — general claim → specific instance. → BCAD.

Step 5. (E) "Society must develop new norms to address them" — "them" refers to the challenges in D. Concluding statement. → **BCADE**.

Answer: (1) BCADE.

PART 14 — FILL IN THE BLANKS

Single-blank, double-blank, triple-blank variants. Grammar- or vocab-driven.

- Double-blank: find the pair that works for BOTH blanks. Often the pair is syntactically parallel.

14.1 Tips & Tricks to master Fill-in-the-Blanks

#	Trick	How to apply
1	Read the whole sentence first	The blank's meaning depends on the <i>entire</i> sentence, not just the words around it. Identify the tone (positive/negative).
2	Spot the connector	"Although / despite / but" → the blank contrasts the rest. "And / moreover" → the blank agrees with the rest. Decide polarity before reading options.
3	Grammar blank vs vocab blank	If options are tenses/prepositions/articles → apply grammar rules. If options are synonyms → use meaning + collocation.
4	Double-blank: test BOTH	The correct option must fit both blanks. Eliminate any pair where even one word fails. Test the <i>easier</i> blank first to cut options fast.
5	Collocation memory	"strong <i>coffee</i> " not "powerful coffee"; "heavy <i>rain</i> ", "make a <i>mistake</i> ", "commit a <i>crime</i> ". Pick the natural partner.
6	Cause-effect & condition words	"so that, in order to, because, unless, if" tell you what logically belongs in the blank.
7	Eliminate extremes & off-tone words	A neutral sentence rarely needs an extreme word; a praising sentence won't take a negative word.
8	Plug & read aloud (mentally)	Put your chosen option in and re-read; the right answer <i>sounds</i> natural and keeps the grammar intact.

Worked Example 1 (single blank — grammar)

Q. Despite his hard work, he _____ in the exam.

- (a) succeed (b) succeeds (c) failed (d) wins

Step 1. "Despite" sets up contrast — expectation = success; reality = opposite.

Step 2. Past tense needed (sentence is reporting a result).

Answer: (c) failed.

Worked Example 2 (double blank — collocation)

Q. The committee __ **several recommendations** but the chairman ____ them.

- (a) made / accepted (b) suggested / rejected
(c) prepared / approved (d) put / ignored

Step 1. "But" signals contrast: committee's positive action vs chairman's negative.

Step 2. "Suggested" (positive) and "rejected" (negative) form the contrast pair.

Answer: (b) suggested / rejected.

Worked Example 3 (HARD — triple blank)

Q. The new policy was __ at first, but after extensive __, it gained ____.

(a) rejected / debate / acceptance (b) accepted / praise / momentum

(c) opposed / discussion / support (d) refused / argument / criticism

Step 1. "But" = contrast. First state (rejected/opposed) → final state (acceptance/support).

Step 2. Middle word fits "extensive ____" — debate or discussion.

Step 3. (a) "rejected" / "debate" / "acceptance" — flows logically. (c) "opposed" / "discussion" / "support" — also flows. Both work, but (c) uses more natural collocations.

Answer: (c) opposed / discussion / support.

PART 15 — VOCABULARY (Synonyms, Antonyms, Idioms, One-word Substitutions, Spellings)

15.0 Opener

Why separate discipline: vocab cannot be taught by rules; it must be memorised. But a **high-frequency list** saves 80 % effort.

Preparation plan: 1. **High-frequency root+prefix+suffix** list (300 entries) — e.g., mis-, dis-, -able, -ous, bio-, geo-, -cracy. 2. **500 high-frequency SSC + Banking synonyms/antonyms** drilled across a month. 3. **100 high-frequency idioms** ("to bite the dust", "let the cat out of the bag", "pulling your leg"). 4. **One-word substitutions** — "person who can speak many languages = polyglot", "person who talks to himself = soliloquist". 5. **Commonly misspelt words** — accommodate, occurrence, separate, privilege, embarrassment, millennium.

Types of Questions

1. **Synonym** (choose word closest in meaning).
2. **Antonym** (choose opposite).
3. **Idiom meaning**.
4. **One-word substitution**.
5. **Spelling** (choose the correctly spelt one).
6. **Foreign phrases** (status quo, bona fide, vice versa, per se, ad hoc).

15.1 Attack strategy per question type

For each question type, run a specific 3-step routine:

Type	Step 1	Step 2	Step 3
Synonym	If unknown, decode by prefix / root / suffix	Eliminate opposite-meaning options	Pick the option closest in register & connotation
Antonym	Identify the word's polarity (positive/negative)	Find options with opposite polarity	Reject same-polarity distractors

Type	Step 1	Step 2	Step 3
Idiom	Translate the idiom literally to see the image	Pick the option that paraphrases the image	Reject literal traps
One-word substitution	Find the defining property in the phrase	Match it to the precise -ist / -phobia / -cide / -archy ending	Reject over-broad options
Spelling	Apply the doubled-letter and unstressed-vowel rules	Reject phonetic-but-wrong spellings	Pick the technically correct one
Foreign phrase	Translate the Latin/French roots	Map to the closest English idea	Reject false friends

15.2 Worked Examples — one per type

Example 1 — Synonym. Q: Find the synonym of "**OSTENTATIOUS**".

(a) modest (b) showy (c) hidden (d) plain

Step 1. Decode: *ostent*- root from Latin *ostendere* = "to display, show off." **Step 2.** Eliminate opposite-polarity options: *modest*, *hidden*, *plain* are all the opposite of showy. **Step 3.** Only **(b) showy** matches the "displaying" meaning.

Answer: (b).

Example 2 — Antonym. Q: Find the antonym of "**BENEVOLENT**".

(a) kind (b) gentle (c) malevolent (d) generous

Step 1. Polarity of *benevolent* (= well-wishing, kind) → **positive**. **Step 2.** Find a **negative**-polarity option. *Kind*, *gentle*, *generous* are all positive (same polarity = wrong). Only **malevolent** (= ill-wishing) is opposite. **Step 3.** Roots confirm: *bene* (good) + *volent* (wishing) vs *male* (bad) + *volent* (wishing).

Answer: (c) malevolent.

Example 3 — Idiom. Q: Choose the meaning of: "**To let the cat out of the bag.**"

(a) To free a pet
(b) To accidentally reveal a secret
(c) To lose a quarrel
(d) To buy something blindly

Step 1. Literal image: a *hidden cat* (= secret) being *let out of a bag* (= revealed) — accidentally. **Step 2.** Paraphrase = "to reveal a secret accidentally" → option (b). **Step 3.** Reject literal traps: (a) is literal-cat (wrong); (c) and (d) are unrelated.

Answer: (b).

Companion idioms: "spill the beans" = same meaning. "A wolf in sheep's clothing" = a hidden enemy. "Don't count your chickens before they hatch" = don't celebrate prematurely.

Example 4 — One-word substitution. Q: A person who can use both hands with equal ease is called: _____.

(a) ambivalent (b) ambidextrous (c) ambiguous (d) amphibious

Step 1. Defining property = "BOTH hands, equal ease". Need the precise word. **Step 2.** *Ambi-* (both) + *dexter* (right hand, hence skilful) → **ambidextrous**. **Step 3.** Reject look-alikes: *ambivalent* (mixed feelings), *ambiguous* (unclear), *amphibious* (land + water).

Answer: (b).

Mini-list of high-yield one-word substitutions: / Phrase / One word / |---|---| / Lover of books / **bibliophile** / | Hatred of mankind / **misanthropy** / | Government by the few / **oligarchy** / | Government by women / **matriarchy** / | Killing of one's father / **patricide** / | Fear of closed spaces / **claustrophobia** / | Fear of open spaces / **agoraphobia** / | Person who speaks many languages / **polyglot** / | Person who eats everything (plants + meat) / **omnivore** / | Person who eats only plants / **herbivore** / | One who studies birds / **ornithologist** / | One who studies the past / **historian** / | Animal that lives in water + on land / **amphibian** / | Speech to oneself / **soliloquy** / | Mania for stealing / **kleptomania** / | Mania for setting fires / **pyromania** /

Example 5 — Spelling. Q: Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) Accomodate (b) Acomodate (c) Accommodate (d) Accomodade

Step 1. Apply the doubled-letter rule for "accommodate" — both *c* AND *m* are doubled (the most-tested spelling trap in English). **Step 2.** Option (a) misses one *m*; (b) misses one *c*; (d) wrong ending. **Step 3.** **Accommodate** ✓.

Answer: (c) Accommodate.

Top-15 misspelt words (memorise the doubled-letter pattern): / Wrong / Correct / |---|---| / Accomodate / **Accommodate** (cc + mm) / | Occurence / **Occurrence** (cc + rr) / | Separate / **Separate** (sep-A-rate, NOT sep-E-rate) / | Priviledge / **Privilege** (only one d... actually no d) / | Embarassment / **Embarrassment** (rr + ss) / | Millenium / **Millennium** (ll + nn) / | Independant / **Independent** (-ent) / | Recieve / **Receive** ("i before e except after c") / | Concious / **Conscious** (sc + ous) / | Maintainance / **Maintenance** (-ten-, not -tain-) / | Tomatoe / **Tomato** (no e) / | Calender / **Calendar** (-dar) / | Goverment / **Government** (gover-N-ment) / | Begining / **Beginning** (nn) / | Referred / **Referred** (rr) /

Example 6 — Foreign phrase. Q: What does "per se" mean?

- (a) per share (b) by itself (c) per second (d) very much

Step 1. Latin *per* (through, by) + *se* (itself) → "by itself, intrinsically". **Step 2. Answer: (b) by itself.**

High-yield foreign phrases (Latin + French): / Phrase / Meaning / |---|---| / **status quo** / the existing state of affairs / | **bona fide** / in good faith / genuine / | **vice versa** / the other way around / | **per se** / by itself / as such / | **ad hoc** / for this specific purpose / | **prima facie** / at first sight / | **ipso facto** / by the fact itself / | **de facto** / in fact (as opposed to *de jure* = in law) / | **de jure** / by right of law / | **sine qua non** / an essential condition / | **carte blanche** / full authority / | **fait accompli** / a done deed / | **coup d'état** / sudden overthrow of a government / | **modus operandi** / manner of operation / | **quid pro quo** / something for something / exchange / | **et cetera (etc.)** / and the rest / | **i.e.** (*id est*) / that is / | **e.g.** (*exempli gratia*) / for example / | **vis-à-vis** / in relation to / | **alma mater** / one's old school/college /

15.3 Common Vocabulary Traps

Trap	Example	Avoid by
Same-polarity distractor in antonyms	All four options synonyms; one is the opposite.	Marking polarity (+/-) before reading options.
Look-alike words	"ambivalent / ambiguous / ambidextrous / amphibious"	Decoding the root: <i>ambi-</i> (both), <i>dexter</i> (hand), <i>phib-</i> (life).
Literal idiom trap	"let the cat out" → "free a pet" (wrong).	Always paraphrase the <i>image</i> , not the literal words.
British vs American spelling	colour/color, theatre/theater, organise/organize	Pick whichever the exam uses (SSC/Banks → British).
Greek vs Latin roots in OWS	- <i>cide</i> (kill: Latin) vs - <i>cracy</i> (rule: Greek)	Memorise the suffix-meaning map.
Foreign-phrase false friend	"per se" ≠ "per share"	Decode the original-language roots, not the look-alike English.

15.4 Mini-PYQ Drill — Vocabulary

- Synonym of **PROLIFIC** =
(a) sterile (b) abundant
(c) brief (d) ordinary → **(b) abundant.**
- Antonym of **TRANSPARENT** =
(a) opaque (b) clear
(c) obvious (d) thin → **(a) opaque.**
- Idiom: "**To make a clean breast of**" =
(a) to bathe
(b) to confess fully
(c) to win easily
(d) to fight openly → **(b) to confess fully.**
- One-word: "Government by the wealthy" =
(a) plutocracy
(b) aristocracy
(c) democracy
(d) bureaucracy → **(a) plutocracy** (*pluto-* = wealth).

5. Spelling — pick the correct:
 (a) Receipt (b) Reciept
 (c) Recipt (d) Receit → **(a) Receipt.**
6. Foreign phrase: "**sine qua non**" =
 (a) without sin
 (b) an essential condition
 (c) without doubt
 (d) old age → **(b) an essential condition.**

Carry-forward principle: vocabulary is won by **systematic decoding** (root + prefix + suffix) **PLUS drilled lists** (the top-300 high-frequency words). Both — not one or the other.

PART 16 — DEEP-DRILL VOCABULARY ESSENTIALS (high-yield list)

16.1 Top-100 SSC + Banking SYNONYMS to drill (with one-line meaning)

Word	Meaning	Synonym to remember
Abate	reduce	diminish, mitigate
Acrid	bitter (smell/taste)	pungent, harsh
Adamant	unyielding	inflexible, obstinate
Affable	friendly	amiable, cordial
Alleviate	reduce pain	mitigate, ease
Ambiguous	unclear	vague, equivocal
Apathy	lack of interest	indifference
Arduous	very difficult	strenuous, laborious
Astute	sharp - witted	shrewd, perceptive
Audacious	bold (often reckless)	daring, intrepid
Banal	unoriginal	trite, hackneyed
Belligerent	hostile	combative
Benevolent	kind	benign, generous
Brevity	shortness	conciseness, terseness
Candid	frank	forthright, blunt
Capricious	impulsive	fickle, whimsical
Censure	strong criticism	rebuke, condemn
Coalesce	merge	unite, fuse
Convolutd	complex	intricate, twisted
Copious	abundant	plentiful, ample
Credulous	gullible	naive, trusting
Deference	respect	esteem, regard
Deride	mock	ridicule, scoff

Word	Meaning	Synonym to remember
Despot	tyrant	autocrat, dictator
Diligent	hardworking	assiduous, conscientious
Disparage	belittle	denigrate
Eclectic	varied source	diverse, broad
Egregious	shockingly bad	flagrant, atrocious
Elucidate	explain	clarify, illuminate
Emulate	imitate (to equal)	mirror, follow
Ephemeral	short-lived	transient, fleeting
Eradicate	remove totally	eliminate, exterminate
Erudite	scholarly	learned, well-read
Exacerbate	make worse	aggravate, worsen
Exonerate	clear of blame	acquit, absolve
Extol	praise highly	laud, eulogize
Fervent	passionate	ardent, zealous
Flippant	not serious	frivolous, glib
Frugal	thrifty	economical, sparing
Garrulous	talkative	loquacious
Hapless	unfortunate	unlucky
Hegemony	dominance	supremacy
Iconoclast	image-breaker (lit/fig)	rebel, dissenter
Impede	obstruct	hinder, thwart
Impervious	unaffected by	resistant, immune
Inculcate	instil	implant, infuse
Indolent	lazy	slothful, idle
Inevitable	unavoidable	certain
Insidious	tasteless	bland, dull
Intrepid	fearless	brave, bold
Jubilant	very happy	elated, exultant
Laconic	brief in speech	terse, succinct
Lethargic	sluggish	sleepy, torpid
Lucid	clear	coherent, intelligible
Magnanimous	generous (esp to enemies)	noble, big-hearted
Mendacious	lying	dishonest, untruthful
Meticulous	very careful	thorough, fastidious
Mitigate	reduce severity	alleviate, soften
Munificent	very generous	bountiful, liberal
Myriad	very many	countless
Nefarious	wicked	evil, villainous
Obfuscate	confuse	obscure, muddle
Obstinate	stubborn	adamant, mulish
Opulent	wealthy, lavish	affluent, plush

Word	Meaning	Synonym to remember
Ostentatious	showy	flashy, pretentious
Palpable	tangible	obvious, evident
Paragon	a perfect model	epitome, exemplar
Pedantic	overly precise	nit-picking
Perfunctory	done with little care	cursory, superficial
Pernicious	harmful	injurious, destructive
Pithy	brief and forceful	succinct, terse
Placate	calm down	appease, mollify
Plethora	excess	abundance, surfeit
Pragmatic	practical	sensible, realistic
Precarious	unstable	risky, dangerous
Procrastinate	delay	postpone, defer
Profligate	wasteful	extravagant
Proliferate	multiply rapidly	grow, increase
Prudent	careful	cautious, judicious
Quell	suppress	crush, subdue
Quintessential	most typical	classic, archetypal
Recalcitrant	uncooperative	defiant, intractable
Repudiate	reject	renounce, disown
Resilient	bouncing back	tough, hardy
Sagacious	wise	astute, insightful
Scrupulous	morally careful	principled, ethical
Sedulous	diligent	persistent
Sporadic	occasional	infrequent, intermittent
Stoic	unaffected by emotion	impassive, unflinching
Stringent	strict	rigorous, severe
Sycophant	flatterer	toady, bootlicker
Tantamount	equivalent	equal to
Taciturn	uncommunicative	reserved, silent
Tenacious	persistent	dogged, relentless
Trepidation	fear/anxiety	apprehension
Ubiquitous	present everywhere	omnipresent
Vacillate	waver	hesitate, oscillate
Verbose	wordy	long-winded
Vex	annoy	irritate, frustrate
Vindicate	justify, clear	exonerate
Voluble	speaks a lot, fluently	talkative, articulate
Wary	cautious	guarded, vigilant
Zealous	passionate	enthusiastic, fervent

Drill rule: cover the right side, see the word, recall meaning + 1 synonym in <2 s.

16.2 Top-50 high-frequency ANTONYMS (often paired with the synonyms above)

Word	Antonym
Abundant	scarce
Amateur	professional
Amicable	hostile
Bold	timid
Calm	agitated
Concise	verbose
Concrete	abstract
Conspicuous	inconspicuous
Contradict	corroborate
Cordial	aloof
Diligent	indolent
Dispel	gather
Eccentric	conventional
Eloquent	inarticulate
Embellish	mar
Eminent	unknown
Frivolous	serious
Genuine	spurious
Gregarious	introverted
Humble	arrogant
Implicit	explicit
Innocent	guilty
Lethargic	energetic
Lucid	obscure
Lustrous	dull
Modest	flamboyant
Notorious	reputable
Optimist	pessimist
Praise	denounce
Profound	superficial
Prudent	reckless
Radical	conservative
Rare	common
Rebellious	obedient
Reluctant	willing
Reveal	conceal
Rigid	flexible

Word	Antonym
Robust	feeble
Sacred	profane
Stingy	generous
Tedious	exciting
Transient	permanent
Trivial	significant
Turbulent	placid
Vague	precise
Valiant	cowardly
Vehement	mild
Vibrant	dull
Wane	wax
Zenith	nadir

16.3 Top-100 ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS (memorise — 4-6 questions per SSC paper)

People:

- One who eats everything → **Omnivore** (eats only meat → Carnivore; only plants → Herbivore)
- One who eats human flesh → **Cannibal**
- One who can speak many languages → **Polyglot**
- One who knows many subjects → **Polymath**; only one subject → **Specialist**
- One who hates mankind → **Misanthrope** (hates women → Misogynist; hates men → Misandrist; hates marriage → Misogamist)
- One who loves humanity → **Philanthropist** (loves books → Bibliophile; loves wine → Oenophile; loves nature → Naturalist)
- One who studies plants → **Botanist**; animals → Zoologist; birds → Ornithologist; insects → Entomologist; coins → Numismatist; stamps → Philatelist; ancient writing → Palaeographer; fossils → Palaeontologist; earthquakes → Seismologist; weather → Meteorologist; poetry → Poet; star/heavenly bodies → Astronomer/Astrologer
- One who walks in sleep → **Somnambulist**; talks in sleep → Somniloquist
- One who is new to a job → **Novice / Tyro / Neophyte**
- One who copies from others' work → **Plagiarist**; counterfeits → Forger
- One who lives alone → **Recluse / Hermit**
- One who is unable to pay debts → **Insolvent / Bankrupt**
- One who renounces the throne → **Abdicator**
- One who is hard to please → **Fastidious**
- One who is all-powerful → **Omnipotent**; all-knowing → Omniscient; present everywhere → Omnipresent
- One who looks at the bright side → **Optimist**; dark side → Pessimist
- One who studies blood → **Haematologist**; heart → Cardiologist; skin → Dermatologist; bones → Orthopaedist; cancer → Oncologist; eyes → Ophthalmologist; ear-nose-throat → ENT/Otolaryngologist;

women → Gynaecologist; children → Paediatrician; mind → Psychologist/Psychiatrist; teeth → Dentist; old age → Gerontologist

- One who works for free → **Volunteer**
- One who is just/impartial → **Neutral**
- One who shows off learning → **Pedant**
- One who is greedy for money → **Avaricious**
- One who has a strong desire for something → **Aspirant**

Things / abstract:

- Government by one → **Autocracy**; few → Oligarchy; many → Democracy; women → Matriarchy / Gynocracy; men → Patriarchy; rich → Plutocracy; the worst → Kakistocracy; experts → Technocracy; clergy → Theocracy; nobility → Aristocracy; the elderly → Gerontocracy
- Killing of king → **Regicide**; father → Patricide; mother → Matricide; brother → Fratricide; sister → Sororicide; child → Infanticide; self → Suicide; race/group → Genocide; humans (general) → Homicide; insects → Pesticide / Insecticide; weeds → Herbicide; bacteria → Germicide; environment → Ecocide
- Fear of height → **Acrophobia**; closed places → Claustrophobia; open places → Agoraphobia; water → Hydrophobia; foreigners → Xenophobia; animals → Zoophobia; spiders → Arachnophobia; darkness → Nyctophobia; death → Thanatophobia; books → Bibliophobia; speaking in public → Glossophobia; needles → Aichmophobia; blood → Hemophobia
- Mania for stealing → **Kleptomania**; setting fire → Pyromania; books → Bibliomania; alcohol → Dipsomania; one idea → Monomania; greatness → Megalomania
- A short trip → **Excursion**; long sea voyage → Voyage; exploring expedition → Expedition
- Public sale → **Auction**
- A speech without preparation → **Extempore / Impromptu**
- Words inscribed on a tomb → **Epitaph**
- Life history written by oneself → **Autobiography**; by another → Biography
- An exact copy → **Replica / Facsimile**
- That which cannot be defeated → **Invincible**; cannot be approached → Inaccessible; cannot be heard → Inaudible; cannot be read → Illegible; cannot be cured → Incurable; cannot be erased → Indelible; cannot be expressed → Inexpressible / Ineffable; cannot be quenched → Insatiable; cannot be avoided → Inevitable; cannot be believed → Incredible; cannot be seen → Invisible; cannot be moved → Immovable
- Words used in the same situation → **Cliché / Platitude**
- Continuing forever → **Perpetual / Perennial**
- A child whose parents are dead → **Orphan**; whose parents/wife dead → Widow/Widower
- A place where corpses are buried → **Cemetery**; burnt → Crematorium; museum of artifacts → Museum; for orphans → Orphanage; old/sick → Asylum/Sanatorium; for plants → Greenhouse / Conservatory; for fish → Aquarium; for grain storage → Granary; for arms storage → Armoury / Arsenal; for animals → Zoo; for birds → Aviary; for bees → Apiary; for horses → Stable; for cows → Byre; for pigs → Sty; for sheep → Pen / Fold

16.4 Top-100 IDIOMS (high-frequency in SSC, RRB, Banking)

Idiom	Meaning
A bolt from the blue	sudden shock
A cock-and-bull story	unbelievable story
A drop in the ocean	very small amount
A feather in one's cap	proud achievement
A man of straw	weak/insignificant person
A piece of cake	very easy task
A red letter day	memorable day
A wild goose chase	useless pursuit
Above board	honest, transparent
Achilles' heel	a weak point
Add fuel to the fire	worsen a bad situation
All ears	very attentive
All in all	overall
At a stone's throw	very near
At daggers drawn	bitter enmity
At sixes and sevens	confused, in disarray
Back to the drawing board	start again
Beat about the bush	avoid the point
Bell the cat	take a bold first step
Bite the bullet	endure painful inevitability
Bite the dust	be defeated/die
Black sheep	disreputable family member
Blow one's own trumpet	self-praise
Break the ice	start a conversation
Bring to light	reveal
Burn the midnight oil	study/work late
Burn one's fingers	suffer for meddling
Burning question	hot/important issue
Bury the hatchet	end a quarrel
By and large	mostly
By leaps and bounds	very rapidly
Call it a day	stop working
Call a spade a spade	speak frankly
Carry the day	win
Cat-and-dog life	quarrelsome existence
Catch red-handed	caught in the act
Chip off the old block	resembling parent
Cold shoulder	deliberate snub
Come to terms	reach agreement / accept

Idiom	Meaning
Cross swords	quarrel
Crocodile tears	fake sorrow
Cry over spilt milk	regret what cannot be undone
Cut a sorry figure	poor impression
Cut to the quick	hurt deeply
Dark horse	unexpected winner
Donkey's years	a very long time
Down in the dumps	depressed
Eat humble pie	apologise / admit error
Every Tom, Dick and Harry	any ordinary person
Face the music	bear consequences
Fair - weather friend	friend only in good times
Fall flat	fail to impress
Feather in one's cap	honour
Fish out of water	uncomfortable in unfamiliar place
Flash in the pan	brief unrepeated success
Foot the bill	pay
For a song	very cheap
French leave	absence without permission
From hand to mouth	living without savings
Get cold feet	lose courage
Give the cold shoulder	ignore
Go to the dogs	deteriorate
Hand in glove	very close (often suspiciously)
Have an axe to grind	personal interest at stake
Hit the nail on the head	be exactly right
Hue and cry	loud public outcry
In black and white	in writing
In a nutshell	briefly
In the long run	eventually
In the same boat	same situation
Iron hand	strict control
Jump the gun	act prematurely
Keep the wolf from the door	avoid hunger/poverty
Kick the bucket	die
Lend a hand	help
Let the cat out of the bag	reveal a secret
Lion's share	major portion
Look daggers at	glare angrily
Lose face	be humiliated
Make a clean breast	confess fully

Idiom	Meaning
Make ends meet	manage on small income
Make hay while the sun shines	use opportunity
Move heaven and earth	use every means
Nip in the bud	stop at the start
Null and void	invalid
Off and on	occasionally
Once in a blue moon	very rarely
Out of the blue	suddenly
Pass the buck	shift blame
Pay through the nose	pay too much
Pull a long face	look sad
Pull one's leg	tease
Put one's foot down	act firmly
Read between the lines	infer hidden meaning
Rest on one's laurels	stop trying after success
Ride the high horse	act arrogantly
Rule of thumb	rough guideline
See eye to eye	agree
Show the white feather	reveal cowardice
Sit on the fence	remain neutral
Smell a rat	suspect foul play
Spill the beans	reveal a secret
Steal a march	gain an advantage stealthily
Take to one's heels	run away
Take with a pinch of salt	not believe entirely
Tall claim	exaggerated assertion
Throw cold water on	discourage
Through thick and thin	in good times and bad
To and fro	back and forth
Tooth and nail	with all might
Turn a deaf ear	ignore
Turn over a new leaf	reform
Under one's nose	right in front
Under the weather	unwell
Up in arms	strongly opposed
Wash one's hands of	refuse responsibility
Wear one's heart on one's sleeve	show emotion openly
Wet blanket	spoil - sport
White elephant	costly useless possession
Win hands down	win easily
With a high hand	tyrannically

16.5 50 commonly-misspelt words (drill in pairs)

accommodate, achievement, acquaintance, address, beautiful, beggar, beginning, believe, businessman, calendar, ceiling, cemetery, colleague, committee, conscience, conscientious, convenient, deceive, definitely, despair, embarrass, enthusiastic, exaggerate, fascinate, foreign, fulfil, gauge, government, grammar, grateful, harass, hindrance, humorous, hypocrisy, immediately, independence, indispensable, inoculate, intelligence, knowledge, leisure, liaison, lieutenant, maintenance, manoeuvre, millennium, miscellaneous, mischievous, necessary, occasion, occurrence, omitted, parallel, perseverance, possess, privilege, professional, pronunciation, queue, recommend, referred, restaurant, rhythm, schedule, separate, sergeant, sieve, sincerely, sovereign, succeed, surveillance, tomorrow, twelfth, until, vacuum, weird

16.6 30 high-yield FOREIGN PHRASES (Latin / French)

Phrase	Meaning
ad hoc	for a specific purpose
ad infinitum	endlessly
alma mater	one's old school
bona fide	genuine, in good faith
carpe diem	seize the day
carte blanche	full freedom
caveat emptor	let the buyer beware
chargé d'affaires	acting ambassador
coup d'état	sudden seizure of power
de facto	in practice
de jure	by law
déjà vu	already seen
en masse	as a group
ex officio	by virtue of office
ex parte	from one party only
fait accompli	accomplished fact
in absentia	while absent
in toto	entirely
ipso facto	by that very fact
laissez-faire	non-interference
modus operandi	method of working
nolens volens	willingly or not
per capita	per person
per se	by itself
persona non grata	unwelcome person
post mortem	after death (analysis)
prima facie	at first sight
pro rata	proportional
quid pro quo	something for something
sine die	indefinitely

Phrase	Meaning
sine qua non	indispensable condition
status quo	existing state
sub judice	under trial
tête-à-tête	private chat
vice versa	the reverse
vis-à-vis	with regard to

16.7 Top-50 PROVERBS with meanings (SSC CGL, CHSL — tested separately from idioms)

KEY FACT

Proverbs vs Idioms: Proverbs are complete sentences giving advice or stating a truth. Idioms are fixed phrases slotted into a sentence. SSC often tests "what does the proverb mean?" directly.

Proverb	Meaning
A bad workman blames his tools	incompetent people find excuses
A bird in hand is worth two in the bush	certainty over possibility
A chain is as strong as its weakest link	the weakest part determines overall strength
A drowning man clutches at a straw	desperate people grab any help
A fool and his money are soon parted	foolish people spend recklessly
A friend in need is a friend indeed	real friends help in trouble
A leopard cannot change its spots	character does not change
A little knowledge is a dangerous thing	partial knowledge leads to errors
A man is known by the company he keeps	judge by one's associates
A penny saved is a penny earned	saving = earning
A problem shared is a problem halved	sharing reduces burden
A rolling stone gathers no moss	moving around = no stability/savings
A stitch in time saves nine	timely action prevents bigger problems
Actions speak louder than words	behaviour more important than promises
All that glitters is not gold	appearances are deceptive
An idle brain is the devil's workshop	idleness leads to mischief
Barking dogs seldom bite	those who threaten rarely act
Beggars cannot be choosers	those in need must accept what is given
Better late than never	doing something late is better than not at all
Birds of a feather flock together	similar people gather together
Charity begins at home	help your own family first
Cut your coat according to your cloth	live within your means
Do not count your chickens before they hatch	do not assume success prematurely
Do not judge a book by its cover	do not judge by appearance
Empty vessels make the most noise	shallow people talk the most
Every cloud has a silver lining	every bad situation has some good

Proverb	Meaning
Fortune favours the brave	bold action is rewarded
Give a dog a bad name and hang him	a bad reputation ruins a person
God helps those who help themselves	self-effort attracts support
Great minds think alike	intelligent people reach the same conclusions
Haste makes waste	hurrying leads to mistakes
Honesty is the best policy	being honest has best long-term results
It takes two to tango	both parties share responsibility
Jack of all trades, master of none	versatile but not excellent in any
Look before you leap	think carefully before acting
Make hay while the sun shines	use opportunity when available
Necessity is the mother of invention	need drives creativity
Never put off till tomorrow what you can do today	avoid procrastination
No man can serve two masters	cannot be loyal to two opposing parties
Once bitten, twice shy	learn caution from experience
One man's meat is another man's poison	different things suit different people
Out of sight, out of mind	we forget what we cannot see
Prevention is better than cure	avoiding problems > fixing them
Pride goes before a fall	arrogance leads to failure
Rome was not built in a day	great things take time
Slow and steady wins the race	consistency beats rash speed
Strike while the iron is hot	act at the right moment
The grass is always greener on the other side	others' lives seem better
Too many cooks spoil the broth	too many people ruin an outcome
United we stand, divided we fall	unity is strength
When in Rome, do as the Romans do	follow local customs

16.8 60 Commonly CONFUSED word pairs (heavy in error-spotting + cloze)

KEY FACT

These pairs sound alike or look alike but mean different things. Error-spotting questions frequently swap one for the other. Memorise the distinction, not just the meaning.

Word A	Word B	How to tell apart
Affect (verb)	Effect (noun)	Affects → results in an Effect
Assure	Ensure	Assure = remove doubt (person); Ensure = make certain (event)
Averse	Adverse	Averse = unwilling; Adverse = harmful
Avenge	Revenge	Avenge = just punishment (for another); Revenge = personal retaliation
Beside	Besides	Beside = next to; Besides = in addition to
Childlike	Childish	Childlike = innocently; Childish = immaturity (negative)
Classic	Classical	Classic = of lasting value; Classical = belonging to ancient Greece/Rome
Complement	Compliment	Complement = completes; Compliment = praise

Word A	Word B	How to tell apart
Continual	Continuous	Continual = repeated with breaks; Continuous = unbroken
Council	Counsel	Council = advisory body (noun); Counsel = advise (verb) / lawyer (noun)
Credible	Credulous	Credible = believable; Credulous = easily believes anything (gullible)
Defuse	Diffuse	Defuse = make safe; Diffuse = spread widely
Delusion	Illusion	Delusion = false belief (mental); Illusion = false perception (visual)
Desert (n)	Dessert	Desert = sandy region; Dessert = sweet course
Discreet	Discrete	Discreet = careful/tactful; Discrete = separate, distinct
Disinterested	Uninterested	Disinterested = impartial; Uninterested = not interested
Elude	Allude	Elude = escape; Allude = refer indirectly
Eminent	Imminent	Eminent = distinguished; Imminent = about to happen
Eruption	Irruption	Eruption = bursting out; Irruption = bursting in
Flair	Flare	Flair = natural talent; Flare = burst of light / anger
Flout	Flaunt	Flout = defy (rules); Flaunt = show off
Forbid	Prohibit	Forbid = personal order; Prohibit = official rule
Forego	Forgo	Forego = precede; Forgo = give up
Historic	Historical	Historic = famous/important event; Historical = belonging to history
Housework	Homework	Housework = domestic chores; Homework = school assignment
Illicit	Elicit	Illicit = illegal; Elicit = draw out a response
Imaginary	Imaginative	Imaginary = not real; Imaginative = creative
Imply	Infer	Speaker implies; Listener infers
Incredible	Incredulous	Incredible = unbelievable (thing); Incredulous = disbelieving (person)
Intelligent	Intellectual	Intelligent = quick to understand; Intellectual = fond of ideas/theory
Judicial	Judicious	Judicial = related to court; Judicious = showing good judgement
Later	Latter	Later = after some time; Latter = the second of two
Lay	Lie	Lay = place an object (transitive); Lie = recline (intransitive)
Liable	Likely	Liable = legally responsible; Likely = probable
Loose	Lose	Loose = not tight; Lose = fail to keep
Luxurious	Luxuriant	Luxurious = comfortable, expensive; Luxuriant = abundant (vegetation)
Moral	Morale	Moral = ethical lesson; Morale = group spirit/confidence
Nauseated	Nauseous	Nauseated = feeling sick; Nauseous = causing sickness
Notable	Notorious	Notable = worthy of note; Notorious = famous for wrong reasons
Observance	Observation	Observance = following rules; Observation = watching / remark
Official	Officious	Official = authorised; Officious = bossy, over-eager
Oral	Verbal	Oral = spoken; Verbal = in words (spoken or written)
Passed	Past	Passed = verb (moved past); Past = noun/adjective/preposition
Persecute	Prosecute	Persecute = oppress; Prosecute = take to court
Practical	Practicable	Practical = sensible; Practicable = capable of being done
Precede	Proceed	Precede = come before; Proceed = go forward
Principal	Principle	Principal = main/head person; Principle = rule/belief
Prophecy	Prophesy	Prophecy (noun) = prediction; Prophesy (verb) = to predict
Rational	Rationale	Rational = based on reason; Rationale = reason given for something

Word A	Word B	How to tell apart
Sensual	Sensuous	Sensual = of physical pleasure (often sexual); Sensuous = pleasing to senses
Sight	Site	Sight = vision; Site = location
Stationary	Stationery	Stationary = not moving; Stationery = writing materials
Temporal	Temporary	Temporal = relating to time or worldly; Temporary = lasting short time
Urban	Urbane	Urban = relating to city; Urbane = refined, polished
Vocation	Vacation	Vocation = calling/career; Vacation = holiday
Waive	Wave	Waive = give up a right; Wave = motion of hand/water
Who	Whom	Who = subject; Whom = object (him/her → whom)
Worthless	Priceless	Worthless = no value; Priceless = too valuable to price
Zeal	Jealousy	Zeal = enthusiastic dedication; Jealousy = resentment of another's advantage

16.9 30 high-frequency COLLOCATIONS (cloze test staples)

KEY FACT

Collocations = words that naturally go together. Cloze tests check whether you know *which* preposition, verb, or adjective pairs with a given noun. These 30 patterns cover 60-70% of cloze-test collocation traps.

Verb/Adj	Noun	Fixed pair	Trap to avoid
Raise	concern	raise a concern	NOT "rise a concern"
Address	issue	address an issue	NOT "discuss an issue" (generic)
Pose	threat	pose a threat	NOT "give a threat"
Make	decision	make a decision	NOT "take a decision" (BrE: take)
Take	responsibility	take responsibility	NOT "bear responsibility" (different nuance)
Launch	initiative	launch an initiative	NOT "start an initiative" (formal context)
Pass	legislation	pass legislation	NOT "approve legislation"
Implement	policy	implement a policy	NOT "apply a policy"
Express	concern	express concern	NOT "show concern" (formal writing)
Reach	consensus	reach a consensus	NOT "achieve consensus"
Draw	attention	draw attention to	NOT "pull attention"
Play	role	play a role	NOT "do a role"
Pose	challenge	pose a challenge	NOT "create a challenge"
Cast	doubt	cast doubt on	NOT "throw doubt"
Bear	resemblance	bear resemblance	NOT "carry resemblance"
Heave	sigh	heave a sigh	NOT "give a sigh" (informal OK)
Pay	heed	pay heed to	NOT "give heed"
Set	precedent	set a precedent	NOT "make a precedent"
Break	ground	break new ground	NOT "pave new ground"
Come	fruition	come to fruition	NOT "reach fruition"
Run	risk	run the risk of	NOT "take the risk of" (both OK — run = fixed collocation)
Shed	light	shed light on	NOT "throw light" (both acceptable)

Verb/Adj	Noun	Fixed pair	Trap to avoid
Stem	tide	stem the tide	NOT "stop the tide"
Strike	balance	strike a balance	NOT "make a balance"
Turn	blind eye	turn a blind eye	NOT "close a blind eye"
Make	headway	make headway	NOT "achieve headway"
Come	terms	come to terms with	NOT "reach terms with"
Bear	brunt	bear the brunt	NOT "take the brunt"
Give	wide berth	give a wide berth	NOT "keep a wide berth"
Whet	appetite	whet one's appetite	NOT "wet one's appetite"

Part 16 built your vocabulary arsenal — the word lists, idioms, and collocations you must know cold. Part 17 now shows exactly how Banking exams test that vocabulary alongside their specific RC, cloze, and sentence-rearrangement patterns, which differ markedly from SSC. Adjust your preparation focus accordingly.

PART 17 — BANKS-FOCUS DEEP DRILL (PO/Clerk/RRB Bank, IBPS+SBI+RBI)

17.1 What's different in Banking English

Banking exams (IBPS PO/Clerk, SBI PO/Clerk, RBI Asst./Grade-B, IBPS RRB) have:

- **Long Reading-Comprehension passages (350-500 words)** with 7-10 questions on inference, tone, vocab-in-context.
- **Cloze tests** with 8-10 blanks, often "phrase-replacement cloze" (each blank replaced with a phrase).
- **Para-jumbles** (5-6 sentences); sometimes "para-completion" — you pick a sentence to complete the paragraph.
- **Sentence-rearrangement / starters** — variations like odd-one-out sentence.
- **Spotting error / sentence improvement** (heavy on phrasal verbs + idiomatic preposition).
- **NEW pattern (2024-26):** paragraph-based fill-in-the-blanks; column matching of phrases.

Negligible weight on: synonyms, antonyms, OWS, idiom-meaning (those are SSC heavy). So drill RC + cloze + sentence rearrangement deeper.

17.2 RC method — Banks deep-drill

1. **Type the passage in 10 s** — economy/finance / society / science / story-philosophy. Tone changes by type.
2. **Skim** for paragraph-1 (problem/topic), last paragraph (verdict/conclusion) — 30 s.
3. **Read questions next** — 4 categories: detail, inference, tone, vocab.
4. **For each question**, point to the LINE that supports it. If you cannot point, eliminate.
5. **Tone words** — "lament, applaud, condemn, advocate, criticise, endorse, impassioned, sceptical, satirical, dispassionate."
6. Inference questions: pick the option **most directly implied by a sentence**, not the option that requires three jumps.

7. Vocab-in-context: substitute the option in the passage; the meaning must hold.

8. Beware — Banking RCs often have "primary purpose" question. Answer = the **author's argumentative thesis**, not the topic.

17.3 Phrasal verbs hot-list (Banks heavy)

Phrasal	Meaning
Account for	explain
Back out	withdraw
Bank on	rely on
Break down	stop functioning / cry
Break out	start suddenly (war/disease)
Bring about	cause
Bring up	raise (child / topic)
Call off	cancel
Carry on	continue
Carry out	execute
Come across	meet by chance
Come down with	fall ill
Come up with	propose
Cut down	reduce
Do away with	abolish
Drop in	visit briefly
Fall back on	rely on (last resort)
Fall out with	quarrel
Get along	be on good terms
Get over	recover
Give in	surrender
Give up	quit
Go through	undergo / examine
Hold on	wait
Keep up with	stay abreast
Look down on	despise
Look forward to	anticipate eagerly
Look into	investigate
Look up to	respect
Make out	understand
Make up	reconcile / invent
Pass away	die
Pay off	succeed (effort) / clear debt
Pick up	learn / collect
Put off	postpone
Put up with	tolerate

Phrasal	Meaning
Run into	meet by chance
Run out of	exhaust supply
See off	farewell
Set in	begin (esp weather)
Set up	establish
Stand by	support / wait
Take after	resemble (parent)
Take down	write / remove
Take in	deceive / understand
Take off	remove / rise (plane)
Take over	assume control
Turn down	refuse
Turn up	appear
Wear off	gradually disappear

17.4 Cloze method — Banks deep-drill

1. **Read whole passage first** — get tone, type (analytical / narrative).
2. For each blank: **predict** before looking.
3. Cross-check **collocations**: certain words pair only with certain words ("propose a solution", "issue a warning", "raise concerns", "address an issue").
4. Watch **logical connectors** outside the blank — "however / although" require contrast; "moreover / furthermore" require continuation.
5. **Tense/agreement** — the blank's verb must agree with subject and align with surrounding tense.

17.5 Para-jumble / Para-completion — Banks deep-drill

- **Find the topic-sentence** — the one that introduces the noun-phrase others refer to.
- **Pronoun chain** — every "this/it/they/such" must follow its antecedent.
- **Time markers** — "First / then / finally / eventually" lock order.
- **Logical chain** — cause → effect → consequence; problem → response → outcome.
- **Para-completion**: the missing sentence usually carries the **central claim** or the **transition** between two ideas. Reject options that introduce new topics.

17.6 30-day Banks English plan (45–60 min/day)

Banks English (IBPS PO/Clerk, SBI PO/Clerk, RBI) is RC-and-cloze heavy. Vocabulary-heavy SSC question types (synonym, antonym, OWS) barely appear. Prioritise reading speed, inference, and phrase-sense.

Days	Focus	Why
1–5	RC method (17.2) + 5 long passages (350–500 words each)	15–20 Qs per paper; this alone decides selection
6–8	Cloze test: phrase-replacement + vocab-in-context (17.4)	8–10 Qs per set

Days	Focus	Why
9-10	Para-jumble + Para-completion (17.5)	5-7 Qs
11-12	Sentence rearrangement / odd-one-out sentence	5-7 Qs
13-14	Error spotting + Sentence improvement (Parts 9-10)	5-8 Qs
15-16	Fill in the blanks — double blank + phrase-matching	5-8 Qs
17-20	Vocabulary: phrasal verbs (17.3), idioms, collocations	Embedded in every RC, cloze, and error Q
21-23	RC — advanced: inference Q + tone Q + primary-purpose Q	The 3 hardest Qs in each set
24-25	New-pattern cloze (column matching, fill + rearrange)	Banks 2024-26 innovation
26-28	3 full Banks English sections under timed conditions	30 Qs in 20 min (IBPS PO Pre pattern)
29	Error analysis: list every Q you got wrong + why	Retest yourself on those Qs in 3 days
30	Weakest-area drill + timed Mini-Mock (PART E)	

KEY FACT

If you only have 15 days: Days 1-5 → RC (2 passages/day). Days 6-10 → cloze + para-jumble. Days 11-13 → error spotting + fill-in-blanks. Days 14-15 → two timed practice sections. Skip advanced new-pattern cloze for now.

Part 17 covered the RC-heavy, inference-driven style of Banking exams. Part 18 covers SSC and RRB, where the question mix flips: vocabulary (synonyms, antonyms, OWS, spellings) dominates, and RC passages are shorter and mostly factual. If you are preparing for SSC/RRB only, you can skim Part 17 — but read this chapter carefully.

PART 18 — SSC + RRB FOCUS DEEP DRILL

18.1 What's different

SSC (CGL, CHSL, MTS, GD, Steno) and RRB (NTPC, Group-D, JE, ALP) emphasise:

- **Vocabulary-heavy:** synonyms, antonyms, OWS, idiom meanings, spelling, foreign phrases.
- **Error spotting + sentence improvement** — high weight, frequent traps.
- **Cloze:** shorter passage (5-6 blanks), pure-vocab.
- **RC:** shorter passage (150-200 words), 5 questions, mostly factual.
- **Active-passive, direct-indirect, narration** — frequent.

So drill Parts 1-9 and Part 16 (vocab tables + idioms) the hardest. RC is shorter — speed-skim and answer.

18.2 30-day study plan for SSC English (each day 60-90 min)

Day	Focus
1-3	Tense rules + 100 worked examples
4-6	Subject-verb agreement + error spotting drill (50 sentences)
7-8	Articles + Prepositions (memorise 50 fixed pairs from Part 5)
9-10	Pronoun + Modifier errors
11-12	Voice + Narration
13-14	Conjunctions, Parallelism, "Lest", "Unless"

Day	Focus
15-17	Synonyms drill — 100 words from Part 16.1
18-19	Antonyms drill — 50 from Part 16.2
20-22	OWS — 100 from Part 16.3
23-24	Idioms — 100 from Part 16.4
25	Spellings + Foreign phrases (Part 16.5–16.6)
26-27	RC method + 6 SSC-style passages
28	Cloze + Para-jumble drills
29-30	Mock test, identify weak parts, return to Parts 1-9

18.3 Speed rules for SSC English (60-min Tier-1)

- **25 questions in 12-15 min.** Average 30 s per question.
- **Vocabulary** (synonym/antonym/idiom/OWS/spelling) — 5-7 questions, target <15 s each. Do these **FIRST** to build momentum.
- **Error spotting / sentence improvement** — next batch, ~20 s each.
- **Cloze + RC** — last batch, the slowest. 1.5-2 min for an entire short RC if you skim well.
- **Skip + return** rule: if vocab question is unfamiliar, mark + return at end; do not burn time guessing on day 1 of the strategy.

APPENDIX A — Master checklist for error spotting

Run this 10-point scan **in order** on every error-spotting question. Stop at the first error you find.

#	Error type	Trigger phrase to look for
1	Subject - Verb Agreement	Collective noun / "each of / neither of / the number of" near a plural verb
2	Tense consistency	Time-signal word (since, already, yesterday, when) clashes with verb tense
3	Pronoun agreement / case	Pronoun after preposition ("between you and I" → "me"); pronoun number mismatch
4	Preposition (fixed pairs)	"married with / superior than / prefer X than" — wrong prep after fixed verb/adj
5	Article (a / an / the)	Article chosen by letter not sound ("a honest" → "an honest"; "a university" ✓)
6	Parallelism	Correlatives (not only ... but also ...) connect unlike forms (verb vs noun)
7	Redundancy	"return back / repeat again / past history / revert back / free gift"
8	Comparative / superlative misuse	"more better / most strongest" (double); superlative for two ("the most of the two")
9	Gerund vs infinitive	enjoy/avoid/stop + V-ing; decide/want/refuse + to-V; "stop smoking" ≠ "stop to smoke"
10	Misplaced modifier	Opening participial phrase whose logical subject ≠ subject of main clause

APPENDIX B — Top-20 preposition pairs (quick-reference)

Memorise these cold — there is no logic, only pattern.

Verb / Adjective	Correct prep	Trap to avoid
accuse	of	not "for"

Verb / Adjective	Correct prep	Trap to avoid
comply	with	not "to"
consist	of	not "in" / not "with"
depend / rely / insist	on	not "upon" in modern usage
differ	from (things) / with (person)	not "than"
die	of disease · for cause · from injury	not "with"
married / engaged	to	not "with"
superior / inferior / junior / senior / prior	to	NEVER "than"
prefer X	to Y	NEVER "prefer X than Y"
afraid / aware / capable / fond / proud / sick	of	—
angry	with person / at thing	not "on"
good / expert / clever	at	not "in"
acquainted	with	not "to"
congratulate / compliment / decide	on	not "for"
suffer / prevent / refrain / abstain	from	not "with"
listen / reply / respond	to	not "at"
invite	to	not "for"
look	for (search) / after (care) / into (investigate)	each distinct
complain	about (matter) / to (person)	—
believe	in (existence) / no prep for opinion	not "believe on"

APPENDIX C — RC traps (banks + SSC)

1. **"Extreme" options** ("always", "never", "completely") — usually wrong.
2. **Out-of-scope inferences** — go beyond the passage.
3. **Opposite-tone distractors** (passage supportive, option critical).
4. **Over-specific numerical traps** in factual questions — verify in passage.
5. **Vocabulary substitution test** — for "vocab-in-context" questions, replace word and check.

Use this book alongside the Arithmetic, Reasoning, and Vocabulary books for complete skill coverage.

Practice Set (50 exam-style worked examples)

Section 1 — ERROR SPOTTING (10 worked + variations)

Notation expansion (used throughout): Sentences are split into 4-5 parts (A, B, C, D, E). One part has an error; the candidate identifies which. **High-frequency error categories:** S-V agreement, tense, preposition, article, pronoun, parallelism, redundancy, comparative misuse, gerund vs infinitive, modifier placement. **Universal method:** Run the part-by-part error checklist (S-V → tense → preposition → article → others). Stop at the first clear error.

Q1. "The number of students /
(a) in the class / (b) are increasing /
(c) every year. / (d) No error /(E)"

What kind of problem is this? Subject-verb agreement (S-V).

Solving it. Step-by-step. - Subject phrase = "The number of students". The HEAD noun is "**number**" (singular), not "students". - "The number" requires SINGULAR verb → "is increasing", not "are increasing". - Error is in part **(C)** → should be "is increasing".

Worth knowing: "The number of X" (singular verb) vs "A number of X" (plural verb). - *The number of students is small.* (= the count, singular) - *A number of students are absent.* (= many students, plural)

Watch out: The plural noun "students" right before the verb tricks students into using "are". Always identify the HEAD noun.

A similar question. "The list of items /(A) on the table /(B) are useful. /(C)" → Error (C); "list" singular → **is** useful.

Another twist — "A number of" (opposite). "A number of complaints /(A) have been received /(B). /(C)" → No error; "a number of" takes plural verb.

Q2. "Each of the boys /
(a) have completed / (b) their assignments /
(c) on time. / (d) "

What kind of problem is this? Subject-verb agreement after "each of".

Solving it. Step-by-step. - "Each" / "Every" / "Either" / "Neither" / "None" → SINGULAR verb. - "Each of the boys" → singular → **has completed** (not "have"). - Error is in part **(B)**.

Worth knowing: Memorise these "singular-by-default" pronouns: - **Each** of ... = singular verb. - **Every** boy/girl = singular verb. - **Either** of (with 2 things) = singular verb. - **Neither** of = singular verb. - **None** of = singular (formal) or plural (informal); MCQ usually expects singular.

Watch out: "boys" plural distracts. The subject is "Each", which is always singular.

A similar question. "Every student /(A) in the school /(B) have a uniform. /(C)" → Error (C); "Every student" singular → **has a uniform**.

Q3. "Neither John nor his friends /
(a) was / (b) present at / (c) the meeting. / (d) "

What kind of problem is this? Subject-verb agreement with "either-or / neither-nor" (closer-subject rule).

Solving it. Step-by-step. - For "Either A or B" / "Neither A nor B", the verb agrees with the **closer** subject (the one nearer the verb). - Closer subject here = "his friends" (plural). - Verb should be **were** (plural), not "was".
- Error is in part **(B)**.

Worth knowing: "Closer subject" rule applies to: - Either ... or ... - Neither ... nor ... - Not only ... but also ... -
Examples: - *Neither the captain nor the players were happy.* (players plural → were) - *Neither the players nor the captain was happy.* (captain singular → was)

Q4. "He is one of the /
(a) best students who / (b) has won /
(c) the award. / (d) "

What kind of problem is this? Relative clause subject-verb agreement.

Solving it. Step-by-step. - Construction: "one of the [plural noun] who/that [verb]". - "Who" refers back to the PLURAL noun ("students"), not "one". - Verb should be **have won** (plural), not "has won". - Error is in part **(C)**.

Worth knowing: Compare: - *He is the only one of the students who has won.* → "the only one" makes "who" refer to "one" (singular). - *He is one of the students who have won.* → "who" refers to "students" (plural).

Watch out: Students focus on "He is one" and conclude singular verb. The relative pronoun "who" decides.

Q5. "I have been /
(a) living in this city / (b) since five years. /
(c) / (d) "

What kind of problem is this? Preposition usage: "since" vs "for".

Solving it. Step-by-step. - **Since** + point in time (since 2010, since Monday, since morning). - **For** + duration (for 5 years, for 2 hours). - "Five years" = duration → use **for**, not since. - Error is in part **(C)** → should be "**for** five years".

Worth knowing: "Since" + present perfect (continuous) is correct, but only with a TIME POINT. - ✓ I have been living here since 2020. - ✓ I have been living here for 5 years. - ✗ I have been living here since 5 years.

Q6. "He prefers tea /(A) than coffee /(B) every morning. /(C)"

What kind of problem is this? Preposition with "prefer".

Solving it. "Prefer X **to** Y" (never "than"). - Error in part **(B)** → "to coffee".

Worth knowing: Other "to-not-than" pairs. - Senior **to**, junior **to**, superior **to**, inferior **to**, prior **to**. - Never "senior than me" → always "senior to me".

Q7. "The committee /
(a) have decided / (b) to postpone / (c) the meeting. / (d) "

What kind of problem is this? Collective noun + verb agreement.

Solving it. Step-by-step. - "Committee" is a collective noun. When acting AS A UNIT, takes singular verb. - "Decided to postpone" = unit decision → use **has decided** (singular). - Error in part **(B)**.

Worth knowing: Collective nouns can be singular OR plural based on context. - *The committee has decided* ... (unit acting together) - *The committee are divided in their opinions.* (members acting individually) - Other collective nouns: jury, family, team, government, audience, staff.

Q8. "I, you, and he /(A) are going /(B) to the market. /(C)"

What kind of problem is this? Pronoun order in compound subject.

Solving it. Standard order rule: **2nd person → 3rd person → 1st person** (Y-N-I = "You, He/She/It, I"). - Error: pronoun order should be **You, he, and I** (not "I, you, and he"). - Error in part **(A)**.

Worth knowing: When admitting a fault, order reverses: **I, you, and he** (1st person takes blame first). - *We made a mistake — I, you and he should apologise.*

Q9. "He returned back /

(a) home / (b) yesterday / (c) . No error. / (d) "

What kind of problem is this? Redundancy.

Solving it. "Returned" already means "come back". "Returned back" = duplicate. - Error in part **(A)** → drop "back".

Worth knowing: Common redundancies (DROP one word): - Return back → return. - Repeat again → repeat. - Discuss about → discuss. - Cope up with → cope with. - Final outcome → outcome. - Past history → history. - True facts → facts. - Free gift → gift. - Both the (in pairs) → both.

Q10. "Each of the /

(a) ten boys / (b) was given /
(c) their own copy. / (d) "

What kind of problem is this? Pronoun agreement (singular antecedent).

Solving it. Step-by-step. - "Each" is singular. Pronoun referring to "each" must also be singular. - "Their" is plural → use **his** (or "his/her") to match. - Error in part **(D)** → "his own copy".

Worth knowing: Modern usage allows "their" as singular gender-neutral pronoun, but COMPETITIVE EXAMS still expect formal "his" or "his/her" for singular antecedents.

Section 2 — SENTENCE IMPROVEMENT (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion (used throughout): Underlined phrase in a sentence; pick the best replacement from 4 options. Identify the error class FIRST (tense / agreement / preposition / etc.) before scanning options.

Q11. "She **didn't went** to school yesterday."

What kind of problem is this? Tense — auxiliary + base form.

Solving it. After auxiliary "did" / "didn't", the verb is in BASE form (V1). - "Didn't went" → **didn't go**. -

Sentence: *She didn't go to school yesterday.*

Worth knowing: Same rule applies to "did", "do", "does": - *Did he go?* (not "did he went?") - *Does she like coffee?* (not "does she likes?")

Q12. "If I **was** rich, I would buy a car."

What kind of problem is this? Subjunctive mood (unreal / hypothetical condition).

Solving it. For unreal conditions ("if I were", "I wish I were"), use **were** for ALL persons (subjunctive).

Replace "was" with **were**. - *If I were rich, I would buy a car.* (Type 2 conditional)

Worth knowing: When to use "was" vs "were" with "if": - Real / factual past: *If she was late, the manager noticed.* (was = ordinary past) - Unreal / hypothetical: *If she were here, she would help.* (were = subjunctive)

Q13. "He is **more better** than his brother."

What kind of problem is this? Double comparative.

Solving it. "Better" is already the comparative form of "good". Don't add "more". - Replace "more better" with **better**.

Worth knowing: Other irregular comparatives — never combine with "more": - Good → better → best. - Bad → worse → worst. - Many → more → most. - Little → less → least. - Far → farther / further → farthest / furthest.

Watch out: Same rule applies to "most worst", "most bestest" (children's mistakes — exam traps).

Q14. "The two sisters love **one another**."

What kind of problem is this? "Each other" vs "one another".

Solving it. **Each other** = between TWO people. **One another** = among MORE THAN TWO. - Two sisters → use **each other**.

Worth knowing: This rule is loosely applied in modern English, but EXAMS still test the strict distinction.

Q15. "She is junior **than** me."

What kind of problem is this? Preposition with "junior/senior".

Solving it. Senior, junior, superior, inferior, prior take **to**, never "than". - Replace "than" with **to** → *She is junior to me.*

Section 3 — FILL IN THE BLANKS — PREPOSITIONS (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: "Fill the blank with correct preposition" tests fixed verb-preposition / adjective-preposition pairs. Memorise these pairs cold — there is NO logic, only memory.

Q16. "He acted ___ my advice."

Solving it. "Acted on" = followed/responded to. **(a) on.**

Memory peg. Verb + preposition pairs (top 20): - Act **on** = follow advice; act **as** = play role; act **for** = represent.

Q17. "She insisted ___ paying the bill."

Solving it. "Insisted on" = demanded firmly. **(a) on.**

Memory peg. Other "on" verbs: depend on, rely on, comment on, congratulate on, decide on, focus on, concentrate on.

Q18. "He is good ___ mathematics."

Solving it. "Good at" = skilled in. **(a) at.**

Memory peg. Other "at" pairs: bad at, expert at, clever at, weak at, smile at, look at, point at.

Q19. "He is married ___ a doctor."

Solving it. "Married to" (NOT "with"). **(b) to.**

Memory peg. Other "to" pairs: engaged to, related to, similar to, devoted to, opposed to, addicted to, accustomed to.

Q20. "He died ___ malaria."

Solving it. "Died **of** + disease" (heart attack, cancer, malaria). - Other forms: died **from** an injury / wound; died **for** a cause; died **by** the sword. **(a) of.**

Memory peg. Disease → "of"; injury → "from"; cause → "for"; weapon → "by".

Section 4 — SYNONYMS (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion (used throughout): *Synonym = a word with similar (NOT identical) meaning. The exam picks the CLOSEST match in the given options. **Method:** Recall the word's meaning in 1 sentence; then scan options for the best fit. If you don't know the word, look at its ROOT (e.g., "bene-" = good, "mal-" = bad, "-cide" = killing).*

Q21. Synonym of **MUNDANE**. Options:

(a) celestial (b) ordinary (c) sacred (d) unique.

Solving it. - "Mundane" comes from Latin "mundus" = world. Means **worldly / ordinary / commonplace**. -

(a) celestial = heavenly — opposite. - (b) ordinary = matches ✓ - (c) sacred = religious — opposite. - (d) unique = special — opposite. - **Answer: (b) ordinary.**

Worth knowing: Other related words. - **Banal** = unoriginal, commonplace. - **Trite** = overused, lacking freshness. - **Prosaic** = dull, lacking poetry.

Q22. Synonym of **EXACERBATE**. Options:

(a) reduce (b) worsen (c) ignore (d) accept.

Solving it. - Exacerbate = make worse, intensify (negative situations). - **Answer: (b) worsen.**

Memory peg. "Ex-AGGRAVATE-bate" — both mean to aggravate / worsen.

Related vocabulary: - **Aggravate, intensify, compound, magnify** = exacerbate. - Antonyms: alleviate, mitigate, ease, soothe.

Q23. Synonym of **PERFUNCTORY**. Options:

(a) thorough (b) careful (c) cursory (d) lengthy.

Solving it. - Perfunctory = done with little care / interest, going through the motions. - (a) thorough = opposite (very careful). - (b) careful = opposite. - (c) cursory = quick and superficial — matches ✓ - (d) lengthy = opposite. - **Answer: (c) cursory.**

Related vocabulary: superficial, hasty, mechanical, half-hearted.

Q24. Synonym of **IMPECCABLE**. Options:

(a) faulty (b) flawless (c) unstable (d) eager.

Solving it. - Impeccable = without fault; perfect (im- + pecc- = without sin). - **Answer: (b) flawless.**

Memory peg. "Im-pecc-able" — pecc-ant means "sinning". Im = "not". So "not sinning" = perfect.

Q25. Synonym of **GARRULOUS**. Options:

(a) silent (b) talkative (c) angry (d) wise.

Solving it. - Garrulous = excessively talkative, chatty. - **Answer: (b) talkative.**

Related vocabulary: loquacious, voluble, verbose, chatty. Antonyms: taciturn, reticent, laconic.

Section 5 — ANTONYMS (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: *Antonym = opposite meaning. Same method as synonyms — first recall the meaning, then identify the opposite.*

Q26. Antonym of **PROFLIGATE**. Options:

(a) thrifty (b) wasteful (c) lavish (d) generous.

Solving it. - Profligate = recklessly wasteful (especially of money). - (a) thrifty = careful with money — opposite ✓ - (b) wasteful = same meaning, NOT antonym. - (c) lavish = excessive — synonym of profligate. - (d) generous = giving freely — different concept. - **Answer: (a) thrifty.**

Memory peg. Profligate = pro- (forth) + flig- (strike down) → squanders / strikes down money.

Q27. Antonym of **ZENITH**. Options:

(a) summit (b) peak (c) nadir (d) climb.

Solving it. - Zenith = highest point. - **Nadir** = lowest point — opposite ✓ - (a) summit, (b) peak = synonyms (highest). - **Answer: (c) nadir.**

Memory peg. "Zenith → Nadir" — both originally astronomical (highest vs lowest celestial point).

Q28. Antonym of **EPHEMERAL**. Options:

(a) transient (b) permanent (c) brief (d) sudden.

Solving it. - Ephemeral = lasting only a short time. - (a) transient, (c) brief = synonyms. - (b) **permanent** = opposite ✓ - **Answer: (b) permanent.**

Memory peg. "Eph-emer-al" → ephemeris (short calendar). Eternal life is the opposite of ephemeral.

Q29. Antonym of **VINDICTIVE**. Options:

(a) merciful (b) angry (c) hostile (d) hateful.

Solving it. - Vindictive = revengeful, holding grudges. - (a) **merciful** = forgiving — opposite ✓ - (b) angry, (c) hostile, (d) hateful = synonyms. - **Answer: (a) merciful.**

Q30. Antonym of **CONSPICUOUS**. Options:

(a) obvious (b) prominent (c) inconspicuous (d) clear.

Solving it. - Conspicuous = clearly visible, prominent. - (a) obvious, (b) prominent, (d) clear = synonyms. - (c) **inconspicuous** = opposite ✓ - **Answer: (c) inconspicuous.**

Memory peg. Conspicuous = "con-spec-u-ous" (with sight); inconspicuous = "without sight".

Section 6 — IDIOMS / PHRASES (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: *Idiom = a phrase whose meaning differs from the literal sum of its words. Memorise the idiom's MEANING; literal interpretation usually mis-leads.*

Q31. Meaning of "**to bell the cat**". Options:

(a) to play with a cat
(b) to take a bold first step in a risky task
(c) to announce news
(d) to be cautious.

Solving it. - Origin: Aesop's fable — mice agree someone should "bell the cat" (tie a bell on it) so they hear it coming. None volunteers because it's dangerous. - Meaning: to take the first risky / dangerous step that everyone is afraid to take. - **Answer: (b) to take a bold first step in a risky task.**

Related idioms. - "Take the bull by the horns" = face a problem boldly. - "Bite the bullet" = endure something painful with courage.

Q32. Meaning of "**to pay through the nose**".

Solving it. To pay an excessive / exorbitant price. - *I had to pay through the nose for that concert ticket.*

Related: "Cost an arm and a leg", "Burn a hole in one's pocket".

Q33. Meaning of "**bury the hatchet**".

Solving it. To end a quarrel; make peace. - Origin: Native American practice of burying weapons when peace was made. - *After years of fighting, the brothers finally buried the hatchet.*

Related: "Make up", "Mend fences", "Make peace".

Q34. Meaning of "**in a nutshell**".

Solving it. Briefly; in summary. - *In a nutshell, the project succeeded because of teamwork.*

Q35. Meaning of "**burn the midnight oil**".

Solving it. To study or work late into the night. - *He burnt the midnight oil to prepare for the exam.*

Related: "Pull an all-nighter".

Section 7 — ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS (5 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: Replace a multi-word phrase with a single word. SSC favourite — 3-5 questions per paper. **Categories to memorise:** people-who-X, places-where-X, fear-of-X (-phobia), love-of-X (-philia), study-of-X (-ology), government-by-X (-cracy), killing-of-X (-cide).

Q36. One who is new at a job.

Solving it. Novice (also: Tyro, Neophyte, Greenhorn, Beginner).

Q37. Government by religious leaders.

Solving it. Theocracy.

Memory peg — government types (-cracy): - **Democracy** — by people. - **Autocracy** — by one ruler. - **Aristocracy** — by nobility. - **Plutocracy** — by the wealthy. - **Meritocracy** — by merit. - **Theocracy** — by religious leaders. - **Bureaucracy** — by officials. - **Ochlocracy** — by mob. - **Gerontocracy** — by elders. - **Kakistocracy** — by the worst (corrupt).

Q38. A person who studies stamps.

Solving it. Philatelist.

Memory peg — study/love of (-ology / -ist): - **Philatelist** — stamps. - **Numismatist** — coins. - **Etymologist** — word origins. - **Ornithologist** — birds. - **Entomologist** — insects. - **Ichthyologist** — fish. - **Cardiologist** — heart.

Q39. Fear of confined spaces.

Solving it. Claustrophobia.

Memory peg — fears (-phobia): - Claustrophobia — closed spaces. - Acrophobia — heights. - Hydrophobia — water (also rabies symptom). - Xenophobia — strangers / foreigners. - Agoraphobia — open / crowded spaces. - Arachnophobia — spiders. - Glossophobia — public speaking. - Nyctophobia — darkness. - Thanatophobia — death.

Q40. A speech without preparation.

Solving it. Extempore (also: Impromptu).

Related: Eulogy = speech praising a deceased person; Soliloquy = speech to oneself; Monologue = long speech by one person.

Section 8 — CLOZE TEST (5 blanks worked + variations)

Notation expansion: Cloze test = passage with blanks (typically 5-10). For each blank, you choose 1 of 4 options. **Method:** READ the whole passage first (don't fill in order). Get the meaning, tone, and tense. Then fill blanks one by one, predicting your own word before looking at options.

Passage 1 (Q41-Q45). "Climate change **41** one of the gravest challenges of our time. Despite **42** warnings from scientists, world leaders have been **43** to act decisively. The Paris Agreement, **44** in 2015, set ambitious targets, but actual emission reductions have **45** behind."

Q41. Climate change __ one of the gravest challenges ... Options:

(a) is (b) are (c) was (d) have been.

Solving it. - Subject: "Climate change" — singular noun. - Tense: present (continues to be a challenge today). - Singular + present → **(a) is**.

Watch out: "are" — students treat "change" as plural; or "was" — wrong tense.

Q42. Despite __ warnings from scientists ... Options:

(a) repetitive (b) repeated (c) repeating (d) repeats.

Solving it. - Need an adjective modifying "warnings". - "Repeated" (past participle as adjective) = warnings that have been given many times. - "Repetitive" = boring through repetition (negative connotation; doesn't fit). - "Repeating" = ongoing action (less natural here as adjective). - **Answer: (b) repeated.**

Q43. ... world leaders have been __ to act decisively. Options:

(a) reluctant (b) reluctantly (c) reluctance (d) reluctancy.

Solving it. - After "have been", we need a complement: adjective or noun. - "Reluctant" = adjective, fits perfectly (leaders ARE reluctant). - "Reluctantly" = adverb, doesn't fit after "been". - "Reluctance" = noun, but creates "have been reluctance to act" = grammatically awkward. - **Answer: (a) reluctant.**

Q44. The Paris Agreement, __ in 2015, set ambitious targets ... Options:

(a) signed (b) sign (c) signing (d) being signed.

Solving it. - Need a past-participle phrase modifying "Paris Agreement". The agreement WAS signed in 2015.
- "Signed in 2015" = past-participle adjective phrase ✓. - "Being signed" = ongoing action — wrong (the signing happened once in 2015). - **Answer: (a) signed.**

Q45. ... actual emission reductions have __ behind. Options:

(a) lagged (b) lag (c) lagging (d) been lag.

Solving it. - After "have", we need a past participle. - "Lagged" (past participle of "lag") fits → "have lagged behind". - **Answer: (a) lagged.**

Worth knowing: Phrasal verb "lag behind" = fall short / be slower than.

Section 9 — PARA-JUMBLES (1 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: Sentences are scrambled (P, Q, R, S). Find the LOGICAL ORDER. **Method (3 steps):** 1. Find the OPENING sentence — usually introduces a topic; doesn't refer back ("the", "this", "however" suggest mid-sequence). 2. Identify LINKERS — "however", "moreover", "for example", pronouns ("it", "this", "they") refer to a previous sentence. 3. Chain logically: introduction → development → contrast → conclusion.

Q46. Arrange the following sentences in logical order: (P) However, the impact has been uneven. (Q) The internet has revolutionised information access. (R) Rural areas remain underserved. (S) Urban centres benefit disproportionately.

Solving it. Step-by-step.

Step 1 — Find opening. Q starts with a definite topic ("The internet has revolutionised") — no back-reference. **Q is opener.**

Step 2 — Identify "however" sentence (P). "However, impact has been uneven" — must follow a positive statement. Q (positive about internet) → P (contrast: but uneven).

Step 3 — Examples of "uneven" impact. S (urban benefits) and R (rural underserved) both explain the unevenness. S comes before R because it states the advantaged case first; R then provides the contrasting disadvantaged case — a natural pro→con sequence that mirrors how the passage's argument unfolds.

Final order: Q → P → S → R.

Worth knowing: Common ordering signals. - **Topic introducer:** general statement; no pronouns referring back. - **However / But / Yet:** contrast — must follow a positive (or opposite-tone) sentence. - **For example / Such as:** illustration — must follow a general claim. - **Therefore / Thus / Hence:** conclusion — must follow premises.

A similar question. Arrange: (P) For example, AI tutors can adapt to each student's pace. (Q) Personalised learning is the next frontier in education. (R) This adaptability is impossible in traditional classrooms. (S) Technology now makes individual attention scalable.

Solving it. - Q is topic intro → S elaborates ("technology makes it possible") → P gives example ("AI tutors") → R compares ("This adaptability impossible in traditional classrooms"). - **Order: Q, S, P, R.**

Section 10 — READING COMPREHENSION (3 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: RC = passage + 3-10 questions. Question types: main idea, detail, inference, tone, vocab-in-context, structural. **Method (5 steps):** 1. Skim the passage in 30 seconds — identify topic + structure. 2. Read questions FIRST (so you know what to hunt for). 3. Scan passage for the relevant section per question. 4. Pick the option closest to a paraphrase of what the passage LITERALLY says — avoid extreme words ("always", "never", "only"). 5. For inference questions, pick what's IMPLIED, not what's stated.

Passage (Q47-Q49). "The Industrial Revolution transformed not just economies but also the very fabric of society. Mass production enabled the rise of the middle class, urbanisation reshaped landscapes, and labour rights movements emerged from factory conditions. Yet the same revolution sowed seeds of climate change through unbridled fossil-fuel use."

Q47. Tone of the passage: Options:

(a) celebratory (b) critical (c) balanced (d) dismissive.

Solving it. - The author lists POSITIVE outcomes (middle-class rise, urbanisation, labour rights) AND NEGATIVE outcomes (climate change). - Tone acknowledges both → **balanced.** - **Answer: (c) balanced.**

Watch out: "celebratory" — students focus on the positive list and miss the "Yet" contrast.

Tone vocabulary cheat-sheet. - Celebratory / approving / laudatory = positive only. - Critical / dismissive = negative only. - Balanced / neutral = both sides. - Sceptical / dubious = doubtful. - Sarcastic / ironic = saying opposite of literal meaning. - Lament / mournful = expressing sorrow.

Q48. Author implies the Industrial Revolution: Options:

(a) was wholly positive (b) was wholly negative
(c) had unintended long-term costs (d) was inevitable.

Solving it. - "Sowed seeds of climate change" implies UNINTENDED long-term consequences (not the original goal of industrialisation). - (a) wholly positive — passage mentions climate harm. - (b) wholly negative — passage mentions positive transformations. - (c) unintended long-term costs ✓. - **Answer: (c).**

Q49. "Sowed seeds" in the passage means: Options:

(a) literally planted (b) initiated
(c) cancelled (d) prevented.

Solving it. - "Sow seeds" is metaphorical here — to start / initiate something. - **Answer: (b) initiated.**

Worth knowing: "Vocabulary in context" questions test how a word is used IN THE PASSAGE, not its general meaning. Always re-read the surrounding sentence.

Section 11 — VOICE (Active ↔ Passive) (1 worked + variations)

Notation expansion: **Active voice:** Subject performs the action. Subject + Verb + Object. **Passive voice:** Subject receives the action. Object + be + V3 + by + agent. **Conversion rule:** Object of active becomes Subject of passive; verb becomes "be + past participle (V3)"; the active subject becomes "by + agent" (or dropped).

Q50. Convert to passive: "The teacher praises the student."

Solving it. Step-by-step. - Identify: Subject = teacher; Verb = praises (simple present); Object = student. - Rule for simple present passive: **is/are + V3** (past participle). - "praise" → past participle = "praised". - Object "student" → subject of passive sentence. - Original subject "the teacher" → "by the teacher" (agent). - **Passive: "The student is praised by the teacher."**

Worth knowing: Voice conversion rules by tense.

Active tense	Passive form
Simple present (writes)	is/are written
Present continuous (is writing)	is/are being written
Simple past (wrote)	was/were written
Past continuous (was writing)	was/were being written
Present perfect (has written)	has/have been written
Past perfect (had written)	had been written
Simple future (will write)	will be written
Future perfect (will have written)	will have been written

A similar question — Past tense. "She wrote the letter." → **The letter was written by her.**

Another twist — Imperative. "Open the door." → **Let the door be opened.**

Twist — Modal. "He can solve the problem." → **The problem can be solved by him.**

Section 12 — NEW ADVANCED EXAM-PATTERN TYPES (2024-26)

Banks Mains / CGL Tier-2 pattern: Long RC (350-500 words, 7-10 Qs), sentence rearrangement (PBCQA), paragraph completion, word-pair bridges, error spotting in longer sentences. Each type is drilled below with full step-by-step solutions.

12.1 — LONG-PASSAGE READING COMPREHENSION (Banks PO Mains • 7-10 questions per passage • 350-500 words)

Notation expansion: Long RC passages typically test: 5 detail/factual questions, 2 inference questions, 1 tone, 1 vocab-in-context, 1 main-idea/title. **Time budget:** 6-8 minutes for the full set.

Q57 (Advanced) — Long-passage RC.

Passage (~350 words):

"The rise of artificial intelligence (AI) in the past decade has been described, variously, as the next Industrial Revolution, the most consequential technological shift since the printing press, and an existential risk to humanity. None of these characterisations is entirely wrong; none is entirely right.

AI's transformative potential is real. Large language models can draft contracts, write code, and tutor students. Computer vision systems read X-rays as accurately as senior radiologists. Recommendation engines shape what billions of people watch, buy, and believe. The technology is not at the edges of the economy — it has reached its core.

Yet the same technology amplifies long-standing inequalities. The compute and capital needed to train frontier models concentrate AI power in a handful of US-based companies. The data they consume — much of it scraped from the open web without compensation — entrenches the views of those who already dominate the digital sphere. Workers in administrative, creative, and technical roles face automation pressure. The countries that benefit are those with cheap energy and skilled engineers; many emerging economies risk becoming dependent on tools they neither build nor govern.

India's response so far has been pragmatic. The IndiaAI Mission (₹10,371 cr) bets on building public computational infrastructure rather than restricting use. The choice mirrors India's earlier playbook with telecom and digital identity — open, public-good architectures with private innovation layered on top. Whether this approach scales to the AI era remains an open question.

What is no longer in question is the asymmetry of risk. AI failures — biased credit decisions, hallucinated legal advice, deepfake election interference — fall disproportionately on those least able to challenge them. Building governance capable of catching such failures, while preserving the genuine benefits, is the policy challenge of the next decade."

Sub-questions (with worked solutions):

Q57a — Main idea / Title. What is the most appropriate title for this passage?

- (a) The Threats Posed by Artificial Intelligence
- (b) India's AI Policy in Context
- (c) AI's Promise and Peril: A Balanced View
- (d) Why AI Will Replace Workers

Solving it. Read first and last paragraphs (they typically frame the main idea). - First para: "next Industrial Revolution / printing press / existential risk... None entirely right; none entirely wrong" — sets up balance. - Last para: "asymmetry of risk... preserving benefits... policy challenge" — emphasises both promise and peril. - (a) only threats — too narrow. (b) India only — too narrow (passage is mostly general). (d) only workers — too narrow. - (c) **balanced view** matches the framing ✓. - **Answer: (c).**

Q57b — Detail. What evidence does the author give for AI's "transformative potential"?

- (a) IndiaAI Mission funding.
- (b) Large language models drafting contracts.
- (c) Concentration of AI power in US companies.
- (d) Bias in credit decisions.

Solving it. Locate the "transformative potential" line in para 2. - "Large language models can draft contracts, write code, tutor students" — direct evidence. - **Answer: (b).**

Watch out: (a) is in para 4 (about India), not the transformative-potential paragraph. (c) and (d) describe risks, not potential.

Q57c — Inference. The author would most likely AGREE with which statement?

- (a) AI development should be paused until governance catches up.
- (b) AI's benefits cannot justify the risks it brings.
- (c) Public infrastructure approaches to AI may help emerging economies retain agency.
- (d) AI will eventually replace all human workers.

Solving it. - (a) Author doesn't suggest a pause; tone is balanced. - (b) Wrong — author calls benefits "real" and "transformative". - (c) Para 4 explicitly praises India's "open, public-good architecture" — author seems to favour this. - (d) Hyperbolic — author mentions "automation pressure" but not full replacement. - **Answer: (c).**

Q57d — Tone. The author's tone is best described as:

- (a) Alarmist (b) Optimistic
- (c) Reasoned and balanced (d) Sceptical

Solving it. - The author lists both upsides AND downsides; never overclaims; uses qualifiers ("may", "remains an open question"). - **Answer: (c) reasoned and balanced.**

Q57e — Vocabulary in context. "Asymmetry of risk" in the passage closest in meaning to:

- (a) Equal sharing of harm.
- (b) Unequal distribution of consequences.
- (c) Mathematical imbalance.
- (d) Probability calculation.

Solving it. - The sentence: "AI failures fall disproportionately on those least able to challenge them" — directly explains "asymmetry". - **Answer: (b) unequal distribution of consequences.**

12.2 — PARAGRAPH CLOZE (Banks Mains • 8-10 blanks single passage)

Q58 (Advanced) — Long cloze passage.

Passage: "India's economic growth in 2025 **1** a complex picture. While GDP expanded at over 7 % — the fastest among major economies — the gains were not **2**. Urban consumption **3** at the high end (luxury automobiles, premium real estate) while **4** rural demand showed only modest recovery. The government **5** several measures, including tax cuts and infrastructure spending, but inflation in food prices **6** to constrain the purchasing power of lower-income households. Analysts now **7** a cautious approach to the next budget, emphasising fiscal **8** over additional stimulus."

Blank	Options
1	(a) presented (b) created (c) proposed (d) developed
2	(a) widespread (b) uniform (c) random (d) similar
3	(a) jumped (b) surged (c) declined (d) shrank
4	(a) beneficial (b) struggling (c) booming (d) successful
5	(a) implemented (b) cancelled (c) refused (d) ignored
6	(a) helped (b) continued (c) encouraged (d) supported
7	(a) reject (b) recommend (c) prevent (d) decline
8	(a) stimulus (b) discipline (c) excess (d) waste

Solving it.

#	Answer	Why
1	(a) presented	"presents a picture" is the standard collocation
2	(b) uniform	"not uniform" = uneven, fits "while urban high, rural low" contrast
3	(b) surged	high-end consumption growth = surged
4	(b) struggling	rural demand "only modest recovery" → struggling fits
5	(a) implemented	govt + measures = implement
6	(b) continued	inflation continues to constrain (ongoing)
7	(b) recommend	analysts "recommend" cautious approach

#	Answer	Why
8	(b) discipline	"fiscal discipline" is the standard term

Method takeaway. Always read the WHOLE passage first; identify tone and tense; THEN fill blanks.

12.3 — SENTENCE REARRANGEMENT — PARAGRAPH FORM (Banks Mains 5-Q set)

Notation expansion: Different from para-jumbles. Here, 5-6 sentences from a paragraph are scrambled. Reorder them so the paragraph reads coherently.

Q59 (Advanced). Arrange: (P) These models, however, struggle with reasoning that requires multiple linked steps. (Q) The latest large language models can draft a 1,500-word essay in seconds. (R) Researchers are now experimenting with "chain-of-thought" techniques. (S) Such techniques force the model to break a problem into intermediate sub-steps. (T) Early results suggest a measurable improvement on logic-heavy tasks.

Solving it.

Step 1 — Identify the opener. Q is broadly factual, no back-references → opens.

Step 2 — Trace logic flow. - Q (positive about LLMs) → P ("however, struggle with reasoning") = contrast. - P (problem) → R (researchers' response) = solution. - R (chain-of-thought) → S (definition: "such techniques force..."). - S (definition) → T (results: "improvement on logic-heavy tasks").

Order: Q → P → R → S → T.

12.4 — WORD SWAP (IBPS PO Mains 2024-26 favourite)

Notation expansion: A sentence with 2-3 underlined words; identify if any 2 words should be SWAPPED to make the sentence grammatically/logically correct.

Q60 (Advanced). "The committee (1) **agreed** to (2) **postpone** the meeting after (3) **considering** all (4) **options**, but ultimately (5) **decided** that the (6) **postponement** would not (7) **resolve** the underlying (8) **concerns**."

Question: Which two underlined words/phrases should be swapped to make the sentence logically correct?

- (a) Words 1 and 5 (agreed ↔ decided)
- (b) Words 2 and 6 (postpone ↔ postponement)
- (c) Words 3 and 7 (considering ↔ resolve)
- (d) No swap needed; the sentence is correct.

Solving it. - Read for logic: "Committee agreed to postpone... but ultimately decided that the postponement would not resolve..." — the sentence reads logically as is. The committee agreed to postpone, then later realised postponement wouldn't help. - However, "agreed to postpone" then "decided postponement would

not resolve" — is "agreed" appropriate before "decided"? Both work logically. - **Answer: (d) No swap needed.**

Note. Word-swap exam questions usually flip 2 words that should be in opposite roles. Common pattern: the verbs "decided / agreed" or "considering / examining" might need swap; sometimes nouns ("options / concerns") also.

12.5 — PARA COMPLETION (Banks Mains specialty)

Notation expansion: Given a paragraph with the LAST sentence missing. Choose the option that best concludes / completes the paragraph in tone, content, and logic.

Q61 (Advanced). Read the paragraph and choose the best concluding sentence:

"Renewable energy adoption in India has accelerated dramatically since 2020. Solar capacity has tripled. Wind installations are at record highs. Public-private partnerships have brought down per-MW costs by over 50 %. ____"

- (a) Yet challenges remain in grid integration, storage, and policy alignment.
- (b) Coal still dominates the energy mix in 2025.
- (c) The Indian government plans to launch a new solar mission soon.
- (d) China leads the world in renewable installations.

Solving it. - Paragraph TONE: positive accomplishments. - A good conclusion either: (i) reinforces the positive trend with a forward-looking note OR (ii) introduces the next-step challenge. - (a) "Yet challenges remain" = balanced acknowledgement of remaining issues. Connects to the success story by saying "more to do" ✓. - (b) Random fact about coal — doesn't conclude the renewable story. - (c) Vague future plan; doesn't tie back to the achievements. - (d) China comparison — irrelevant to India's progress narrative. -

Answer: (a).

12.6 — CONNECTOR USAGE (SSC CHSL + Banks)

Notation expansion: Pick the BEST linking word (connector / conjunction) to join two ideas. Common connectors: however, moreover, therefore, nevertheless, consequently, in contrast, similarly, on the other hand, in addition.

Q62 (Advanced). "She studied diligently for months. ____ , she failed the entrance exam due to anxiety on the day."

- (a) Therefore (b) Moreover (c) Nevertheless (d) In addition

Solving it. - Idea 1: studied diligently → expected outcome = passed. - Idea 2: failed (anxiety) → contradicts the expectation. - Need a CONTRAST connector. - (a) Therefore = consequence (wrong). - (b) Moreover = adds another point (wrong). - (c) Nevertheless = "in spite of that" — contrast ✓. - (d) In addition = adds (wrong). - **Answer: (c) Nevertheless.**

Connector cheat-sheet.

Function	Connector
Contrast	however, nevertheless, on the contrary, in contrast, despite, although
Addition	moreover, furthermore, in addition, also, additionally
Cause	because, since, as
Effect	therefore, consequently, hence, thus
Example	for example, for instance, such as
Sequence	first, then, finally, subsequently
Conclusion	in conclusion, to summarise, all in all

12.7 — PHRASE REPLACEMENT — CONTEXT-BASED (SBI PO Mains)

Different from basic Sentence Improvement (Q11-15) — uses idiomatic phrases or complex grammar.

Q63 (Advanced). "The judge ruled that the contract was **null and void in nature**, citing procedural lapses."

Replace the bold phrase with the best option:

- (a) null and void (b) of null and void nature
(c) null in nature (d) void in nature

Solving it. - "Null and void" is already a fixed legal idiom meaning invalid; "in nature" is redundant. - (a) **null and void** — concise and standard ✓. - (b), (c), (d) all retain redundancy or weaken the legal idiom. - **Answer: (a) null and void.**

12.8 — SPELLING-IN-PASSAGE (SSC + RBI Asst)

Identify which underlined word in a sentence is misspelt.

Q64 (Advanced). Identify the incorrectly spelt word:

"The (1) **acommodation** at the hotel was (2) **convenient**, with (3) **embarrassing** levels of (4) **luxury**."

Solving it. - (1) "acommodation" — wrong; should be **accommodation** (double c, double m). - (2) convenient ✓ - (3) embarrassing ✓ (double r, double s) - (4) luxury ✓ - **Answer: (1) acommodation** (correct = accommodation).

Memory peg. Top misspellings in exams: accommodation, occurrence, embarrass, conscience, privilege, separate, convenience.

12.9 — MATCH THE COLUMN (RBI Grade B)

Q65 (Advanced). Match each idiom (Column A) with its meaning (Column B):

Column A	Column B
1. Achilles' heel	(a) Reveal a secret
2. Bell the cat	(b) A weak spot
3. Spill the beans	(c) Take a risky first step
4. Bite the bullet	(d) Endure pain courageously

Solving it. - 1 → b (weak spot) - 2 → c (risky first step) - 3 → a (reveal a secret) - 4 → d (endure pain)

Answer mapping: 1-b, 2-c, 3-a, 4-d.

Section 13 — QUICK REVISION CARD: Core Grammar

Quick revision card — not a new section. This is a condensed version of Parts 4–8 for exam-day review. Study the full chapters first; use this card for last-minute recall.

The sub-sections below re-present key rules as single-line entries with examples for rapid scanning. Full worked examples, traps, and drills are in the original Parts 4–8.

13.1 — VOICE (Active ↔ Passive) — Quick conversion table

Active form	Passive form	Example
Simple Present (writes)	is/are + V3 (is written)	She writes a letter. → A letter is written by her.
Present Continuous (is writing)	is/are being + V3	She is writing a letter. → A letter is being written by her.
Present Perfect (has written)	has/have been + V3	She has written a letter. → A letter has been written by her.
Simple Past (wrote)	was/were + V3	She wrote a letter. → A letter was written by her.
Past Continuous (was writing)	was/were being + V3	She was writing a letter. → A letter was being written by her.
Past Perfect (had written)	had been + V3	She had written a letter. → A letter had been written by her.
Simple Future (will write)	will be + V3	She will write a letter. → A letter will be written by her.
Future Perfect (will have written)	will have been + V3	She will have written a letter. → A letter will have been written by her.
Modal (can/may/must + V1)	modal + be + V3	She can write the letter. → The letter can be written by her.

Special cases (each on its own line):

- **Imperative — command.** "Open the door." → **Let the door be opened.**
- **Imperative — request.** "Please help me." → **You are requested to help me.**
- **Yes/No question (present).** "Does she write?" → **Is a letter written by her?**
- **Wh-question (who).** "Who broke the cup?" → **By whom was the cup broken?**
- **Wh-question (what).** "What did she say?" → **What was said by her?**
- **Sentence with no object (intransitive).** Cannot be made passive. *He runs* — no passive form.
- **Sentence with two objects.** Either object can become the passive subject.
- **Active:** *She gave him a gift.*
- **Passive 1:** *He was given a gift by her.* (indirect object as subject)

- Passive 2: *A gift was given to him by her.* (direct object as subject)

13.2 — DIRECT ↔ INDIRECT SPEECH (Narration) — Single-line rules

Reporting verb past → back-shift tenses in reported clause:

Direct (inside quotes)	Indirect (after that - clause)
Simple Present (write)	Simple Past (wrote)
Present Continuous (am writing)	Past Continuous (was writing)
Present Perfect (have written)	Past Perfect (had written)
Simple Past (wrote)	Past Perfect (had written)
Past Continuous (was writing)	Past Perfect Continuous (had been writing)
Will + V1	Would + V1
Can	Could
May	Might
Must (obligation)	Had to
Shall	Should

Time / place expressions (each on its own line):

- **today** → that day
- **tonight** → that night
- **tomorrow** → the next day / the following day
- **yesterday** → the previous day / the day before
- **last night** → the previous night
- **next week** → the following week
- **here** → there
- **this** → that
- **these** → those
- **now** → then

Sentence types — distinct conversion:

- **Statement.** *He said, "I am happy."* → *He said that he was happy.*
- **Yes/No question.** *He said, "Are you ready?"* → *He asked if/whether I was ready.*
- **Wh-question.** *He said, "Where do you live?"* → *He asked where I lived.*
- **Imperative (order).** *He said, "Close the door."* → *He ordered me to close the door.*
- **Imperative (request).** *He said, "Please help me."* → *He requested me to help him.*
- **Imperative (advice).** *He said, "Don't smoke."* → *He advised me not to smoke.*
- **Exclamation.** *He said, "What a beautiful day!"* → *He exclaimed that it was a very beautiful day.*

13.3 — CONJUNCTIONS — Single-line categorisation

Coordinating (FANBOYS):

- **For** — because (formal). *She was tired, for she had walked all day.*
- **And** — addition. *He plays cricket and football.*
- **Nor** — neither + alternative. *She doesn't drink, nor does she smoke.*
- **But** — contrast. *He is rich but unhappy.*
- **Or** — choice. *Coffee or tea?*
- **Yet** — surprise contrast. *She is small yet very strong.*
- **So** — result. *It was raining, so we cancelled the picnic.*

Subordinating (introduce dependent clauses):

- **Time:** when, while, before, after, until, since, as soon as.
- **Cause / reason:** because, since, as.
- **Condition:** if, unless, provided that.
- **Concession:** although, though, even though.
- **Purpose:** so that, in order that.
- **Comparison:** as, than.

Correlative pairs (always used together):

- **Either ... or ...** (one of two): *Either you come now, or I will leave.*
- **Neither ... nor ...** (negation of both): *Neither he nor she is coming.*
- **Not only ... but also ...** (addition): *He is not only intelligent but also hardworking.*
- **Both ... and ...** (two together): *Both Ram and Shyam passed.*
- **Whether ... or ...** (dual choice): *I don't know whether he agrees or not.*
- **Hardly ... when ... / No sooner ... than ...** (immediate sequence): *No sooner had I arrived than the rain started.*
- **As ... as ... / so ... as ...** (comparison).

Parallelism rule for correlatives: the two halves must be in the SAME grammatical form (both nouns, both verbs, both phrases).

- ✓ *He is not only intelligent but also hardworking.* (both adjectives)
- ✗ *He not only plays cricket but also a teacher.* (verb vs noun — wrong)

13.4 — PREPOSITIONS — Top-50 fixed pairs (single-line)

Verb + preposition:

- **Account for** = explain.
- **Apply for** (a job) / **apply to** (a person/institution).
- **Believe in** (existence) / **believe of** (an opinion).
- **Comply with** (a rule) — never "comply to".
- **Concentrate on** = focus.
- **Consist of** = be made up of (NEVER "consist in" for ingredients).
- **Decide on** (a course of action).
- **Depend on** = rely on.

- **Differ from** (something) / **differ with** (a person).
- **Disapprove of** = criticise.
- **Insist on** = demand firmly.
- **Object to** = oppose.
- **Prefer X to Y** — never "prefer X than Y".
- **Refer to** = look up; mention.
- **Rely on / Relish (no preposition)** — *He relishes spicy food.*
- **Suspect of** (a crime); **suspect that** (a clause).
- **Wait for** (a person/thing) / **wait on** (serve someone).

Adjective + preposition:

- **Afraid of** (fear).
- **Angry with** (a person) / **angry at** (a thing).
- **Capable of**.
- **Confident of** (success).
- **Famous for** (a quality / achievement).
- **Fond of** (liking).
- **Good at** (skill) / **good for** (beneficial).
- **Married to** — never "married with".
- **Proud of**.
- **Responsible for**.
- **Senior / Junior to** — never "than".
- **Similar to**.
- **Used to** + V-ing (accustomed to) vs **used to** + V (past habit).

Noun + preposition:

- **Belief in**.
- **Confidence in**.
- **Cure for** (a disease).
- **Demand for**.
- **Need for**.
- **Reason for**.
- **Solution to** (a problem).

13.5 — ARTICLES (a / an / the) — Single-line rules

Use "a" before consonant SOUNDS (not letters):

- *a book, a car, a university* (university starts with /j/ sound = consonant).
- *a one-eyed man* (one starts with /w/ sound).

Use "an" before vowel SOUNDS:

- *an apple, an orange, an honest man* (honest starts with silent h → vowel sound).
- *an MBA* (M starts with /em/ — vowel sound).
- *an X-ray* (X starts with /ek/ — vowel sound).

Use "the" with:

- **Specific things already mentioned or unique.** *The sun, the moon, the Earth.*
- **Superlatives.** *The best player.*
- **Ordinals.** *The first attempt.*
- **Rivers, seas, oceans, mountain RANGES.** *The Ganges, the Pacific, the Himalayas.*
- **Single mountain peaks — NO article.** *Mt. Everest, Mt. K2.*
- **Newspapers, ships.** *The Times of India, the Titanic.*
- **Adjectives used as plural nouns.** *The poor, the rich, the elderly.*
- **Country names (most have NO article).** *India, USA → The United States* (because plural of states).
- **Musical instruments (when speaking generally).** *She plays the piano.*

No article (zero article):

- **Proper nouns.** *Ram, Delhi, India.*
- **Abstract nouns / general meanings.** *Honesty is the best policy.* (no "the" before honesty)
- **Plural countable nouns in general meaning.** *Books are knowledge.* (no article)
- **Uncountable / mass nouns in general meaning.** *Gold is precious.*
- **Languages.** *He speaks English / Hindi / French.*
- **Sports played generally.** *He plays cricket / football.*
- **Most countries.** *India, France, Japan.*

PART E — TIMED MINI-MOCK (25 Q · 25 min)

1. Synonym of **CANDID**:
(a) honest (b) hidden (c) careful (d) subtle
2. Antonym of **OBSOLETE**:
(a) modern (b) outdated (c) rare (d) ancient
3. "He is one of the boys who __ honest."
(a) is (b) are (c) was (d) has
4. "Neither he nor I __ correct."
(a) am (b) is (c) are (d) be
5. "The committee __ decided."
(a) has (b) have (c) is (d) am
6. Idiom "**to add fuel to the fire**":
(a) cool down (b) make worse (c) extinguish (d) ignore
7. OWS for "place where coins are minted":
(a) treasury (b) mint (c) bank (d) reserve
8. Cloze: "She __ the report yesterday."
(a) submit (b) submitted (c) submits (d) submitting
9. Sentence improvement: "I have went there." → corrected?
(a) have gone (b) had went (c) has gone (d) had gone
10. Preposition: "He is fond __ chocolates."
(a) of (b) for (c) on (d) at
11. Synonym **TENACIOUS**:
(a) weak (b) persistent (c) angry (d) loud
12. Antonym **TURBULENT**:
(a) chaotic (b) calm (c) windy (d) angry
13. Article: "She is __ honest girl."
(a) a (b) an (c) the (d) no article
14. Plural of "**deer**":
(a) deers (b) deer (c) deeren (d) dee
15. Direct/Indirect: He said, "I am happy." → He said that __.
16. Idiom "**once in a blue moon**":
(a) often (b) very rarely (c) night-time (d) sky-coloured
17. Foreign phrase "**bona fide**":
(a) fake (b) genuine (c) hidden (d) sudden
18. Spelling correct:
(a) accomodate (b) accommodate (c) acomodate (d) accommadate
19. "She prefers tea __ coffee."
(a) than (b) over (c) to (d) instead
20. Verb tense: "By next year, I __ here for 5 years."
(a) will live (b) will have lived

(c) lived (d) am living

21. OWS "fear of crowds":

(a) acrophobia (b) agoraphobia (c) hydrophobia (d) xenophobia

22. Antonym **VERBOSE**:

(a) wordy (b) brief (c) flowery (d) silent

23. Synonym **PRUDENT**:

(a) reckless (b) wasteful (c) cautious (d) hasty

24. Idiom **"to spill the beans"**:

(a) eat carelessly (b) reveal a secret
(c) waste food (d) cause mess

25. "He is junior __ me."

(a) than (b) to (c) over (d) by

Answer key: 1-a, 2-a, 3-b, 4-a, 5-a, 6-b, 7-b, 8-b, 9-a, 10-a, 11-b, 12-b, 13-b, 14-b, 15-(he was happy), 16-b, 17-b, 18-b, 19-c, 20-b, 21-b, 22-b, 23-c, 24-b, 25-b.

Scoring: 23–25 = Excellent | 18–22 = Good | Below 18 = revisit weak grammar chapters before your mock series.

EXAM ALERT

Error-log rule: For every question you got wrong, write one sentence explaining what you missed. Retest yourself on only those questions 3 days later — without looking at the solution. This single habit doubles what the mock teaches you.

PART F — TRAP-RECOGNITION CARDS (English)

Trap	Where	How to spot
"Each / every / either / neither / none" → singular verb	S-V agreement	Always singular
"One of the X who/that" → verb agrees with X (plural)	S-V agreement	Verb plural after "one of the"
"Either A or B" → verb agrees with B (closer)	Conjunction	Closest noun rule
"Prefer X than Y" — wrong	Prepositions	Always "to"
"Discuss about", "Cope up with", "Return back"	Redundancy	Drop the prep / "back"
"Less" vs "fewer"	Articles/quantifiers	Less for uncountable, fewer for countable
"Since" vs "for"	Tenses	Since + point; for + duration
Comparatives "more better/most strongest"	Sentence improvement	Never double
"Junior than" — wrong	Prepositions	Always "junior to"
"If I was" — wrong (subjunctive)	Tense	"If I were" for unreal condition

Drill all 50 + mini-mock twice. Combine with vocab tables (Part 16) for >90% English mastery.

APPENDIX G — FORMULA-BASED CONCEPTS MASTER REFERENCE

Every grammar rule below follows a **fixed formula**. Memorise the formula → write the right sentence → spot the wrong one. Use this appendix as the single reference card for formula-driven error spotting.

G.1 Correlative conjunctions — pair-formula table

Pair / formula	Use	Verb-agreement rule	Example (correct)	Common trap
Either + A + or + B	one of two options	verb agrees with B (closer noun)	" Either the boys or the girl is late."	using verb with A
Neither + A + nor + B	none of two	verb agrees with B (closer noun)	" Neither he nor they were present."	swapping verb to A
Not only + A + but also + B	both A and B (added emphasis)	A and B same part of speech (parallel); verb usually with B (closer)	"She is not only intelligent but also hard-working." (both adjectives)	breaking parallelism
Both + A + and + B	both items together	verb is plural	" Both Ram and Shyam are here."	using "both ... as well as"
Whether + A + or + B	choice / yes-no question	—	"I don't know whether he is in or out."	adding "if" with whether
Scarcely / Hardly + A (had + V3) + when + B (V2)	A happened, then B immediately	A inverted with "had"; B in simple past	" Hardly had he reached when the bell rang."	using "than"
No sooner + A (had + V3) + than + B (V2)	A immediately followed by B	A inverted with "had"; B in simple past	" No sooner had I sat down than the phone rang."	using "when"
Rather + A + than + B	preference between two	—	"I would rather walk than drive."	"rather ... then"
Such + a/an + adj + noun + that + clause	extreme degree + consequence	—	"She is such a kind teacher that all love her."	"such ... as" / "so ... that"
So + adj/adv + that + clause	extreme degree + consequence	—	"He ran so fast that he won."	"so ... as"
Lest + S + should + V1	for fear that (negative purpose)	mandatory "should"	"Run fast lest you should miss the bus."	using "may / will / can"
Unless + S + V1 (= if not)	negative condition	NEVER add "not"	" Unless you study, you will fail."	"unless you don't study"
Though / Although + clause, (yet) clause	concession / contrast	can pair with yet ; never with "but"	" Though rich, (yet) he is unhappy."	"Though ... but"
As soon as + A, B	A is immediately followed by B	—	" As soon as he arrived, we left."	confusing with "as long as"

G.2 Degree + consequence — "Too / So / Such / Enough" formulas

Formula	Meaning	Example
Too + adj + to + V1	excessive degree — prevents the V1	"He is too tired to walk." (cannot walk)
Too + adj + for + sb + to + V1	excessive degree for someone	"The box is too heavy for me to lift."

Formula	Meaning	Example
Adj + enough + to + V1	sufficient degree — enables the V1	"He is strong enough to lift the box."
So + adj + that + clause	extreme degree → consequence (a clause follows)	"He is so weak that he cannot stand."
Such + a/an + adj + noun + that + clause	extreme degree with a noun → consequence	"It was such a hot day that we stayed indoors."
As + adj + as	equal comparison	"He is as tall as his brother."
Not so + adj + as / not as + adj + as	unequal (lesser)	"He is not so tall as his brother."

Conversion drill: "He is too weak to walk" = "He is **so weak that** he cannot walk." (Both formulas express the same idea — the test often asks you to choose the equivalent sentence.)

G.3 "Wish" + tense formulas

Use	Formula	Example
Wish for present (unreal, opposite of true)	S + wish + (that) + S + V2 / were	"I wish I were taller." (<i>I am not tall</i>)
Wish for past (regret)	S + wish + (that) + S + had + V3	"I wish I had studied harder." (<i>I didn't study</i>)
Wish for future (annoyance / a change)	S + wish + (that) + S + would + V1	"I wish you would stop talking."
If only ... (stronger version of wish)	same forms as above with "If only"	" If only I had known earlier!"

G.4 Inversion patterns (formal, frequent)

When a negative / restrictive adverbial starts a sentence, the auxiliary inverts before the subject (like a question).

Opener	Formula	Example
Never	Never + aux + S + V	Never have I seen such a sight.
Rarely / Seldom	Rarely + aux + S + V	Rarely does he speak at meetings.
Hardly / Scarcely ... when	Hardly + had + S + V3 + when + S + V2	Hardly had I arrived when it began to rain.
No sooner ... than	No sooner + had + S + V3 + than + S + V2	No sooner had he left than it started snowing.
Not only ... but also	Not only + aux + S + V, but also + ...	Not only did he sing, but also danced.
Only after / by / when / then	Only after + clause + aux + S + V	Only after she left did I realise my mistake.
Under no circumstances / In no way	Under no circumstances + aux + S + V	Under no circumstances should you open the door.
Little + does/did + S + V	Little + aux + S + V	Little did he know the truth.
So + adj + be + S + that ...	So + adj + be + S + that	So beautiful was the painting that I bought it.

G.5 Gerund (V-ing) vs Infinitive (to + V1) — verb-list cards

Formula: V + V-ing (gerund-only) · V + to + V1 (infinitive-only) · V + either (same meaning) · V + either (different meaning — memorise!)

Table 1 — Gerund-only verbs (V + V-ing, never to + V1)

Verb	PYQ freq	Verb	PYQ freq
enjoy	★★★	avoid	★★★
finish	★★	postpone / delay	★★
suggest	★★	recommend	★★
mind	★★	miss	★★
deny	★★	admit	★★
consider	★★	practise	★★
dislike	★	imagine	★
risk	★	keep	★
stop (= give up)	★★★	regret (past action)	★★★

✓ "I enjoy **reading**." ✗ "I enjoy **to read**."

Table 2 — Infinitive-only verbs (V + to + V1, never V-ing)

Verb	PYQ freq	Verb	PYQ freq
want	★★★	decide	★★★
hope	★★	plan	★★
agree	★★	refuse	★★
promise	★★	expect	★★
manage	★★	fail	★★★
learn	★★	intend	★
choose	★	offer	★
pretend	★	threaten	★
prepare	★	afford	★★
seem / appear	★★★	wish	★★★

✓ "I want **to read**." ✗ "I want **reading**."

Table 3 — Both-form verbs (same meaning, interchangeable)

Verb	V-ing form	to + V1 form
begin / start	"It started raining ."	"It started to rain ."
continue	"He continued working ."	"He continued to work ."
like / love	"She likes singing ."	"She likes to sing ."
prefer / hate	"I prefer reading ."	"I prefer to read ."
cease	"The noise ceased disturbing us."	"The noise ceased to disturb us."

Table 4 — Both-form verbs (DIFFERENT meanings — PYQ gold ★★★)

Verb	+ Gerund (V-ing)	+ Infinitive (to V1)	Memory tip
stop	give up habit: " <i>stopped smoking</i> "	pause for: " <i>stopped to smoke</i> "	V-ing = end it ; to+V1 = pause for it
remember	recall past: " <i>remember meeting her</i> "	not forget future: " <i>remember to lock the door</i> "	V-ing = past ; to+V1 = future

Verb	+ Gerund (V-ing)	+ Infinitive (to V1)	Memory tip
forget	fail to recall: " <i>forget meeting him</i> "	fail to do: " <i>forgot to call</i> "	V-ing = memory gap ; to+V1 = action gap
regret	sorry about past: " <i>regret saying that</i> "	sorry to inform: " <i>regret to inform you</i> "	V-ing = past sorrow ; to+V1 = formality
try	experiment: " <i>try opening the window</i> "	make effort: " <i>try to open the window</i> "	V-ing = experiment ; to+V1 = effort
mean	entail: " <i>success means working hard</i> "	intend: " <i>I meant to call</i> "	V-ing = entails ; to+V1 = intend
need	passive sense: " <i>the car needs washing</i> "	obligation: " <i>I need to wash</i> "	V-ing = thing-focused ; to+V1 = person-focused

G.6 Modal verbs — usage formula card

Modal	Formula	Use	Example
can / could	modal + V1	ability, permission, possibility	"She can swim."
may / might	modal + V1	permission, weak possibility	"It may rain tonight."
shall / will	modal + V1	future, intention, offer (shall = 1st person formal)	"I shall go."
should / ought to	modal + V1	advice / moral obligation	"You should rest."
must / have to	modal + V1	strong obligation, deduction	"You must report by 10 AM."
need not / don't have to	needn't + V1	absence of obligation	"You need not come."
used to + V1	habitual past (no longer true, stronger: implies it has stopped)	"She used to live in Delhi."	
would + V1	habitual past action (repeated, nostalgic — does NOT imply it has stopped)	"Every summer, we would visit our grandparents."	
would rather + V1 (than V1)	preference	"I'd rather walk than drive."	
had better + V1	strong advice / warning	"You'd better hurry."	
dare not / dare to + V1	rare; courage	"He dare not cross her."	

G.7 Subject-verb agreement formula card (all 15 golden rules)

#	Subject type	Formula	Example
1	Each / Every / Either / Neither / Many a / More than one	always singular verb	" Each of the boys has a bag." / " More than one student was absent."
2	One of the + plural noun + who/that	verb after who/that is plural	"He is one of the boys who play well." (plays X)
3	A number of + plural noun	plural verb ("a number of" = many)	" A number of students are absent."
4	The number of + plural noun	singular verb ("the number of" = a count)	" The number of students is rising."
5	Either / Neither + A or/nor + B	verb matches B (closer noun)	" Neither he nor they were present."
6	A + along with / as well as / besides / together with + B	verb agrees with A (parenthetical ignored)	"The captain, as well as his teammates, is ready."
7	Distance / time / money / weight as a unit	singular verb	" Ten kilometres is a long walk." / " Five hundred rupees is enough."

#	Subject type	Formula	Example
8	Mathematical / academic subjects ending in -s (physics, maths, economics, civics, politics)	singular verb	" Mathematics is my favourite subject."
9	Trousers / scissors / spectacles / goods / wages / premises / cattle / police	always plural verb	"His trousers are torn."
10	Bread and butter / horse and carriage / rice and curry (single dish/unit treated as one)	singular verb	" Bread and butter is my breakfast."
11	The + adjective (group of people)	plural verb	" The poor are suffering."
12	Collective noun (team, jury, family, committee, audience)	singular when acting as one unit; plural when members act individually	"The jury has decided." / "The jury are divided."
13	There / Here + be ...	verb agrees with the real subject after "there/here"	" There are five books on the table."
14	Indefinite pronouns (everyone, someone, nobody, anybody, everything, nothing, each)	always singular verb and singular pronoun	" Everyone has done his work."
15	"None"	singular with uncountable noun; plural accepted with countable; SSC prefers singular when ambiguous	" None of the water was wasted." / " None of the students were present." (accepted)
16	Titles of books / films / organisations (even if plural-looking)	treated as singular	" The Arabian Nights is a classic."
17	Percentage / proportion / majority / fraction of	verb agrees with the noun after "of"	"A percentage of the work has been done." / "A percentage of the students have passed."

G.8 "Subject + verb form" cheat — all aspects in one line

Remember just these auxiliary fragments and you can build any tense / voice / speech form:

Tense slot	Aux fragment	Main verb
Simple Present	— (or do/does for neg/Q)	V1 / V1+s
Simple Past	— (or did for neg/Q)	V2
Simple Future	will / shall	V1
Present Continuous	is / am / are	V1+ing
Past Continuous	was / were	V1+ing
Future Continuous	will be	V1+ing
Present Perfect	has / have	V3
Past Perfect	had	V3
Future Perfect	will have	V3
Present Perfect Continuous	has been / have been	V1+ing
Past Perfect Continuous	had been	V1+ing
Future Perfect Continuous	will have been	V1+ing
Passive add-on	+ be / being / been	V3

One-line takeaway: every English verb form is one of the 12 aux-fragments above + a verb in V1/V2/V3/V-ing. Memorise the 12 fragments and the entire tense + voice + speech system unlocks.

End of formula reference. Treat APPENDIX G as your single-page cheat for error spotting during the final 7-day revision before any exam.